Leap of Faith

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44250982.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Major Character Death

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

Something twitched in Catra's expression. She stepped back, claws still flexing. "Then *who are you*?"

Adora rubbed her throat, stepping back as well. "My name's Adora."

"Bullshit," Catra spat. "Adora's *dead*."

Oh. *Oh.* Adora swallowed, staring at her for a long moment. "So is Catra," she said finally in a low voice.

The universe is cruel - Adora and Catra, in their own worlds, lose their counterparts.

The multiverse is worse - it drops Adora in Catra's lap, and now they have to work together to get her home without killing each other, and figure out how she got there in the first place. Great. Perfect. No big deal.

(Spoiler Alert: it's a very big deal.)

Notes

OKAY LISTEN, this is. A lot. Both words and in feelings. My brain to the Spiderverse hyperfixation reared its ugly head and then my brain started turning and then I wrote 26,000 words of just...Feelings. I need y'all to trust me, okay? If you're an older reader, you know I always promise a happy ending. If you're new, just trust me, okay? I'm posting chapter one and two together because they need to be read together.

Sunflower

Adora Gray was sixteen when she was bitten by the radioactive spider.

Weaver had kicked the kids out for the day and Catra had a genius idea – tagging. She'd recently gotten into spray painting, and was really, really good at it. There was just one obvious problem, as Adora pointed out. It was the middle of the day.

"Oh, Adora." Catra slung one arm over her shoulders, grinning. "You're thinking too small. We're not tagging city walls. We're going *deeper*."

Deeper, it turned out, was an abandoned subway tunnel. "Look at all this free real estate!" Catra cheered, dancing ahead of Adora and swinging her flashlight around. Adora smiled. She loved seeing Catra so happy. It was a rare occurrence, and who was she to deny her best friend?

Well, girlfriend. Maybe. They were working on it. They'd kissed once or twice, under the cover of night and a blanket, and Adora was definitely planning a first date.

"What're you gonna do?" Adora asked as they finally stopped in front of an empty wall. Catra dropped her bag, bending down to grab a can and twirling it like a showoff.

"What am I going to do? I'm going to make *art*."

She was so dramatic.

They spent hours down there, Catra deeply absorbed in her work. Adora helped where she could, but that was mostly giving Catra a boost to reach places she wouldn't be able to otherwise at her oh so small height. It took Adora longer than she cared to admit to realize what Catra was drawing.

"Y our great masterpiece is *ely Adora?* "

"ely Adora done *art tscal l y*," Catra corrected with a grin. "Look at this beauty."

t *was* nice. The bubble letters were written in black spray paint, with a rainbow of colors exploding outward like ripples. The writing was messy, but perfectly legible —somehow a reflection of Catra herself. The fact that she could work like this was also incredible.

She finished with her tag (a cartoonish rendering of her own face in the corner) and stepped back to admire her work as a whole.

"Art."

"Theyll put it in a museum one day ," Adora teased, nudging Catra with her shoulder.

"I call it A T ribute to a Dork."

"Rude!"

Adora grabbed Catra, holding her in a pretend headlock. She squealed, pretending to struggle to get free, but she didnt move away when Adora let go;instead, she kissed her . Talk about playing dirty.

"W ow," Adora murmured, her lips moving against Catra' s.

"Dont ruin it." Catra stepped back for real this time, getting her phone out. "Come on, a picture for prosperity ."

"What if W eaver checks your phone?"

"I send them to myself in an email and erase them." Catra tugged Adora closer, angling the camera so it would catch them and the *ely Adora* in the background. "Say cheese."

Later, Adora would realize this was the last normal moment in her entire life. And she hadn't appreciated it nearly enough at the time.

"Ow!"

Catra swung her back over her shoulder, frowning. "What's wrong?"

Adora held the back of her hand up to her face, examining it. "Something bit me. Ew, gross!" She waved her hand, slapping at it. "It's a spider!"

"What, the *great* Adora is afraid of spiders?"

"I'm not *afraid*. We're in an abandoned subway tunnel and a spider just *bit me*. That's reasonable to be concerned about!"

Catra grabbed her hand, examining it critically. "Well, looks like it's gone." She kissed the wound for good measure. "Let's go."

Adora glared half-heartedly after her. Damn it, that was smooth. Where did she get off being so smooth?

The first incident occurred the next morning. They were on their way to school (alone, blessedly), laughing and pushing each other when Adora pressed her hand against Catra's shoulder. She felt a slight shock of static, then Catra was being thrown back, hitting the ground with a sickening thud.

"Catra!"

Adora slid to her knees next to Catra, trying to help her up, but Catra waved her off and sat up. "What the *fuck*, Adora?"

"I don't know, I'm so sorry. I don't know what happened." Adora patted her hair – then froze. Catra scowled at her, trying to pull away.

"Let go."

"Um"…

"Adora *I etgo*."

"I cant."

"What do you mean you *cant*?"

Adora tugged her hand experimentally, but it was stuck. Like glue. She'd gotten glue in Catra's fur once when they were younger. Catra hadn't been happy about it. Oh god, she was going to *murder* Adora in her sleep.

"Okay, don't freak out"—

"Adora Elizabeth Gray if you don't let go of my hair *right now*"—

"I *swear* I'm trying. It's stuck." She pulled again, harder, and Catra yelped. "Sorry!" She jerked her arm back on reflex, and Catra yelped again. "Sorry!"

"Stop moving!"

"Right, right." Adora tried to take a deep breath and steady herself. "Okay. I just don't have a good angle!"

She *carefully* stood, pressed her other hand against the top of Catra's head, and *pulled*. Nothing, except for another shriek from Catra. "Or not." She tried to pull her other hand away. It stuck. "Uh oh."

"*Uh oh*?" Catra's voice cracked. "What *uh oh*? I don't want to hear *uh oh* from the person who has a hand stuck to my head!"

"Uh. Two now."

"*What*?"

"It's fine!" Adora said quickly. "I can fix this!"

It turned out she could not, in fact, fix this. A sympathetic, though somewhat bewildered neighbor found them in the middle of the sidewalk, still struggling, and offered them a ride home.

Weaver was too baffled to be pissed they weren't at school. "What on *earth*."

"Um." Adora tried to smile. It wasn't working. "Incident with a glue gun?"

One hour, a lot of cursing, and a razor shave later, Adora was free. But the cost was high.

"Well, Catra," Weaver drawled, looking her charge over. "I must say, this *does* take care of your hair problem."

Luckily, she turned away before she saw Catra's claws pop out. Adora quickly grabbed her wrist to keep her from slashing. Then blanched when it took a second too long to let go.

"Don't. Touch me. Ever. Again."

They left for school. Again. Adora picked Catra's hair off her hands. Catra, understandably, kept her distance.

"Uh. School's that way," Adora said when they reached the intersection and Catra turned in the wrong direction.

"We're not going to fucking school, Adora!"

"Oh. Right."

They ended up at any empty park. Adora just stood, afraid to touch anything, while Catra paced and ruffled her hair. "What the fuck?" she finally said, whirling to glare at Adora.

"I don't know! I really, really don't know. My hands just. They got stuck. Like they were coated in glue."

"*bw* ? And also what was with that shock?" Oh, right. Adora had forgotten that in all the ensuing chaos.

"Um. static electricity?"

Catra slapped her hand against her face, shaking her head. "Jesus Christ."

She walked over to Adora, grabbed her hand, and stuck two fingers against her palm. Nothing happened. She pulled away , and looked relieved when she could escape. She tried again with one finger. It stuck.

"Oh no."

"This one' s your fault!" Adora said quickly , trying to pull her hand away. It didn't work, of course.

"Stop, stop! Just relax for a minute. I have an idea." Now Catra had an *i dea* was beyond Adora, but she was desperate. "Okay , close your eyes. Try to relax."

"Catra—"

"Adora if you ever want me to hold your hand again, *l i ste n* ." Adora quickly closed her eyes and took a deep breath. "That doesn't count. Do it again. A deep, slow breath." She took another breath, slower this time, as deep as she could. "Okay , let it out. Relax your shoulders. Relax your arms. T ry to breathe out the tension."

That part wasn't as easy , but Adora's shoulders fell after a moment, her arms going limp. And Catra was able to pull her finger away. Adora opened her eyes, blinking.

"Whoa." She reached out to touch Catra, who grabbed her wrist and angled it *away*.

"Uh, no. W e're not there yet."

"Right. Sorry . . . How did you know that would work?"

"I didn't." Catra pulled Adora's hand closer to her face, examining it. "It's just a thought I had. Remember when I was little and I couldn't control my claws? I thought maybe it was something like that. They always came out when I was stressed. It was a defense mechanism."

"Yeah but—" Adora winced as Catra twisted her arm to look at the back of her hand. "Humans don't usually *stick* to other things."

"Usually," Catra agreed. "But maybe…"

She tapped the back of Adora's hand. Adora looked at the spot; it was the spider bite. "Are you kidding?"

"Do you have a *better* idea?" Catra took a step back. "Try and do the electric thing again. *Not* on me." Adora looked around, considering, then reached for the swingset. "Not on a metal bar, either! Are you *trying* to die?!"

"Well, what then?"

"I don't know! A tree?"

It turned out her target didn't matter, because she couldn't make it happen again. Catra even tried jump-scaring her to get a response, but nothing.

"You seem weirdly responsive," Catra said, watching the way Adora's eyes flicked around to follow her. She took a closed fist swing at Adora, who raised a hand to block it almost without thinking. "Yeah, something is definitely going on."

"*What*, do you think I was bitten by a magical spider?"

"Or a radioactive one. What do I know?" Catra shrugged.

"That's insane. You know that's insane, right?"

"Give me a better explanation, then."

She couldn't. That was the problem. Adora had absolutely no way of disputing this, because it made sense. In a way. In a twisted way that made no sense at all.

"So what now?"

A spark twinkled in Catra's eyes. "Now we have some fun."

That wasn't *quite* the start of Adora's Spider Woman career, but it definitely marked a turning point in her life. There was no one who could teach her how to live with sudden spider powers, and *telling* someone just felt wrong. The best they could do was Catra, who had lived with heightened senses her entire life. Adora still wasn't close to her level, but her spacial awareness was far better, and her night vision had improved significantly.

"It's really interesting," Catra said as she circled Adora. It was late. They'd snuck out of the house again and gone to the park. "It's like… something's alerting you when I move. You can't always track my movement, but you know I'm moving."

They hadn't managed to recreate the electricity incident, but Adora *had* discovered another power. "It's not really invisibility." Catra was squinting at Adora. "Human eyes would probably fall for it though. It's more like… camouflage. Can you turn it off?"

"No."

"Well, that's a shame. I guess I'm the only one who will ever see you again."

It eventually turned off on its own. They put it on the list of things to play with.

The best thing, by far, was Adora's heightened strength and agility. Catra was still faster than her, but Adora could keep pace far more easily, and she still wasn't sure what her strength limit was. They'd gone to the junkyard to throw some things around and practice, and she'd managed to lift a *car*.

None of this helped Adora in school, of course, especially not when she was already easily distracted. But she found herself caring less and less about that, and dreaming more about what she could do. What *they* could do. They could escape. They didn't need to worry about being safe anymore. Adora could protect Catra and herself easily. They'd probably be homeless when Weaver kicked them out, but at least she could take care of them. Catra had dreams to go to college. She wanted to be a doctor, but knew that was out of the realm of possibility without full-ride scholarships. Maybe Adora could work. They could get a place together. A cheap place, but a place. Adora could basically do anything now, except pass eleventh grade algebra. Heavy lifting, dangerous jobs, long hours? She could do it.

They could have a life.

"Hey, check this out."

Adora looked up to see Catra leaning over the top bunk to look down at her, holding out her sketchbook. It was rare of her to actually show Adora anything she drew.

"What is it?"

"Just a little something I designed for you."

It was a suit. A full, one-piece suit with a hood and a small cape with a red lining. The top half was white, the bottom half black, and there were golden accents around the feet.

"Did you make me a superhero outfit?"

I *designed* you a superhero outfit. You're welcome."

It *was* pretty cool. Adora could see herself in it. She looked at the drawing, then Catra, who was smiling proudly.

"I like it. Now if only we had a friend who could sow . And a need for a superhero."

"The world *always* needs a superhero, Adora. Even if they don't realize it yet."

That should have been the end of it. Could have been the end of it. Adora desperately wished that was the end of it.

"So you know Scorpia?"

Adora looked over her shoulder at Catra, who was swinging back and forth idly. The playground had become their training ground of sorts. Big, exoskeleton, red?"

"Yeah, her. She said there's a gang in Bright Moon that's blackmailing students."

"*Catra* —"

"Seriously , hear me out," Catra said quickly . "They'll hire kids to do *errands* that are actually like, running drugs or whatever, then threaten them unless they keep working. It's pretty shitty."

It *was* shitty. Adora sighed, scrubbing her forehead. "Okay . So what are you suggesting?"

Catra shrugged. "Maybe we could check it out? I can be bait. We both know if they're going to target someone it'd be me."

Adora *definitely* didn't like that. "We'll spend a few nights downtown and see if we can find something. Deal?"

"Deal."

At least she had agreed. Adora turned back to the tree, frowning. Possibly putting Catra on a gang's radar was a terrifying thought. If asked, Catra would say she didn't need to be protected, and yeah, she could take care of herself. But Adora *wanted* to protect her. The world had already been so terrible to them. They both deserved better.

Something sparked in Adora's right hand.

She looked down, bewildered, then gasped. "What?" Catra asked, straightening up. Adora held up her hand, then slammed her palm into the tree trunk. And the tree exploded as electricity ran through it. Catra rocketed off the swing, wide-eyed. "Holy *shit*."

Yeah. They could handle this.

It didn't take long to find signs of a gang. They spent two nights downtown, and on the second night managed to over here a guy saying, "You kids looking for a job?"

Adora camo-ed to get closer, hood pulled over her head, while Catra perched herself on a nearby roof as backup.

There were two guys, standing over two boys Adora vaguely recognized from school. "What kind of job?" one of them asked suspiciously.

"The kind where you get money, obviously."

"What would we have to do?"

"Just run a few deliveries across town. Nothing too heavy. They'll fit in your bags."

Adora looked up at Catra, who had narrowed her eyes in disgust. She was definitely about to claw their faces off. Adora waved to get her attention, furiously shaking her head. This was *not* a fight they could do, not now. Besides, they had the information they were looking for. That was a start.

"You're *late*."

Adora peeked down the stairs to see Catra standing in the front door, kicking lightly at the floor, not looking at Weaver.

"I was working on a school project."

"You missed curfew. I don't want to hear your excuses."

"Okay, whatever." Catra tried to shoulder around Weaver, but she grabbed Catra by the arm, yanking her back. "Hey!—"

Adora was halfway down the stairs, already camouflaged, but paused when she heard Weaver hiss, "Do not test me, Catra. If it weren't for Adora's ridiculous attachment to you, you'd be spending your night in very *different* places. But her good graces won't save you forever if your attitude doesn't change."

Catra's eyes flicked to the stairs, fixing on Adora. She shook her head slightly, just once, then focused on Weaver. "I'm sorry," she said in the flattest, most insincere tone she manage. Weaver glared at her for a minute before letting her go.

"Get out of my sight."

Adora hurried back to their shared bedroom, waiting for Catra to run in and shut the door. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I'm fine. Fuck her. Check this out." Catra sat on the bottom bunk with her bag in her lap. She unzipped it and pulled out…

"What. What is that?"

Catra looked quite smug and pleased. "I got someone to help me with your suit. Try it on. I had to guess at measurements but I like to think I know you."

"Who?"

"Try it on and I'll tell you."

It fit well. The fabric was tight, but still breathed, and Adora didn't feel trapped. She looked herself up and down in mild surprise. "Whoa."

"I asked Entrapta for help with a few things." Catra was digging around in her bag as she spoke. "She promised not to tell anyone, and if you become a superhero, she'll abide by the sidekick law of never telling anyone your secret identity."

"Is that a thing?"

"I dunno, but I trust her. Look at *this*." She produced what looked like two golden wristlets, pointed one at the wall, and pushed a button. A long, thick stream of web shot out of it, hitting plaster hard enough to crack it. Catra made a show of cutting through it.

"Are those"…

"Web shooters." Catra sounded practically gleeful. "They were Entrapta's idea, but I did the design."

"Is. Is that going to come off the wall?"

"No clue." Catra grabbed Adora's wrist and dragged her closer to attach one of the wristlets. "But you know what I do know? You're going to be an *awesome* superhero."

And she was. For a bit.

For nearly a year, she lived up to that expectation, to the standard Catra had set. The Bright Moon police weren't happy about a masked, spider-themed vigilante, but they were never fast enough to catch her, either. Or to stop all the crimes she stopped. So really, they should've thanked her.

That didn't mean she was perfect. She fumbled. She messed up. Catra did chores around the neighborhood to earn money (since Weaver sure as hell didn't give her any allowance), and used it to buy and stash a fancy first-aid kit in their bedroom.

"You're such an idiot," Catra said one night as she probed some bruised ribs and patched Adora up. "Again."

"Hey, this is all practice for when you go to medical school. You're welcome."

Catra met Adora's gaze, half smiling and half rolling her eyes. It was the kind of expression Adora lived and breathed for. The kind she loved. The kind she would've fought for forever.

They were only seventeen. They didn't know any better.

"I *knew it*," Catra hissed. Adora shushed her, shoving her shoulder. "I knew that bitch was up to something!"

"Catra, shush."

There was absolutely no way Weaver could hear them from their perch, roughly six stories up from the door she was walking to, but better safe than sorry. "I bet she's been selling kids to the Horde," Catra whispered. "There were other kids around our age at one time, weren't there?"

"I think so?" Adora said slowly. "Do you really think she sold them to the Horde, though?"

"They use kids to run their packages around, she has access to foster kids nobody will miss. It's a win-win situation for her."

Adora sighed, pulling her mask down. "I'm going to try and get closer. Stay *here*."

She camo-ed and jumped off the building, landing on a street light. The apartment complex the Horde occupied was large or overly complicated, and more importantly, it didn't have air conditioning. That drove everyone to leave their windows open during the summer. Even Hordak.

"That spider brat cost me two more good men," he was snapping at Weaver as Adora climbed up to his window. "And street recruitment is down. When are you going to get more kids?"

"It's not that simple, sir," Weaver replied silkily. "I've only the two girls now. You can have Catra as soon as she turns eighteen, unless she gives me a reason to throw her out sooner—"

A loud *bang* rattled the window frame. "I don't have *time* for your games, Weaver. If we don't start showing a turnaround now, it'll be our necks on the line next."

Adora scowled, clenching her jaw tight. Hordak's words caused a moment of pause, however; was *he* reporting to someone else? Who?

Wait. One thing at a time. Weaver was definitely supplying the Horde with kids. That was bad. Even if she hadn't done it in years, it clearly wasn't for a lack of desire. Just lack of children.

"You know I'll be in trouble if too many go missing at one time. If I lose my license, we're both out of luck."

Translation: Adora had to find a way to stop this *now*.

"Okay , you were right," Adora said as she hopped back onto the roof to join Catra. "W eaver's totally been selling kids to the H orde. And it sounds like H ordak has someone over his head."

"I knew it," Catra said with a snort. "N o way he runs this entire thing on his own. I mean, how did they af ford to buy an entire freaking apartment building?"

"Y eah, yeah, you're a genius," Adora said, rolling her eyes. "Congratulations on being right again."

"What can I say , I'm a genius." Catra smirked, leaning in to kiss Adora. "Y ou just keep being the brawns. I got brains covered."

She stood, humming to herself as she walked to the fire escape and made her way down. Adora rolled her eyes, getting a running to jump to the nex t building. She liked using the web shooter to get up high and have a good view of everything going on. Unfortunately, it put her out of earshot sometimes.

"I said I'm not interested."

Adora landed on a streetlight and froz e at the sound of Catra' s voice. "Come on, sweetie—"

"Do *not* call me that—"

"Someone like you must need a couple ex tra bucks."

There. They were standing on empty sidewalk, two guys easily twice Catra's siz e hovering over her , trying to use their height to look menacing. Adora shot a strand of web at one of them; it plastered against his leg, and he yelled when Adora yanked the web, pulling his legs out from beneath him. Catra took advantage of the distraction to swipe at the other guy, tearing right through his arm. N ot a fatal injury , but certainly a painful one. Adora shot another web off and swung in to glide alongside Catra as she ran.

"Show of f," Catra called breathlessly .

"Are you okay?"

"Of course I am"—

The shot rang in Adora's head a split second before the gun actually went off. Catra yelled in surprise, diverting to the side and stumbling slightly to avoid it. Adora skidded to a halt, whirling around. Where? The two who had confronted Catra were still down. They must have had backup. A third guy watching in case things get wrong. Spider Woman *di d* tend to crash in on them a lot of the time—

Another shot. Adora finally managed to orient herself, shooting off a blind string of web, but it did its job of hitting the shooter right in the middle of his forehead with enough force to take him down. That had been close, she thought, breathing heavily. That had been way too—

"Hey. Adora?"

The weak words were followed by a groan, and then a thud as Catra's small (frail) body hit the ground.

"*No* !"

There was blood — *so much blood* . Adora ripped the cape off her back without a second thought, pressing it against Catra's stomach. It was immediately soaked in red. Blood. *Catra's blood* . Catra let a small, pained whine. "I know , I know , I'm sorry . I'm so sorry . It's okay. You're going to be okay ." There were sirens in the distance. Someone must have called the police. "Hear that? An ambulance is coming, you'll be fine."

But Catra was shaking her head. Why? There was nothing to shake her head about. Everything would be fine. "It's okay . Hey ." Slim fingers wrapped around her wrist, squeezing tight. "It's okay , Adora. Really."

"I know it's okay. You're fine. You're going to be fine."

It was a suspended moment in time, where Adora could live in her denial. Catra was watching her with a sad, half-smile, the sirens were still off in the distance, and there was no else near them.

"Can you—" Catra's hand tried to climb up Adora's arm, but it fell weakly. Adora spared one hand to yank her mask over her face, meeting Catra's gaze. She let out an almost content sigh. "You're amazing. You know that, right? Even without the freaky spider powers. You're an amazing person."

"Catra—"

"No, shush." Catra winced, and coughed. It was a terrible, rattling noise that didn't have nearly air in it. "My turn. I... I love you. I love you, and you're amazing, and I can't... can't really think right now. But you get where I'm going with this, right?"

Adora nodded, tears rolling slowly down her cheeks. "I love you too," she whispered. Catra's eyes fluttered shut.

"Cool," she breathed. "Was really hoping you weren't going to leave me hanging."

She was gone by the time the police arrived. And so was Adora. But the three gang members had been tied up and left in the middle of the street, one with the gun quite literally attached to his head.

Adora felt numb as she crawled in through the bedroom window. Weaver's car wasn't in the driveway, but going through the window still felt safer. She pulled her mask off, letting it drop to the floor. The room was too quiet. Bits and pieces of Catra were scattered among it – her favorite hoody, the hem and sleeves frayed and worn. It had been Adora's once, but she wouldn't complain. Her colored pencils and art book were scattered around the desk. She didn't usually leave them out like that, but Weaver had left, and she'd felt safe. For once. Her blanket was on Adora's bed. She insisted Adora sleep with it after they did laundry so it would smell like her again. Adora

had teased her about it. Catra had said she was just jealous her sense of smell still sucked. There was still a bit of web on the wall that Weaver had somehow never seen from the first time Catra had shown Adora the web shooters.

"*You're going to be an* awesome *superhero.*"

Adora let out a strangled noise, driving her fist into the wall once, and then again, and again. She ripped the chair from the desk, throwing it across the room;it hit the wall and shattered. She wanted to rip off this stupid suit and *burn it*; she never wanted to see it again, she—

"*The world* always *needs a superhero, Adora. Even if they don't realize it yet*"

But Catra had worked so hard on it. And she had been *so confident* in Adora. She'd really made Adora feel like anything was possible. Even saving the world. Even though the world had been wrapped in her arms the entire time.

Weaver didn't come home that night. Adora didn't sleep. She had enough sense to change out of the suit and hide it in her bag, but beyond that, all she did was climb up to Catra's bunk and wrap herself in the blanket Catra would eventually give her when she took her own back. A social worker came very early the next morning. Adora really hadn't thought she'd have tears left by the time, but it turned out to be stunningly easy to cry when the woman gently told her the news.

A foster kid *dying* in someone's custody was always suspicious at best. A foster kid being shot in a well-known gang neighborhood while the caregiver was absent from the house overnight, leaving her *other* charge alone, was cause for investigation. The social worker ~~—a~~ woman named Castaspella ~~—did~~ her best to break everything kindly to Adora ~~—she~~ was being moved to another home across the

city, which meant she'd have to transfer schools, which *sucked* . The only high school on that side of town was the private school.

"The family is happy to pay your tuition," Castaspella assured her . "I know it's not ideal, but they're the people I trust most for emergency cases."

Is that what Adora was? An emergency case? She went back to packing, pausing when she looked in her bag and saw the suit. "What. What about Catra? I mean, her body ."

The question obviously made Castaspella uncomfortable. Good. Adora knew the answer, but she wanted to hear it. "Unclaimed bodies are usually buried in a private plot provided by the city."

"Can *I* claim her?"

"Can you afford a burial or cremation?" Adora didn't answer . Castaspella rested a hand on her arm. "I know this is hard. I'm sorry."

Adora shrugged her off. "You don't know anything."

Casta didn't say anything. They didn't speak again as she finished packing her meager belongings. Adora took Catra's blanket and pillow before they left.

The drive across town was punctuated by gentle attempts at conversation from Casta. Adora muttered one-word answers, staring out the window. She understood what the social worker was trying to do, but she didn't want to play the game. She just wanted to sleep. Forever.

"It's my brother and his family," Casta finally said as they pulled into the driveway. "They're good people, I promise."

Adora didn't really care. They could have locked her in a bedroom forever, and that would be just fine.

"Is there any chance I could move to another home closer to Bright Moon High before summer is over?" she asked as they parked in front of the large house. They had money. This was charity. She hated it.

Casta hesitated, looking back at her. "If you're really unhappy, we can look into it," she said slowly. "But this is a good chance for you. It's a better school, and a better home—"

"All of my friends are at Bright Moon High." She'd already lost the one person who mattered the most, but losing everything else was just the icing on the cake.

"I know. I'm sorry." To her credit, Casta actually did look sorry. "But Micah and Angella are good people. I think you'll be happy here."

Funny, she thought Adora would be happy again someday. She didn't say anything as she climbed out of the car, shouldering her backpack.

Micah and Angella and their daughter Glimmer probably *were* nice people. Adora didn't really pay attention beyond initial introductions. Casta stayed long enough to show her to the guest room with Micah, then had to hurry off to deal with the fallout of everything.

"Are you hungry?" Micah asked. Adora toed her shoes off, leaving them near the door.

"Just tired."

"Okay. Angie and I will be right downstairs, and Glimmer's room is next door if you need anything."

He closed the door behind him. Adora went to the bed and collapsed, drawing Catra's blanket over herself and curling up in a tight cocoon. She felt slightly disconnected from reality, like the idea that Catra was really gone just wouldn't settle. How was she supposed to live without her? It was *always* supposed to be the two

of them. Adora and Catra against the world. That had been the endgame.

What was the point now?

She must have fallen asleep at some point, because it was almost noon when someone knocked on the door, jarring her out of unconsciousness.

"Come in?" she called uncertainly, voice scratchy. It was Glimmer who peeked in; Adora resisted the urge to roll her eyes. She was exactly the kind of preppy rich girl Adora and Catra would laugh at when they went to the mall for people watching.

"Hey, Dad made lunch."

The unspoken invitation to come down and eat was there. Adora ignored it, rolling over. "Cool."

"Um... he made enough for you."

"I'm not hungry," Adora said flatly.

"You should probably still eat—"

"I don't *care*. Just leave me alone."

Glimmer huffed, but the door closed. Adora wasn't expecting that to be the end of it, and wasn't surprised when another person knocked a few moments later. She yanked the blanket over her head. "Go *away*."

"No can do," Micah said as he opened the door. "I gotta feed you. It's part of the whole foster parent thing."

Adora pressed her lips together tight, still glaring at the wall. She heard the desk chair move against the rug, presumably as Micah sat. "I'm not going to say I know what you're going through, because

Idont.”At least he wasnt an idiot. “And Iam really , truly sorry youve had to go through this. t’ s not fair.”

“Life isnt fair .”

“No, it isnt,”he agreed qietly . “And that’ s a lesson youve had to learn far too young. And Im sorry for that as well. Nothing Isay can make this better, or easier, but well do whatever we can to help, if you let us.”

There was nothing they could do, but Adora didnt want to say that. “Okay . Thanks.”

Micah sighed qietly . “There’ s a couple sandwiches here for you. Ill leave you be, but you should really eat.”

He left, qietly closing the door behind him. Adora sat up slowly , looking at the plate on the desk. Her stomach rumbled. W ell.Catra wouldnt want her to starve. She crawled out of bed to grab the plate, and started eating.

The nexcouple days went by in the same manner . Micah or Angella would bring her food, try to talk to her, but ultimately gave in, letting her go. They probably left it because she was eating, at least. At night she would sneak out to use the bathroom, and showered once. She slept in broken fits, dreaming of Catra and blood and gunshots and the light fading from amber and blue eyes…

Day three disrupted the routine when Castaspella returned, looking a little nervous.

“Hi, Adora. Do you think youre up to answering a few qestions?”

No. Adora dragged herself up, letting out a long breath. “Sure,”she muttered. Casta sat at the desk, a tablet ready to take notes. “What do you want to know?”

"Well, as you know, we're investigating Ms. Weaver for possible abuse of the system. Do you have any insight into that?"

Adora laughed bitterly, a sound utterly devoid of emotion. "Of course I do. She was a terrible person. She never touched me, but she'd slap Catra and shove her around whenever Catra annoyed her. Which was almost always."

Casta pressed her lips thin, but didn't say anything as she tapped out a few notes. "Did either of you ever try to report this to your social workers?"

"Sure." Adora shrugged. "But she never left bruises, and we had beds and food, so they didn't really care. They thought we were making it up for attention."

"I see." Casta took another note. "Did you try reporting it to teachers at school?"

"Once or twice. They didn't care either. We stopped bothering when we were ten."

"Were there other kids in the home with you at any point?"

"Yeah. I don't remember them very well, some of them were older than us. We thought they just aged out and left, or someone adopted them maybe." It had never struck Adora as odd that no one ever came around to look into adopting any of them. It was Catra who had eventually realized that this was where they sent kids no one wanted to bother with. She'd wondered more than once why *Adora* was there. "Did... did something happen to them?"

"What makes you think that?"

Adora was a shitty liar. She always had been. But Casta didn't know that. For all she knew, Adora was just really upset and having a hard time putting the story together. That wasn't entirely wrong, either. "Catra... thought there was something off about Weaver. One time,

Weaver told her that if she kept giving her attitude, she would find *other places* for Catra to spend her nights. We never understood what that meant. Or I never did, at least. Catra was smart. Maybe she put it together and I never realized."

Casta was quiet for a moment, taking notes and rereading them. Her expression was sad and a little hesitant. "Did anything seem off the night Catra died?"

Tears filled Adora's eyes. She swiped angrily at them, letting out a shuddering breath. "Weaver left before we went to bed. Catra was still there when I fell asleep. I don't know why she left."

They were silent for a moment while Adora sniffled, trying to get back under control. "It wasn't fair. None of this was fair. I'm so sorry," Casta said finally, quietly. "I really, truly am. Neither of you deserved this."

"But it's what we got," Adora said, gritting her teeth. "You just left us there to rot. What do you care *now*?"

"Because we're trying to fix it. I know it's too late for Catra, but we can make it so no one else ever has to go through this."

Yeah, it was too late for Catra. So why should Adora care? She felt bad the moment the thought crossed her mind. Of course she should care. No one else deserved to suffer just because they did.

"I don't know what else I can tell you," Adora admitted after a moment. "We didn't know anything."

"I believe you," Casta said. "Any details are helpful, really. We don't know what we're looking for, either."

Adora nodded. "I'll try to think if anything else stands out," she said.

"That's all I can ask."

There was a knock at the door. Adora rolled her eyes. "What?"

Glimmer poked her head in, giving her a small smile. "Hey. Mom and Dad are gone for the day, but they asked me to make sure you ate."

"I'm not hungry," Adora muttered, rolling over to stare at the wall. She heard Glimmer huff.

"Okay, but you should probably still eat, so." She let herself into the room; there was a clink as something was set on the desk. "I'm not leaving until you eat." Adora huffed back, rolling to glare at the smaller girl. She crossed her arms, staring back. It had been a week since Adora had come to stay here. Micah and Angella handled most interactions, because Glimmer had a bit of a short fuse, but she was clearly trying to smile and be patient.

"I made buns. They're nothing special, but my mom and I make them sometimes for comfort food. They're really good." She must have grabbed one to take a bite. "Mmmph. See? I promise, they're great. I bet you'll really like them."

"Do you not get what *I eave me al one* means?" Adora asked snippily, finally sitting up. Glimmer winced, then scowled.

"Yeah, I do, actually. I know you've gone through something terrible, and I'm sorry, I really am. But you're not alone. My parents want to help. *I* want to help, if you'll let me. I know it's hard to believe, but the entire world isn't out to get you."

"That's easy for you to say. When was the last time *you* had to worry about where your next meal was coming from?"

"Never," Glimmer admitted. "I'm not saying I know what you've gone through or that I understand, but if you need someone to talk to, I can listen."

"Sure. Okay."

Glimmer made an annoyed noise, turned, and walked out. Adora waited until she was sure the girl was gone, then sat up, looking at the steaming buns on the desk. She crawled to the end of the bed, carefully picking one up and taking a bite. It was surprisingly good. Catra might have liked it. The thought was like a punch in the gut, and Adora wasn't hungry anymore.

Adora did her best to keep avoiding Glimmer, because she didn't want to deal with her, and it should have been easy – the house was huge. Adora really only left her room at night. Part of her was still hoping she could get out of this house and back to the public school. There was still a week left before school started. It was possible. Maybe they would realize how miserable she was and let her leave.

She was starting to recognize the knocks on her door. It was Micah this time, with a quick and heavy beat. "Come in," Adora called listlessly. Micah peeked in, giving her a smile.

"Up and at 'em, kiddo. We gotta do some school shopping for you."

"I don't need anything," Adora said, looking at the ceiling. She had a bag. She had notebooks. What else was there?

"Well, we need to get you a school uniform. And a new bag might be good. Unless you want to let Glimmer pick stuff out for you."

Adora shuddered at the thought. No, no she did *not*. "Fine," she muttered, rolling out of bed and going to get her shoes on. Micah looked pleased with himself.

Their first stop was the school uniform store, which was unbearable. The first thing Adora noticed was that absolutely nothing was hybrid friendly. Of course not. Bright Moon Academy was too *good* for hybrids. The store worker started steering them toward the girl section, and Adora planted her feet against the ground, refusing to move.

"I don't do skirts," she said firmly.

"That's fine," Micah said before the worker could argue. "The rules aren't that strict."

It was a small win, but it was a win.

They left half an hour later, after buying more clothing than Adora had spent on clothes in her entire life. Shirts, pants, uniform jackets, shoes... it was all too much. And they weren't even done yet.

Glimmer took over with helping when they got to the store, leading Adora to the backpacks. Everything felt so garish and overly decorated and *stupid*. "Are there any requirements for school?" Adora asked when there was a break Glimmer's chattering.

"Not really," Glimmer said, looking a bit put out. Adora scanned the bags again, finally finding a plain black one and grabbing it.

"There. Can we go?"

"Still need school supplies," Micah said cheerfully, steering her toward that section next. Adora bit down a groan.

She managed to buy a bunch of plain notebooks and binders and regular pens and pencils. "We've got your school schedule, too," Micah said as they got into the car to head home. "Glimmer is happy to help you get things sorted out, right sweetie?"

"Absolutely."

And that was how Adora ended up with Glimmer in her room, going over her school schedule and assigning notebooks and binders accordingly. It was dangerously close to the way Catra had always helped her get organized before school started, albeit with far fewer supplies. It hurt to see Glimmer sitting where Catra should have been.

"Look, I really don't care about any of this," Adora finally snapped. "Can you just go away?"

Glimmer blinked, surprised, before scowling faintly. "I'm trying to help."

"I don't *want* your help. I don't want to go to this stupid school. I don't *care*. Leave me alone."

Adora could tell she'd lit the *very* short fuse in Glimmer's temper. "Look, I get that you're upset, and there's no way I could ever know what you're going through, but you don't have to take it out on me."

"I wouldn't say anything if you stopped trying to butt in." Adora pushed herself up, going to sit on her bed. "If you want to help, convince your aunt to send me literally anywhere else."

"What, would you rather go back to a shitty home?" Glimmer asked, standing and throwing her arms up. "Is being worried that you're going to be *hot* somehow better?"

"We were *fine*!" Adora snapped back, standing as well. She was at least a head taller than Glimmer, although Glimmer's temper more than made up for the height difference. "We had each other, and everything was fine—"

"Until *one of you* ran off alone!"

The fragile thread of sanity snapped in Adora's head. She whirled, grabbing her *ol' d* bag and getting the mask out of it. She shoved it into Glimmer's chest hard enough to push her back a couple steps.

"She wasn't alone! She was there because of *me*, okay? It's my fault!"

Glimmer blinked a few times, staring dumbly at the mask. "Girls?" Micah called from the hallway. They looked around to see him

pushing the door open. Glimmer adjusted her hand slightly to hide the mask without looking suspicious. "What's going on?"

"Nothing," Adora said, voice thick with tears. Micah looked at Glimmer, who shook her head.

"I said something stupid. I'm sorry." She *did* actually sound regretful. Micah looked between them, frowning.

"Maybe you should take a break."

"Yeah," Glimmer agreed. "I'll get my stuff and get out, one second."

Micah, blessedly, didn't feel the need to supervise. Glimmer handed the mask silently back to Adora, kneeling to gather her own things in silence. Adora watched, momentarily stunned.

"Are... Are you going to tell them?"

"No." Glimmer threw her bag over her shoulder and stood. "We can talk when they're not home."

She left. Adora collapsed back onto the bed, shaking, and looked at the mask in her hands. She hadn't even thought about the suit since that night. She'd never planned on even looking at it again. What was the point? Catra was gone. *She* was the one who had believed in Adora.

And Adora had completely failed her.

Adora wasn't really expecting Glimmer to come talk to her, but sure enough, she was knocking on the door as soon as Micah and Angella were gone the next morning. "Yeah," Adora called without lifting her head from the pillow. She didn't want to have this conversation. She knew it was her own fault for showing Glimmer the mask, but anything was better than listening to Glimmer *blame Adora* for something that hadn't been her fault.

Glimmer stepped in, closing the door behind her. They just stared at each other for a long moment, for lack of anything else to do.

"Are you really?" Glimmer finally asked. Adora nodded. "What… What happened?"

It took Adora a moment to find her voice and speak. "We… Catra thought our guardian might have something to do with the Horde — the gang in that area. And she was right. We were there investigating, and someone caught us, and she…" Adora paused, blowing out a long, shuddering breath. "She was there to help *me*. But I can't *tell* anyone that."

"No," Glimmer agreed quietly. "I'm so sorry."

"Are you going to tell your parents?" Adora wasn't even sure what they would do in a situation like this. There wasn't really a foster home for people with weird powers.

"Of course not." The earnest denial baffled Adora. "How would kill me."

"How?"

"My boyfriend. He's a *real* big fan. If he knew Spider-Woman is living under my roof…" Glimmer giggled a little. "Anyway, he wouldn't stand for me betraying a superhero's secret identity. I guess it's a thing. But no, I won't tell. Besides it's none of my business."

Adora sat up, nodding. "Thanks."

"Yeah."

They fell silent again. "I'm really sorry," Glimmer repeated. "I didn't mean to…"

"You didn't know," Adora said. "It's fine."

t’ s not.”Glimmer kicked at the floor . “So have you been..sneaking out at night or anything? To do, Idont know , crime fighting stuff?”

Adora laughed humorlessly. “N. Ithink Im done with that whole life.”

“Why?”Glimmer asked, taking a step into the room.

“I mean..Ialready let down the one person who matters. What’ s the point?”

“W ell..people are still getting hurt, arent they?”Glimmer shrugged. “I dont want to encourage anything. Mom and Dad would *ki l* me if they knew. B t maybe she’d still want you to keep going? And be safe, of course.”

“*You’re goi ng t b be an* awesome *sp rhero.* ”

Catra had been the one who had believed in her. Catra had encouraged her. Catra had been her support through everything.

“*You’re ama zing. Y ou know that, ri ght? E n wi thout the f reaky p der p wers. Y ou’re an ama zing p rson.* ”

“I couldnt save Catra. H w am Isupposed to save anyone else?”

Glimmer shrugged. “I m not sure how any of this works,”she admitted. “B t..you never know until you try , right? And if you need help – n t that Im trying to replace her or anything, but Ican cover for you and stuff. Oh, and Ican do this.”

She disappeared in a shower of sparkles, reappearing nex to Adora. She jumped, surprised. “That’ s handy,”she said.

“I’ s pretty great. Inever miss curfew .”

There was a curfew? H h. Adora probably needed to get to know the house and its occupants a bit more. “I dont know .”She sighed,

sitting on the floor and crossing her legs under herself. Glimmer sat with her, elbows resting on her knees.

"It sounds like she was really important to you."

Adora nodded, reaching for her bag and taking out the mask. "She designed the suit, you know. It was a joke at first, but she really believed I could. I don't know . . . Make a difference, I guess."

"I don't think she was wrong," Glimmer said. "For whatever that's worth. Have you ever seen what people are saying about you online?" Adora shook her head. "You're inspiring. I mean, yeah, there are the losers who just want to make everyone feel bad, but there are more people saying how cool it is that someone is helping the people the police won't help, or are too slow to help. Bow's even talked about how *he* wants to be a superhero." Glimmer rolled her eyes, but she was smiling. Adora recognized that look. It was the same look Catra had always given her. "He wants to be the *Archer*. He likes to make trick arrows and stuff that don't actually hurt people, mostly, but they do a bunch of other things."

"He probably shouldn't do that."

"That's what I keep saying. He definitely can't do all the jumping and stuff that you can do. He hasn't started designing suits or anything yet, at least."

Glimmer laughed, and Adora was surprised to find herself smiling just a little. "Anyway, if Mom and Dad ask, we never had this conversation. I'd be grounded forever if they found out I encouraged you. But I think there's still some good you can do in the world. Or at least in Bright Moon. If you want."

She stood, heading out of the room. Adora watched her, then looked down at the mask in her hands. Catra would never abide by her *giving up*. She'd call her an idiot, then tell her to get up and keep going. Probably make a comment like, "Aaaaawwwww, do you *like* me? That's so embarrassing for you."

Adora smiled weakly, tears filling her eyes. Yeah. That sounded right.

Adora snuck out of the house under the cover of night, wearing the suit for the first time in weeks. It was a bit of a hike across town, and this was the easiest mode of transport. She camo-ed before slipping down into the subway station and making her way down the tunnel to the place where all of this had started.

No one had touched Catra's work. Adora pulled her mask off, tears filling her eyes. "Hey Catra," she whispered, letting out a shuddering breath. "I don't know what to do. I know what *you'd* tell me to do if you were here, but you're not. And that's the problem."

She slowly sank to sit on the ground, pulling her legs up to her chest and resting her chin on her knees. "I'm so sorry. I know you'd tell me not to apologize, but I'll let you down. And I don't know what to do anymore. I don't know if I can still do this. I couldn't be the hero *you* needed. How am I supposed to save anyone else?"

The empty room held no answers, but Adora still felt some comfort just sitting with Catra's art. Catra had given her the email and password for her secret photo stash, and Adora looked at every single one every chance she got. But seeing it in person was a surreal experience. It was proof that Catra had existed. She had been here, and she had left a mark in this world. She'd only been seventeen years old, and living the worst possible life, but she had found enjoyment in the world, in her own way. She had left parts of herself all over the city, and even in the very suit Adora was wearing. She had been so talented and so proud.

And Adora had been lucky to know her.

She was on her way home, fighting down tears, when she heard someone yelling. She landed on a roof, and immediately zeroed in on a man running down the street with a purse that definitely wasn't his. *Uh oh*.

A strand of web glued itself to the man's arm, yanking him back. "That doesn't really go with your outfit," Adora said, using another strand of web to grab the purse. "Maybe try buying your own purse next time."

The woman caught up, gasping for breath. "Spider-Woman?" she sounded shocked. Adora handed the purse over, smiling under the mask.

"The one and only." She attached the web holding the man to a light pole. "You should get somewhere safe and call the police. I would, but I don't have pockets for a cell phone. And they don't really like me."

The woman laughed shakily as Adora swung off into the night. That had felt... good. *So* felt good. Better than she had since the night Catra died.

She hadn't been able to save Catra. But did that *really* mean she couldn't save anyone else?

"Is... is he okay?"

Glimmer frowned, waving her hand in front of Bow's face. "I'm not sure. Bow? Booooooow?"

"You're... You're really... Spider-Woman?" he choked out. Adora nodded. "That's… *oh my gosh*. Wait, why are you telling me?"

"Well." Adora rubbed the back of her neck, shifting from foot to foot. "I told Glimmer. And I don't want her to have to lie to you. Especially to cover for me or something."

"Oh my gosh," Bow whispered again. He was clearly broken.

"Does this mean you're not quitting?" Glimmer asked. That snapped Bow out of his stupor.

"You were going to *quit*?! Why?!"

"It's a long story," Adora muttered. "And I'm not sure yet. I don't know if it's a good idea to keep going or if I should just leave it or…"

"But why?" Bow asked again. Glimmer tried to cover his mouth. Adora blew out a long breath through her nose, preparing herself for the short, painful version.

"My friend died because of all this Spider Woman stuff." Bow immediately snapped his mouth shut. "I don't know if I can keep doing it without her."

"Well, I know we're not your friend, but we'll help," Bow said. "Or I'll help, I don't speak for Glimmer."

"I will too!" Glimmer said quickly. Adora looked at both of them, surprised.

"*Why*?"

"Because we don't all have super powers, but we should still do whatever we can to help." Bow looked at Glimmer, grinning. "Right?"

"You just want an excuse to be a superhero," Glimmer teased.

"I mean…"

Bow waved his hand a little; Adora smiled despite herself. They weren't Catra. No one could be Catra, or replace her. But maybe Adora could still have friends. Maybe this could work. Maybe she could still be the hero Catra had imagined her to be. Maybe. It wouldn't hurt to try.

Adora tried.

It was hard. She wanted to give up more often than not. What was the point without Catra? All of this, even getting through school, had

been for her.

Bow and Glimmer were good. They quickly learned how to recognize Adora's depressive episodes, and learned different ways to cheer her up. Sometimes that was as simple as sitting with her until the episode passed.

Micah and Angella had been kind enough to buy a small plaque for Catra's grave, but Adora only went there once or twice. The idea of it made her feel sick. Instead, she went to the subway tunnel, wasting hours in front of the *Lily Adora* mural. It was as close as Adora ever came to having her back. She took Bow and Glimmer to see other things Catra had done – carefully explaining that *yes*, while it was graffiti, it was also art, and very important, and they withheld judgment. But she never brought them to the tunnel. That was a special thing. Something between them. Adora couldn't share it.

She *did* share her web shooters, which absolutely fascinated Bow, and she had to bring him to meet Entrapta. It turned out they knew each other in passing from the Bright Moon Makerspace, which was where they ended up going to see her.

"It's nice when he finds out someone else to talk nerd stuff about," Glimmer said, looking around the building. "He's probably going to try and incorporate the web stuff into his trick arrows."

"Is that safe?" Adora asked with a grimace.

"Probably?" Glimmer shrugged. "No one's ever gotten hurt. He has a small archery range set up in his backyard, and that's mostly where he practices. It should be fine."

Entrapta took the chance to look over Adora's web shooters and did a little tinkering. "Are you helping her with things now?" she asked Bow curiously.

"Yeah, sorta. The best we can."

"Do you want to learn how to take care of these? Catra knew enough for basic maintenance, but they really do need constant care."

Bow blinked, surprised, then looked at Adora as if to ask *can I?* She shrugged. "Sure." Her voice was thick with tears she was trying to stamp down. "If you want."

The casual mention of Catra had thrown her off. She turned, heading for the door, breathing as deeply as she could. Maybe someday it would get easier. But today was not that day.

Time marched on. And Adora marched with it.

She finished school. She went to college, because Catra would have wanted her to keep going. Bow and Glimmer helped, and the three of them even got an apartment off campus together since they were all going to Bright Moon University. Sometimes, Adora even felt okay. Sometimes she felt guilty for that, but it was okay to be happy. That was what the therapist told her, anyway. It was okay for her to be happy.

Being Spider Woman brought her some amount of peace. She felt good every time she helped someone or stopped a crime. Even better, she indirectly helped get Weaver and Hordak arrested. She swore she could *hear* Catra laughing as she sat on a roof, watching the cops handcuff Weaver and put her in the car.

It wasn't perfect, but it was a decent life.

"Yeah, I'm on my way home," Adora said, yawning. It was late. She'd been at a study group, because her only other choice was failing chemistry.

"*Great, what do you want for dinner?*" Bow asked cheerfully.

"Anything is good—"

She heard a yell from somewhere in the distance. "Second thought, I think I might be late. See you later ." She hung up, threw her phone in her bag, and hurried off. She liked what she did, but honestly, she needed to study. Criminals had no respect.

She pulled her mask on, stashed her bag and clothes behind a trash can where they'd hopefully be safe, and jumped onto the nearest wall to start climbing up the building. It was probably just a mugging, those weren't uncommon, or a couple of guys trying to get handsy with a girl. Either way, she'd put a stop to it, no—

Her hand went through the wall.

"What the—"

Adora looked, expecting to see a window or something, and was greeted with a mass of swirling purple and green energy. She yelped, trying to pull her arm back, but it seemed to drag her in the more she struggled. Like something had grabbed her hand on the other side and was trying to force her through.

"Let *go*! Let me go!"

But the portal tugged hard, and Adora lost her grip, tumbling head first into the mysterious energy.

Invincible

Chapter Summary

Let's do this again, one more time.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra Driluth was sixteen when she was bitten by the radioactive spider.

"Remember, I want best behavior," the teacher called over the din of excited students who were ready to get *off the bus* and see something cool. "Eternia Labs would be a fantastic interning opportunity for any of you. You're the best Bright Moon High has to offer. Act like it."

"The best and Adora," someone whispered to a friend, probably thinking they were out of the range of *certain* ears. A figure jolted out her seat four rows away, turning and storming back to the two boys.

"Wanna say that again?" she demanded. They shook their heads wordlessly.

"*Catra*," the teacher said firmly. Catra scowled, walking back to her seat.

"What'd they say?" Adora asked.

"They were just being assholes. Don't worry about it."

Bright Moon High School was far from being a top tier school. But every year they somehow produced a batch of students who were a little too smart for the school's resources to handle. These year's crop was...especially active. One of them had been deemed a

security risk to Eternia Labs and subsequently banned from the trip. Most of them had been in trouble at one point or another for experiments that resulted in fires and school evacuations and one notable time the bomb squad. Catra was one of the few who could say she had never abused school resources or broken in after hours to use equipment.

"Don't forget to pick up a visitor's badge in the lobby, and *behave* for the tour guide."

Adora grabbed a badge for herself and for Catra, shouldering her way back through the crowd and handing it over. "This place is massive," she said as she looked up at the high vaulted ceilings. "What do they even *do* here?"

"*Invent the future*," Catra said, waving her hands in a *razzle dazzle* sort of way. "They're every kid who's ever set the Chemistry classroom on fire with a budget and some cool toys."

"Is that why Entrapta wasn't allowed to come?"

"Partially. Mostly it's because they have a robotics lab and even she admitted she wouldn't be able to stay away."

A tour guide rounded them up, and off they went.

It wasn't that thrilling. The halls were white and sterile, with glass walls so they could take a look at what the different scientists were working on. Catra only half listened to the tour guide, although she was extremely interested in what was going on in the different labs. She wished she could get a little closer, but they were closed off for a reason. The teacher had already stopped a couple students from sneaking off to get a better look. Adora looked *painfully* bored. She'd only come because Catra had begged her; Entrapta hadn't been able to go, and coming alone would have been boring.

"Why are they so hush hush about everything if it's a public lab?" Adora whispered.

"They still have to protect their research and all that. What if competitors got their hands on something? It would be a disaster."

"Oooooooh." Adora nodded like she understood, and she probably would later, but Catra could tell she was too distracted at the moment. They *finally* walked into one of the labs, and everyone perked up a little. The tour guide introduced a couple of the scientists, and explained they were experimenting with particle accelerators. Catra inched closer to the front of the group, tilting her head.

"How many points of collision are there?" she asked curiously. The scientist looked at her, then followed her gaze to the board, and smiled.

"Six. It's formally been recognized as the world's largest collider."

"What's the advantage to six over four?"

Any other time, Catra would have felt something crawling on her. Her skin and fur were sensitive, and she was almost hyper aware of it sometimes. But she was so wrapped up in listening, and honestly interested, and completely distracted from the spider that had lowered itself from the ceiling by a thin piece of web and rested on her shoulder before proceeding to crawl down her arm. They were leaving the lab when it reached her hand.

"Ow!"

Adora stopped to look at her, concerned. "What's wrong?"

Catra raised her hand to look at it. "Eugh. Spider." She slapped it off, waving her hand a bit. "You'd think a place this high tech and clean would have better bug control."

"Adora, Catra! Keep up!"

They hurried to catch up with the rest of the class, the spider already forgotten.

"Hey, are you okay?"

"Tired," Catra grumbled, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. It had been a long day of walking around, and car rides -or bus rides — always made her sleepy.

"You dont think it's because of that spider, do you? What if it was poisonous?"

"Adora, shut up." Catra yawned, curling up into her friend's side. It was a long bus ride back. Plenty of time to nap.

Catra didnt remember much after that. Adora tried to shake her awake when they arrived at school, but Catra refused to even open her eyes. So, Adora did what any good friend would do;she hoisted Catra onto her back and carried her home. Catra stirred a couple times, vaguely aware of her cheek against Adora's back, but moving seemed like too much effort. And Adora had this under control.

"I didnt think walking around a lab all day would be that exhausting," she heard her mother saying as she roused again. Adora was just lying her down in bed.

"I dont know what's up. She just sorta fell asleep on the bus and refused to move."

"Well, thanks for getting her home." Lyra kissed Catra's forehead, gauging her temperature for a moment. "I guess she didnt sleep last night."

Not true, but it was a good enough excuse, Catra thought as she let herself fall asleep again.

Her dreams were… *weird*

Usually Catra's dreams were hyper-realistic and detailed. This was the exact opposite. Vague shapes flitted in and out of her vision. voices echoed around her, but she couldn't make out what they were saying. The bite mark from the spider burned fiercely, almost enough to wake her up. She tossed and turned restlessly, straining to hear, to see, to process *anything* that was happening around her.

She was drenched in sweat when she finally jolted awake at six the next morning. Her hand hurt a little, but it was nothing like in her dreams. She *needed* a shower, though.

"Look who's awake," Cyra teased as Catra stumbled out of her bedroom. "We were starting to think it was time to bring you to the hospital."

"Yeah, yeah," Catra mumbled before closing herself in the bathroom. She turned the water on as hot as it could go and just stood under it for a moment, taking a deep breath. Okay, that was weird. But she was okay. Maybe there *had* been some kind of venom in that spider. She probably should have showed her mother. But she was fine now. She grabbed the shampoo to start cleaning up. She was fine. She—

Couldn't let go of the shampoo bottle.

"Wha?" She shook her hand, frowning, then grabbed the shampoo bottle with her other hand and finally managed to rip it away. Okay, *that* was weird. She finished cleaning and got out, grabbing a towel.

A fly buzzed by her ear.

Magicat senses were naturally superior compared to human senses. Catra had gotten used to all the little sounds that came with existing around humans. It was either that, or go to a Magicat school, and she preferred Bright Moon High. Well, no. She preferred going

wherever Adora was. But either way, she had gotten used to tuning things out.

But something about the fly made her twitch and look around. She frowned, eyes flicking to follow it, then waved it off. It buzzed behind her, and it felt like something was pinging in the back of her head, alerting to it. Okay. *Weird*.

She went back to her room to get dressed, ignoring her weird jumpiness. She hadn't felt like this in years. Maybe she *was* sick. She mostly felt fine, but the twitching awareness was weird.

"Hey, are you hungry?" Lyra called when she saw Catra coming downstairs. "You missed dinner last night."

"What?" Catra rubbed her eyes, looking at her mother. "Oh, um...no. I'm fine. I mean, I'm not hungry."

Lyra frowned. "Are you sure? I can give you something to go."

"Nope, I'm good. I'll eat at school. Bye!"

Getting out of the house and into the fresh air usually made her feel better when she was like this. But she was still out of sync, odd balance.

Movement behind her. She didn't see it so much as feel it, like a sensation in the back of her head; she whirled to slapping the hand away. Adora jumped in surprise.

"Hey! I was just going to ask if you're okay, jeez. You've been standing here for like an entire minute."

"I was?" Catra rubbed the back of her head, looking around uncertainly. "Weird. I dunno, things feel kind of weird today."

"Weird how?" Adora gasped. "Like you were poisoned by a scientifically enhanced spider?"

“Probably . Right? There was no way. Catra looked at her hand again, frowning. It wasn't possible, right? It was just a spider . They happened everywhere. Right? Right. Adora was being crazy .

“Are you sure? You do seem a little.” Adora waved her hand, frowning. “Like you did when we were kids and everything was really overstimulating.”

She sort of felt that way, too. “Yeah, I'm sure. Come on, we need to get to school.”

“Oops, right. Race you!”

They ran all the way to school, laughing, until Catra grabbed Adora's sleeve at the last second, intent on pulling her back. Something — her claws, maybe — must have caught in the fabric of Adora's jacket. The momentum of Catra trying to throw Adora back turned them into a weird, demented spinning toy; they swung around a few times before tripping and falling. Adora was kind enough to cushion Catra's fall.

“Ooooooow ,” Adora groaned, using her free hand to rub the back of her head. “What the heck?”

“Sorry , I dunno what happened.” Catra rolled off Adora and tried to sit up, but her hand stuck the fabric. “What the hell”…

“Catra, let go.”

“I'm *tying*,” Catra grunted, grabbing her wrist and pulling as hard as she could. Her claws weren't even out, she realized, bewildered. How was she sticking, then?

“We're gonna be late.”

“Okay , okay. Just stand up, and we'll both pull as hard as we can.” They stood, slightly unsteady, and Catra braced herself against the ground. “Ready?” Adora nodded. “Okay , on three. One, two, three!”

They pulled back as hard as they could in other directions, Catra digging her heels into the ground and attempting to flex her fingers slightly. Just a little more…

There was a loud tearing sound, and Catra fell back, momentarily knocking the wind out of her lungs. "My jacket!" Adora's tone was pure despair. Catra pushed herself, looking at her hand, and yup, that was Adora's jacket sleeve still stuck to her hand. She grabbed it with her other hand and tried to pull, and it *finally* came loose. "I know you don't *like* it, but did you really have to *destroy* it?"

"I didn't mean to!" Catra protested, shaking the sleeve off and standing. "I'm… I'm not sure what happened."

Adora still looked annoyed. Catra didn't really blame her. "And now we're *late*. Come on."

Catra stared at her hands, bewildered, then jogged to catch up with Adora. She was sure this was a one-time thing. No big deal.

Except it kept happening.

All day. Books, pencils, her bag, her locker door, her lunch tray, Catra's hands seemed to get stuck on everything they touched. Was that normal for a magicat? She was pretty sure it wasn't normal.

"Uh… Wildcat? What're you doing?"

"Nothing," Catra grumbled as she forced her hand away from her lunch tray *again*. This was getting pretty damn old.

"You've been acting weird all day," Adora added. "What's going on?"

"*Nothing*," Catra repeated insistently. "And I have *not* been acting weird."

"You've been acting a little weird," Entrapta pointed out, swiping through her phone. "In Chemistry you ripped your textbook, then almost broke a beaker—"

"Entrapta what did I say about taking notes like I'm some sort of test subject?"

"I'm just proving my point with data."

The last class of the day was when things got *really* weird. It was gym, because the world hated Catra, and they were playing *dodgeball*. She hated dodgeball. Adora loved showing off how hard she could throw the ball, but it was really just a waste of time. Plus, half the class hated her because she could dodge easily. There was a lot of muttering about hybrids being in *different* classes. She ignored them.

She and Adora ended up on different teams, which wasn't unusual; they were among the first picks because of their various talents, and everyone seemed to know that they would be unstoppable if they were on the same team.

"Everyone ready?" the gym teacher called as they took their places on court. He waited for a moment before blowing the whistle. And the game began.

Catra was good at dodging, but that was about where her dodgeball capabilities ended. Usually. But she was on fire today. She caught one ball, and then another right before it hit her teammate in the face, then used both of those to deflect a third ball. Everyone stopped to stare at her in disbelief. She looked at the balls in her hands, then at the gym teacher.

"Do I have to throw these?"

The teacher let her pass two of the balls off to her other teammates. She threw the last one with little enthusiasm. Adora immediately snatched it up and threw it back over the line.

Catra pulled off two more saves, catching balls before they hit teammates without really trying. It was like she could tell where the

balls were going before they actually got there. She was good, but she'd never been *this* good.

The final straw was when she hit *Adora*. It was usually hard to tag Adora out, but Catra somehow managed to catch her off guard. She didn't even look mad. Just stunned. The rest of Catra's team cheered. If Adora was out, then her team didn't stand a chance.

"Nice one, Driluth," one of Catra's teammates said, clapping her on the shoulder. She tried to smile, but she was too busy trying to figure out what the fuck had just happened.

It was a relief when the bell rang, and they finally escaped. Catra went straight to the locker room, changing haphazardly. Of course, Adora's locker was right next to hers.

"Hey." She sounded cheerful enough. "That was some game."

"Yeah up." Catra closed her locker. "I'm not going home, go ahead without me."

"What're you—"

"Just gonna do some stuff. I'll tell you later."

She hurried out before Adora could stop her.

Bright Moon was a good city, but it wasn't particularly Magicat friendly. They preferred smaller towns with a lot of room to run, and places where they could go to exercise in *their* preferred way. Bright Moon didn't have a lot of that. But there was *one* place—a park that had been built years ago, specifically with Magicats in mind. Lots of climbing and jumping equipment for kids and adults. It wasn't unusual to see parents playing with their kids there on a nice day. Cyra and Lyra used to bring Catra all the time.

But it was empty today. Catra dropped her bag near one of the climbing structures, rolled her shoulders, and took a deep breath.

And she jumped.

It was a larger structure, definitely meant for adults, with hand and foot holds in various places. Catra grabbed the holds to steady herself, then took a deep breath and stuck her hand against the smooth surface.

Her hand stuck.

"Okay," she whispered, blowing out a long breath. "This is fine."

She raised her other hand and pressed it against the wall, where it stuck firmly, and gave her leverage to pull herself up. She kept her feet on the foot holds just in case, but her hands never slipped.

"Okay," she said again. She looked around to make sure no one was watching, then started climbing. It was *bizarre*, but it also felt… natural? In a weird way. Like this was something she was just meant to do. She pulled herself up over the edge of the structure and sat, staring at her hands in disbelief.

"Well. That's a thing." She turned her hands over, ruffling the fur on the back of each one, and caught sight of the spider bite. It was a little red, but not immediately alarming.

"Uh," Catra spoke out loud, like that would somehow help with the ridiculous thought she'd had. "Uh, that's stupid. Uh, anyway."

It was just a spider bite. Just a spider. There weren't *magical spiders* crawling around and giving people spider powers. That was stupid. That was… That was something that happened in *comic books*, not real life. She was over-thinking it. Yup. Totally over-thinking it. She'd just gotten lucky in gym today. There would certainly never be a repeat of that. She'd ask her moms about the sticky hands situation when she got home. There was absolutely a rational explanation for all of this. And it definitely wasn't a magical spider bite.

Catra jumped off the structure and grabbed her bag. She was being stupid. The thought carried her out of the playground and to the street, where some people were waiting at an intersection for the crosswalk to change.

Nothing to worry about. Nothing at all. There was another group of people across the street, including a human mother and her rather fussy child. From what Catra could tell, the little boy didn't *want* to wait for the light to change. He wanted to go *now*. Catra tuned it out, considering how to ask her mothers about this odd sticking predicament. Maybe it would just go away on its own. The child broke loose from his mother, darting across the street. And Catra, almost against her will, was suddenly hyper-focused. She saw the child, she could *feel* the car coming down the road, too fast. It wouldn't stop in time. No one else could get to the child in time.

Catra ran to intercept the child, grabbing him and tucking him into her chest as she dove and rolled out of the way of the speeding car. A few people yelled in surprise and panic, and someone was saying something about calling an ambulance. Catra straightened up, looking down at the kid. He seemed shaken, but relatively unharmed.

"Are you okay?" someone was asking Catra as the mother scooped the boy up, fussing over him. Catra stood slowly, looking at the road, then at her hands.

"Um, yeah. I'm fine. I gotta go."

And she ran.

Adora was rightfully surprised when Catra climbed through her window, falling with a thud onto the floor. It wasn't the first time she had done it, but usually it was to avoid her parents, who weren't even home from work yet.

"Um. Hi?"

"I just climbed up the side of your house."

"Y eah, you do that all the time."

Catra shot up, a little wild-eyed. "No, Adora, you don't get it. My hands *stuck* to your house and I used them to *climb* up here."

Adora blinked, bewildered. "Y ou're right, I don't get it. Are you okay?"

"No. Y es. I don't know!" Catra threw her arms up. "Look, it's like"…

She walked over to the wall, reached up as high as she could, and pressed her hand to the wall. It stuck. She lifted her feet a little to let herself dangle. Adora stared, mouth hanging open.

"Um. Catra?"

"And like, today in gym? It was like I knew were the balls were going before they were actually there. I caught two balls at *once*, Adora. That's not possible! And like, five minutes ago, I saved a kid from getting run over by a car."

"Y ou *what*?"

"He was in the middle of the street and there was a car coming and I just ran out and grabbed him!"

"Are you okay?" Adora demanded, standing up.

"Y eah, I'm fine! The kid is fine! Everyone is fine!" Catra waved her free hand wildly. "Except for the fact that I'm freaking the fuck out!"

"Okay , okay, calm down. Let's just think for a minute"—

"I think it's the spider bite."

Adora stopped. Stared. Blinked a few times. Catra didn't really blame her for being confused. She was still confused herself.

"You think... the spider bite?..."

"Do you have a better explanation?" Catra asked, gesturing to the hand still stuck to the wall. "Because I'd love to hear it."

"Um... puberty?" Adora suggested weakly.

Catra scoffed. "I don't remember learning about this in our sex-ed classes."

"Well they're not really catered for hybrids—"

"Adora!"

"This is weird, okay?!" Adora's voice cracked. "You're just coming in here and telling me you have *spider powers* now and you're hanging off the wall and it's weird!"

"No shit it's weird! *I'm* the one it's happening to!" Catra yanked her hand away from the wall. "What the fuck? What am I supposed to do? Am I going to grow more legs?!"

"Probably not?" Adora shrugged helplessly. "I'm not sure. But probably not!"

Catra sank to the floor, curling in on herself. "I'm going to grow more limbs and be a complete freak."

Adora knelt with her, resting a hand on her back. "I'll still be your friend even if you grow four more limbs."

"That doesn't help!" Catra buried her face in her hands, letting out a long whine. "I don't want to be a weird spider cat thing."

Adora gathered her up in a tight hug. "It's going to be okay. Just… just breathe, alright? It'll be okay."

She couldn't promise that, but Catra didn't argue. She *wanted* to believe it would be okay. "What do I tell my moms?" she asked after

a moment, raising her head to look at Adora. "What if they take me to some hospital and the doctors lock me up to *study* me?"

"Maybe don't tell them for now?" Adora suggested slowly. "I mean, unless you feel really weird or sick or something. Do you?"

Catra shook her head. "Not really." Maybe a little nauseated, but that could also be the panic. Certainly not like she was growing four more limbs. "You won't tell anyone, will you?"

"Of course not. But if anything weird happens, you have to tell me. Deal?"

"Deal."

Catra snuggled into Adora's chest, taking a deep breath, a purr rumbling in her throat. This was her safe place. She'd known Adora for as long as she could remember, and her hugs *always* made Catra feel better. Like maybe everything would really be okay.

Catra, much to her relief, did *not* grow extra limbs.

She didn't sleep much that night, too worried about checking her sides for extra arms. She tossed, turned, and probed her sides; every time she drifted into even a light sleep, she had horrific dreams about her body twisting and changing and—

She didn't sleep much that night.

Luckily, it was the weekend, and she didn't have to worry about getting up early for school or anything. She managed to doze a bit around dawn, and woke up with no extra limbs.

She texted Adora when she woke up to make sure she was free for the day—she was, of course. They hadn't made plans, and Adora tended to be a home body.

"Hey!" Cyra caught Catra as she jumped down the stairs. "Are you going out? I feel like I haven't seen you all week."

"That's because you're a workaholic," Catra said. "I'll be home for dinner, promise."

"I'll hold you to that."

Adora was already waiting at the end of the driveway, hands in the pockets of her new jacket. "How'd you explain your ripped jacket to your parents?" Catra asked as she approached.

"Oh I told them it was your fault. They didn't need much more explanation." Adora shrugged. "Where are we going?"

"Downtown."

There was an abandoned warehouse that all the teenage Magicats in Bright Moon knew about. It was old, probably a hazard, but it hadn't fallen down yet, and it was *great* for blowing off a little energy. Catra didn't usually go to it; the park was enough for her. But she needed something a bit more expansive.

"You've always been good at jumping and running," Adora pointed out, looking around the space. There were chains dangling from the ceiling and beams and platforms to jump on. It was basically perfect. "How are you going to be able to tell the difference?"

"I know myself," Catra said simply, stretching her arms and legs. "I definitely know I shouldn't be able to stick to walls. Or catch two dodgeballs at the same time and deflect a third."

"Fair," Adora conceded. "So what are you going to do?"

Catra looked around, smiling a bit. "Just have some fun."

She took a few steps back, ran, and jumped, grabbing one of the lower chains that definitely should have still been out of her reach. "Whoooooa," she breathed, looking down. She'd done rope climbing

in gym when they were kids, and while she was better than others, she'd still ached at the end of class, arms sore from holding her own body weight. She was fast and flexible, but not strong. Usually .

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah," Catra said breathlessly , laughing. "Holy shit. Check this out."

She let go of the chain with one hand and waved to Adora, who squawked in disapproval. "Don't do that! You're going to fall!"

"No, I'm fine!" Catra rocked a little, swinging the chain. "See? I can hold myself just fine. And watch this!"

She launched herself off the chain, grabbing another one. Adora let out a small shriek. "Would you *relax*?" Catra laughed, climbing up to the nearest beam and jumping onto it. "Look, I'm *fine*!"

She stood up, balancing on the beam as she walked, when an absolutely awful idea hit her. Awful, but hilarious. She made a show of losing her balance, then let out a yell as she "fell." It was a controlled fall, she'd be able to pick herself up if this failed. But Adora didn't know that.

"*Catra*!"

Thankfully, her suspicions were correct; her feet rolled along the edge of the bar, and she caught herself, hanging upside down. "Look!" she called to Adora. "No hands!"

"I'm going to *kill* you."

"Nah, you wouldn't do that." Catra reached for nearest chain, releasing herself from the beam, then dropped to the floor again. "This is *so cool*."

"Giving me a heart attack is cool?" Adora demanded.

"Oh, that's just a lucky side effect. I have *super powers*." Adora. It was possible she was a *little* drunk on her own adrenalin, but man, that rush had been *something*. "I could do anything!"

"Are you *going* to do something?" Adora asked, voice hesitant. Catra focused on her for the first time, noticing the actual worry in her expression. Oh. She was really upset. Catra hadn't mean to do *that*.

"I don't know. I mean it's been like, two days. And it's not like there are super villains in Bright Moon or anything."

Adora didn't look comforted. "Come on, you know I always land on my feet." Catra gave her nudge, smiling. "This is just one more thing I can do that's kind of cool. Doesn't it suck to be a human sometimes?"

"I guess," Adora said uncertainly. "Just…don't do anything stupid, okay? And definitely don't do anything alone."

"I won't," Catra assured her. "Promise."

She wouldn't *do* anything, she had promised Adora, but Catra could dream. And dream she did, lying in bed later that night with her sketchpad and working on the vague outline of a suit. It needed a hood to hide her ears. That was really important. Her ears were sensitive, she wanted them to be safe from the cold. After a moment of thought, she added something for her tail as well. It was also sensitive.

Ink came colors. Catra's first thought was black, but that was boring. Red was her favorite color, but that would be too much. Maybe…

She traced out some lines over the chest and shoulders, making a large X, then sketched in boots. The X and boots were black, while the rest of it was red with black lining. She turned it over, tilting her

head. t looked good, in her very humble opinion. She took a picture and sent it to Adora.

Adora

You're real l y þanni ng your superhero career , arentyou?

Catra

No

Maybe

Do you thi nk i tl ooks cool or not?

Adora

tl ooks pretty cool .

Catra

Thank you

---

t wasnt *qi te* the start of Catra's superhero career. She kept insisting she wouldnt have one, really , but they both knew she was lying. Catra had always dreamed big, even if she kept her expectations scaled down to reality . t wasnt uncommon for Adora to catch her daydreaming, a far off look in her eyes indicating that she had left this reality for something more satisfying. Something where she could be bigger than herself. Something where she could be *i mportant* .

"Y oure literally the smartest person in school,"Adora had said once to try and cheer her up. "Y oure going to be class valedictorian. Teachers trip over themselves to get you in their classes."

"None of that makes me *special* , though."Adora begged to dif fer. "There' s always going to be another smart person for the teachers to

fawn over. But there's only one *me*."

"And that's not enough for you?"

Catra had shrugged. "It's fine. But you can't tell me you don't want to *more* sometimes."

"I just think maybe... I don't know... I don't want to say settle for who you are, but *learn*, maybe. You're already pretty amazing on your own."

And that had been the end of the conversation, for the moment. But Adora could see the spark in Catra's eye again. She had dreams. Ambitions. And now she had a way to make them all come true.

The real problem was that Catra was sometimes too smart for her own good. And too much time to think.

"I suppose something like that would be possible," Entrapta said slowly, looking over Catra's drawings. "Are you planning on using it for violence? I don't personally care, but I think I need to ask if I'm going to be helping commit crimes."

"No crimes," Catra said. "Just some... extracurricular activities."

"Extracurricular activities that involve making a suit to hide your identity?" Even Entrapta was aware enough to find that doubtful.

Catra sighed. "Can you keep a secret?"

"Of course! I have several secrets, including government ones."

"Nope. Not questioning that. Then... then keep this a secret, and just trust me, okay? I'm not going to commit any crimes."

Entrapta looked back at the drawings, tilting her head. "It *would* be a fun challenge... okay, I'll do it."

Catra had been pretty sure Entrapta would help her, but the confirmation still made her smile.

In the spirit of keeping her promise to Adora, Catra brought her along to Entrapta's house a few weeks later, when Entrapta texted to let her know her stuff was ready.

"I can't believe you asked for Entrapta for help."

"I needed to outsource a little. Entrapta's better than me at making things."

Entrapta's house was sizable. Her parents were big in the tech world (Catra had no idea what they did) and were almost never home, which meant Entrapta had the house to herself and almost unlimited resources. She'd told Catra the door was unlocked, and to just head down to the basement.

"That seems like a safety hazard," Adora said, reading the text over to make sure they weren't about to break in. Catra looked around, and caught sight of a camera on the house.

"I think Entrapta has it covered," Catra said, waving to the camera and opening the door.

Entrapta was down in her basement lab, jumping excitedly. "Which do you want first? Suit or web shooters?"

"*Web shooters*?" Adora repeated in disbelief.

"Web shooters it is!" Entrapta said, proudly presenting two black wristlets. She grabbed Catra's arm and hooked it around her wrist, showing her the button that extended out onto her palm. "All right, now you just aim like this, and"…

She turned Catra's wrist, and folded her middle fingers to touch the button. "Now push."

Catra did as she was told; a thick strand of sticky string shot out of wristlet and plastered itself to the wall across the basement.

"Whoa," she whispered, looking at it in surprise. Adora took a few steps closer, leaning in to examine the string.

"What's it made of?"

"Nothing lethal," Entrapta assured her. "But it's strong. Look!"

She grabbed a pocket knife and swung it at the string. It bounced off, the string reverberating like a rubber band. "Okay, maybe don't swing knives that close to my face," Catra said carefully taking one claw to the string. It didn't go through, but she felt a slight tug of pressure from the claw nicking it.

"Yeah, it's not completely foolproof, but Magicats have *really* strong claws. Just try not to get into any fights with them."

"I'll do my best. So uh... how do I free myself?"

"Just press the button again." Catra did so, and the web fell away from her wrist, settling on the floor. "And now the suit!"

Entrapta bounced over to her desk and scooped up a bundle of cloth, letting the suit unravel. It was *better* than Catra could have ever imagined. It was made of spandex, with a loose cloth hoody on the back. "I made the mask separate." Entrapta held up the mask in her other hand. "Wanna try it on?"

"Uh, not right now," Catra said, shifting her weight between her feet. "But this looks *awesome*."

"It was a fun experiment! Especially the web fluid. It should last awhile, but let me know if you need more. I've got the recipe saved!"

"And you definitely won't tell anyone about this?"

"I would never disclose a superhero's secret identity."

She said it so seriously that Catra felt bad about trying to correct her. So she let it go.

"And we *really* trust Entrapta?"

"I trust her enough," Catra said, looking around the warehouse. She had both wristlets on, and was preparing to test them out. "It'll be fine."

"Famous last words."

Catra smirked, aiming one hand at the ceiling and pressing the button. A strand of web shot straight up, plastering to the ceiling. She bounced a few times, then grabbed the string with one hand and climbing up. It was as easy as climbing the chains.

"Hey Adora, watch this!"

She aimed her other web shooter at the ceiling, angling it then shooting. She let go of the strand she was climbing and swung, letting out a whoop of joy. She let go, landing easily on the rail of a catwalk. She balanced carefully on her feet and used one hand to keep herself steady.

"Okay," Adora called grudgingly. "That was pretty cool."

"Hell yeah it was," Catra said, standing and turning so she could swing across the warehouse. It was *such* a rush; she let out a laugh, releasing the web and landing on the catwalk properly. "This is *amazing*. Watch this!"

"I'm really starting to hate when you say that," Adora said. Catra rolled her eyes, shot off a strand of web, and swung toward the wall. She reached out one hand to steady herself on the wall, and let the strand go, sticking to the wall. She'd been practicing a little, and realized it was a bit like unsheathing and resheathing her claws. She

just needed to not freak out and breathe. "You're going to be the death of me."

Catra grinned, letting go and dropping to the floor. Adora had seen her fall from higher heights. This was fine. "You're just jealous because I'm officially the coolest person you know."

"Right up until you put on that ridiculous suit and start fighting crime."

"Psh, I always look amazing no matter what I do."

Adora rolled her eyes, smiling tolerantly. "Suuuuuuuuuuure. So what are you going to do, start swinging around the city looking for crime?"

"I'm not sure," Catra admitted. "Just going to wing it, I guess? Nothing really happens in Bright Moon, huh?"

"Maybe you'll get lucky and some big super villain will come along."

Catra snorted. "I wish."

There were no up and coming super villains, which was probably for the best. Bright Moon couldn't handle that kind of thing. But Catra started paying more attention to the news, paid more attention around school to hear what people were talking about.

That all paid off one day near the end of the school year.

"Adora!" Catra hissed as she shoved Adora's window open and tumbled into the room. Adora looked up from her homework, rolling her eyes.

"You *know* you can use the front door, right?"

"But this is so much more fun. Also I have *important* things to talk about." She sat up, smiling slyly. "I heard some interesting rumors in the library today."

"Where all the good gossip happens."

"I mean, yeah. There's this gang going around hiring students to run packages for them, then blackmailing them into paying back more money, or keep working."

"What kind of packages?" Adora asked. Catra shrugged.

"If I had to guess? Drugs. They're small and don't look suspicious if a teenager is holding them, as long as nobody opens it. But they get pictures of the kids to threaten them."

"Okay, that's obviously messed up," Adora said slowly. "But what do you think you can do about it? Are you going to take on a street gang?"

Catra scoffed. "It's *Brightmoon*. How big could they be? They usually try to get people alone downtown, so I'll just go hang out on roofs for a few nights and see what I can find out. Easy."

"And what are you going to do if you find out something is going on?"

"One step at a time. First I have to confirm it. Then I can make a plan."

It turned out hanging out on roofs was *boring*. Adora had wanted to join Catra for this, but she couldn't climb well and probably would have gotten hurt. Catra texted her updates to let her know she wasn't dead, but mostly she just sat in the shadows and listened to people talk.

She'd just sent Adora another "nothing is happening" update when she heard, "Hey, you kids looking for jobs?" and looked down to see a large man approaching two kids, probably around fifteen. Catra slid down the building a little, ears perked, listening intently.

"Uh, no," one of the kids said — the smarter of the two, apparently, because the other one absolutely looked like he was about say yes.

"Come on, it's just a quick delivery. And you'll get paid for it."

"Still no," the sensible kid said, taking his friend's arm and pulling him away. The man looked a bit pissed a he turned and went in the other direction. Catra thought for a moment before following him, jumping from rooftop to rooftop. The man climbed into a car, and Catra cursed. No other way to do this, she supposed as she aimed at the nearest building and pressed the button on her web shooter.

Keeping up with a car and trying to stay out of sight was difficult. Catra kind of regretted going with all the red in her uniform. Sure, it was cool, but at what cost?

She followed the car into one of the shittiest neighborhoods in Bright Moon, watching it park in front of an apartment complex.

"Gotcha," she muttered, texting the address to Adora. She wanted to follow the man into the building, but that definitely fell into the realm of doing something stupid, and Adora wouldn't approve. Instead, she reluctantly turned to go home. She stopped in on Adora first, though.

"What's up?" Adora asked as Catra climbed in through her window. "What was that address?"

"I heard a guy asking some kids about a job, followed them back to that place." Catra nodded at Adora's phone.

"I googled the area. It doesn't seem that great."

"Didn't look that great, either." Catra pulled her mask off, shaking her hair out. There was really no way to make her hair work with this thing, but she was doing her best. "Must not be a great gang."

"I dunno," Adora said slowly. "It might just be a place for foot soldiers to live."

"Foot soldiers?"

"I'm not sure how else to describe them." She leaned back in her chair, chewing on her lip. "But you know, the lowly members who do all the dirty work. The leaders probably live somewhere a bit nicer."

"I didn't think of that," Catra admitted. It made sense. Of course the leaders wouldn't live in the same place as common members. "So even if I have this place, I'm just going to end up taking out grunts, huh?"

"It's a start. If you plan on taking on a street gang, that is."

Adora was watching Catra as she stewed over the thought. *Was* she going to go after an entire gang? It sounded kind of insane.

"I mean... I've gotta do something, don't I? They're hurting people."

Catra would never call herself a hero. It felt too egotistical. Like *I look at me, give me attention*. But she *was* a helper. She would remind Entrapta to eat at lunch, encouraged Scorpia to chase her dreams and ask out the girl she had been pining over for months. She had spent entire weekends helping Adora study so they could be in some of the same classes, assuring her that she was, in fact, *not* an idiot, and that school was just unnecessarily complicated. If someone asked her a question in class, she would answer. She volunteered with Lyra at the hospital. She had rescued a boy from getting run over by a car. If someone was in trouble, she *was* going to step in and do whatever she could. Especially if she had the power to do it.

That was the real debut of Spider Cat – and god damn it did Catra hate that name. She'd immediately been pegged as a Magicat, of course. The tail was a dead give away. And with the webs... yeah, she was Spider Cat. Her fate was sealed the first time someone got a picture of her and sold it to the Brightmoon Chronicle.

Catra walked into the kitchen to see Cyra reading the newspaper, her lips pursed. Lyra was at the stove, cooking breakfast. "What's with the look?" Catra asked, sitting next to her mother. She shook her head, sighing.

"Have you heard about this Spider Cat person?"

"Unfortunately," Catra muttered. "Why?"

"Just wondering." Cyra shook her head. "I can't imagine what kind of person is running around in a costume pretending to fight crime."

"I mean, they stopped a robbery. That's pretty cool."

"It's *dangerous*. Imagine if a vigilante was going around to hospitals performing surgeries."

"I don't think that's the same thing, dear," Lyra said gently as she put a plate in front of her wife.

"I'm just saying, there are people who are trained in this. Bright Moon doesn't need a vigilante."

"Maybe if the police were better at their jobs, a vigilante wouldn't feel the need to run around in a costume fighting crime," Catra countered, taking her own food. "They can't be everywhere all at once, right? It doesn't hurt for someone to step in and help."

"It does if that person isn't trained or legally authorized. Who holds a vigilante responsible for their actions?"

Adora. Catra bit her tongue, focusing on her breakfast instead. Adora was the voice of reason in her life. She always had been. She knew how to keep Catra from going too far, and how to talk her down. They took care of each other.

"It's probably just some kid blowing off steam," Lyra said reasonably. "They'll stop in a month or two when they realize how much work they're actually taking on."

As if Catra ever gave anything up. Lyra would be singing a very different tune if she knew.

Time passed. Catra continued her extracurricular activities. She kept surveillance on the apartment complex and stopped some petty crimes in the process. Muggers were now *very* scared to walk down the streets of downtown Bright Moon. Good.

Tonight, she was sitting on the roof across the street from the complex, texting Adora, when she heard a car on the street. She straightened up to look at it, blinking in surprise. Wow, that was a fancy car. *Way* too fancy for this neighborhood. She narrowed her eyes, watching as a man with slicked back white hair climbed out, heading toward the complex. Well then, that was interesting. Catra pulled her mask down and swung over to the apartment building.

The inside hall was pitch dark, which gave her cover as she crawled along the ceiling, following the man. He stopped at the third door and knocked. The door opened a moment later. "Sir," a gravely voice said. The man walked in, and the door closed. Catra crawled closer, pulling her hood back slightly to let her ears move freely.

"Your earnings have been down this month."

"I know Mr. Hordak. But we've had some trouble—"

"Don't tell me this is about that ridiculous Spider Cat." Silence. "You can't be serious. You're being hindered by a child in a costume?"

"They've been running off our men and making it hard to recruit—"

"Then take care of them!" Catra winced as the man — Hordak — raised his voice. "We don't have time for games. If you can't handle this, I'll get someone who will. Understand?"

Catra crawled out of the building, using some web to swing away before anyone caught her. Okay, that was a problem.

Adora was *not* amused. "This is dangerous. You need to stop."

"Absolutely not. Now it's more important than ever."

"They're *threatening you*, Catra. You specifically." Adora waved her hand at Catra to emphasize her point. "What if you get hurt?"

Catra tapped away on her phone for a moment, frowning. "Got him. Hordak. Treasurer of state. That sounds right. He looked like a slimy politician."

"Are you listening to me?" Adora demanded, hands on her hips.

"Yeah, you think this is dangerous and I should stop."

"Are you *going* to listen to me?"

"Probably not," Catra admitted. Adora huffed in frustration. "What do you think I should do, Adora? This could be a big deal. I know a corrupt politician isn't exactly new, but someone getting money from street gangs is probably a bad thing."

"The cops can—"

Catra snorted. "The cops are going to do fuck all. Even if I *could* prove it, they won't listen to me. And no one's going to believe an anonymous tip that the treasurer of state is working with a bunch of drug dealers. He's got a clean record, more or less. And no one else is going to do anything."

"That doesn't mean it's *your* responsibility."

"If I don't do it, who will?" Adora didn't have an answer. "They're hurting people. And no one is going to care until someone ends up dead. I'm not letting it get to that point."

Adora lowered her head, taking a deep breath. "*Fine*. But same rules. If you don't let me go with you, you check in with me. And no running off like an idiot. Got it?"

Catra pretended to salute. "Y es ma'am."

I'm serious, Catra."

"So am I"Catra swung a leg over the window sill to jump down. It was late, and she was tired. It' s going to be okay. Just trust me."

"*You* arent the problem."It was everyone in the world who wanted to kill her. Catra smiled crookedly.

"Then just trust that Iknow how to not get hurt."

It was a miserable night to be out, and Catra really wanted to go home. But the Horde wasnt resting, so neither was she.

People were coming and going from the shitty complex, which was a little suspicious. It didnt seem like they were preparing to move out —there were no boxes or anything. Just back and forth to cars. They were getting ready for *something* . She just couldnt figure out what.

One car left, and Catra followed. She couldnt imagine where they going, since this was the complete opposite of downtown. Maybe it would give her a hint as to what was going on.

The suit protected her against the worst of the wind, which was great, because it was *cold* She could feel the sting of the air, but it was mostly repelled. She shot off one last web, and landed on the roof across the street from where the car had stopped. The neighborhood was a far cry from the neighborhood the street grunts lived in. Nice houses, neatly trimmed lawns, cars that probably cost more than an entire house parked in the driveways. Two fairly well dressed people climbed out of the car, walking to the door and knocking. Catra hissed when Hordak opened the door . She should have known.

The door closed, and Catra used a string of web to carry her across the street, carefully landing on the roof. The backyard was dimly lit —a good place for her to sneak around. She dropped to the ground, crouching so she was below windows, and began creeping along the perimeter until she could hear voices.

"We're trying to—"

"I don't want to hear excuses," Hordak snapped. "Since you seem incapable of handling a child, I've hired someone who will. I want you two to make sure there's nothing left behind once this nuisance is dead."

Oh shit. Catra blew out a long breath. He'd hired an *assassin* just for her? What the fuck? She was usually good at staying out of sight, but it only took one misstep when she fighting someone…

Adora was going to lose her shit. Catra scrubbed her face, blowing out a long breath. She couldn't tell her. Adora could *not* know about this. She'd just have to be more careful. She was fast. There was no way someone would be able to easily shoot her, even at close range.

Adora didn't have to know. It would be fine.

Going out on patrols was a little nerve-wracking now. Catra didn't let it stop her; she refused to be scared, and besides, they weren't aware that she knew. It would be weird if she suddenly changed her habits. Having them think she was clueless might actually work in her favor.

She still checked in with Adora, but she didn't tell her anything. It was better she didn't know. She would just worry.

"Hey, kid."

Catra looked down at the alley she was sitting near. There were two large men towering over a young boy. He looked scared. He also

looked familiar.

"You looking for a job?"

"What? No, I'm good."…

Catra narrowed her eyes. She knew this kid. She had seen him hanging around the apartment complex before. She didn't know exactly what he did, but he was there and working with them mostly willingly. So why were they threatening him?…

Oh. Catra looked up, scanning the area around her. And yup, there was a shadowy shape propped on another roof with a rifle, pointed at the alley. It was a setup. They were trying to lure her out so the assassin could have a clean shot.

Nope. Catra shot off some web, circling around and hoping the assassin didn't have exceptionally good eyesight. She kept an eye on them as she moved; they had kept their position. Good.

She landed lightly behind the assassin, and punched them in the back of the head. They let out a yelp of surprise, but managed not to smash their face into their rifle. They whipped around, more stunned than angry, watching as Catra stepped back, out of arm's reach.

"Oh, you *are* a smart one." Their voice was smooth and amused. They stood, but didn't raise the rifle. Instead their features began to shift, their body turning completely black for a moment as they grew and grew…

"You've *got* to be kidding me."

"It's nothing personal, darling," the now very tall, very bulky person said. "Just a job, you know?"

They swung one meaty fist, and Catra ducked. She shot two strands of web, hitting the person in the chest, and pulled back with a grunt,

bringing them crashing down. To her surprise, they chuckled, picking themself up.

"Clever ." They drew a pocket knife. "It' s been awhile since I had a challenge."

They lunged at Catra; she jumped back, dropped into a crouch, then jumped, launching herself over their head and kicked their knees from behind. They stumbled, but managed to hold their footing, and whirled. The knife caught the cheek of Catra's mask. It was a shallow cut, but it hurt like hell.

"Son of a bitch," she hissed, pressing her hand to her cheek.

"Now , now. There's no need for that language."

"You're trying to *kill* me," Catra snarled. "You don't get to lecture me about language."

"Just because I'm trying to kill you doesn't mean we have to forget civility."

Catra unsheathed her claws – always a last response because Magicat claws could cut through metal and she didn't want to kill anyone. But they had a knife, and they *were* trying to kill her. She could just be careful.

She surged forward, ducking around another knife swing, and elbowed the person in the face. She heard a satisfying *crack*, presumably as the person's nose broke. But she'd miscalculated. She felt the physical knife in her side before she actually felt the burning pain. She choked down a scream, stumbling back and barely not falling to her knees.

The assassin chuckled, wiping the blood from their nose. "Not bad, not bad." Catra pressed her hand to her side, grimacing. "It' s always fun to get a fighter."

Catra hissed, stumbling back and shooting off a web to swing away on.

Adora was asleep. It looked like she'd been lying in bed playing on her phone and just passed out. Oh, she was *really* going to be pissed about this. Catra pushed the window up, trying not to groan, and tumbled into the room, hitting the floor with a thud. Adora startled awake, sitting up hurriedly, then focused on the huddled heap on her floor.

"Catra!" She stumbled out of bed, dropping to her knees beside her. "What happened? Are you okay?"

"Been better," Catra said woozily, picking herself up. Adora saw the blood, and gasped.

"Oh my god. Oh my god, okay. Don't freak out." It seemed like she was talking to herself more than Catra. "Just stay here. I'll be right back."

She hurried out of her room. Catra slumped against the wall, letting out a shuddering breath.

Adora returned a moment later with towels and a first aid kit. "Can you get the top off?"

"Yeah," Catra grunted, shifting herself to roll up her shirt and showing Adora the stab wound.

"Jesus *Christ*, Catra."

"Judge me after there isn't a gaping wound in my side?"

"Right, right." Adora carefully cleaned up the wound, ignoring Catra's pained hisses. "What happened?" she asked, trying to distract her.

"You're going to be mad," Catra murmured. Adora gently squeezed her arm.

"I won't be. I promise. Just tell me. Please?"

Catra blew out a long breath, wincing. "So uh. Hordak kind of took out a hit on me."

"*What*?!"

"*Shush*," Catra hissed. There was a knock at the door a moment later.

"Adora?" Marlena called. Catra scooted so she was out of sight of the door, and Adora scrambled up to open her door and keep her mother out. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah," Adora said quickly. "I'm just... mad at a book. It did something *really stupid*."

"Ah. Well, don't stay up too late." Marlena kissed Adora's forehead. "Good night."

"Night."

Adora closed the door, then went back to Catra, kneeling with her. "What do you *mean* Hordak took a hit out on you?" she hissed. "How long have you known about this?"

"A couple weeks," Catra admitted. "I didn't want you to freak out."

"*Yeah*, I'm freaking out," Adora hissed. "A gang leader sent an assassin after you!"

"It's fine—"

"It's *not fine*! You're hurt! What happened?"

"They tried to stage a mugging or something to lure me out, but I saw the person on another roof with a rifle—it was a shapeshifter. I swear to god, I didn't think those were *real*—"

"And you *f oughtthem* ?"

"W ell, Iwasnt going to let them shoot me."

"Why didnt you walk away?"

"Iwas hoping Icould get a look at their face and turn them in or something. The shapeshifting thing really threw a wrench in that idea."

"And then they stabbed you!" Adora waved a hand at the wound. "What are you going to do if an organ is damaged or something?"

"Actually , Ithink Ihave some super healing or something." Catra looked at her side. "It isnt bleeding nearly as much as it was when they first stabbed me."

"Oh, that' s great," Adora said, grabbing some bandages to patch Catra up. "The hole in your side is just *f i ne*."

"Adora, come on—"

"Dont *Adora come on* me! Y ou couldve gotten seriously hurt tonight! You couldve died!" Adora threw her hands up. "Do you even know how many people would miss you if you just never came home?"

Catra wilted a little, shoulders hunching up. "I, I," she admitted qietly . They sat in silence for a bit while Adora finished wrapping up Catra's side.

"Just.be careful. Please. Y our moms need you to come home. *I* need you to come home."

"I'll always come home, Adora," Catra assured her qietly . "I promise."

Adora nodded, swallowing and closing her eyes. "Good. Im going to hold you to that."

Catra didn't go out over the next couple nights. Just moving made her side flare up in a fiery pain, and she couldn't really fake illness to get out of school and chores. So she just took a lot of ibuprofen, breathed through it, and gritted her teeth through the days. Adora tried to help where she could, but there was only so much she could do.

"I'm fine," she grumbled when Adora tried to carry her bag for her. "Stop acting like I'm a damsel in distress or something."

"I don't think you're a damsel, I think you're an idiot," Adora countered.

"Whatever. Give me my bag."

Her mothers, unfortunately, noticed. "Why are you moving like an old lady?" Cyra asked teasingly, ruffling Catra's hair. She knocked the hand away, grumbling.

"I think I pulled a muscle or something."

"Doing *what*?" Magicats were naturally flexible, to the point that they were almost rubber. It wasn't *impossible* for them to do things like pull muscles, but it wasn't really common.

"Showing off in gym class."

"Well, go lie down," Lyra said, kissing Catra's forehead. "I don't want you hurting yourself."

Catra would have laughed if she could. If only her mother knew.

Catra had to be far more aware than usual on her patrols going forward. She wasn't giving that asshole a chance to take her down. Between all of this, it was amazing that she had any time for school at all. But it was senior year, and she *had* to stay on top of things. College applications had to go out. The guidance counselor had

already told her she was on track to be valedictorian —which she really didn't care about, but it meant she couldn't mysteriously let her grades fall.

The assassin seemed to enjoy their cat and mouse game. Catra never got close to them;instead, she used web to take out whatever rifle was pointed at her. Weirdly, she heard them laugh every time she caught them. Sometimes she wondered if they were letting her get away on purpose. They really did seem to be enjoying this.

"Maybe they're just drawing it out to get paid for ," Adora guessed when Catra told her about her suspicions.

"Is that how murder for hire works?"

"How should I know? I've never needed an assassin for anything."

Catra had questions, so why not go straight to the source? She waited until she spotted them one night, and just like the first night, she swung around to get behind them, using webs to tie them up and pull them to the ground.

"Aw, kitten!" They sounded *delighted*. "I was wondering when we'd get to talk again."

"I don't usually talk to people who *stab me* ."

"Oh, I told you it's nothing personal. I'm just doing a job."

"Sure." Catra knelt to meet their gaze. "You must be *really bad* at your job, since I'm still alive."

"I'm one of the best in the city , thank you very much," they replied with a scoff. "You just happen to be difficult. I've never had a Magicat target before. A bit unfair, really."

"But you're still trying."

"Like I said, I like a challenge." They started to shift, body shrinking to try and escape. Catra pulled the webs tighter, making sure to keep them tied up. "This is *very* impressive, by the way."

"I'm *so* glad you approve," Catra said. She was stalling. There was no way she could outpay whatever Hordak was paying the assassin, and money talked louder than anything. "Whoever hired you must be pretty pissed you haven't gotten anywhere yet."

She didn't want to tell them how much she knew. The assassin laughed. "Are you trying to get information out of me? That's cute."

Catra scowled under mask, pulling the webs a bit tighter. "*Oof*. Careful, I have very delicate skin."

"Look, I'm not stupid. Assassins are supposed to get their jobs done fast and move on to the next one. How do you have this much time to play a stupid game with me?"

The assassin smirked. "Fine, I'll give you one thing. My… *employer* can't hire anyone else. They've got a strict budget. Sales are down, you know."

"So you're milking them."

"Like I said — nothing personal. Everyone needs to live, right?"

Catra released the webs, stepping back. "Yeah. Everyone needs to live."

The assassin struggled, grunting. "Hang on, you can't just leave me here," they protested.

"Don't worry, someone will come along to pick you up soon if you don't get yourself free."

Catra swung off to another building to put in an anonymous tip to the police. It couldn't hurt either way.

The bedroom door flew open, crashing off the wall. "*Catra!*" Adora cried dramatically, dropping on top of her. "I need moral support."

"Don't you have parents for that?" Catra mumbled sleepily.

"They don't understand."

"Neither do I. Go away."

Adora pouted, rolling and shifting to get under the blankets with Catra and cuddle up to her. "Pleeeeeeeeease? It's my admission letter from Bright Moon University."

Oh. Yeah, Marlena and Randor *would not* understand that. They didn't have the same standards that Adora had for herself – if she didn't get in, they would be comforting, but they wouldn't understand why she was devastated.

"Okay, okay." Catra rolled over to look at Adora, headbutting her chin. "Let's see it."

It was a small envelope, which already wasn't good. Catra's early admission acceptance had been full of packets and forms and information. She bit her tongue on that observation though. Adora tore the letter open, holding her breath as she read. Tears filled her eyes. Uh oh.

"What does it say?"

Adora shoved the piece of paper at Catra, then rolled out of bed, wiping her eyes.

Dear Ms. May,

Thank you for your application to Bright Moon University. After careful consideration, the selection committee is unable to make an offer of admission at this time, but would like to offer you a place on our waitlist.

"Well...hey, wait list isn't a no—"

"Don't." Adora's voice was rough and thick with tears. "This was *all* I wanted. It's the only school I applied to!"

"Sometimes places want to wait and see how you do before graduation," Catra said gently, reaching out to touch Adora's shoulder. She was surprised when she was shrugged off. "It says they'll consider wait list applicants in May and June, so it's not really over yet—"

"You don't *get it*!" Adora whirled on her heel to look at Catra. "Do you know what it's like to have the class genius as your best friend? Everything just comes so *easy* to you. I have to work twice as hard *and* have you tutor me to do half as good as you. And *everyone* knows how smart you are. I bring home Bs and Cs and my parents are fine with it, but they always talk to your moms about your straight As and I know they wish that was me. You're smart, you're fast, you have these really weird and cool powers. You get to be *everything*. And I'm just the stupid human friend."

Catra stared, slack-jawed. She had to struggle against the tears burning in her eyes. "You're right, I don't get it. All I've ever tried to do is help you—"

Adora snatched the letter back and turned, storming out of the room. Catra scowled, jaw clenching tight. "Fine, whatever. See if I care."

She flopped back down in bed and pulled the covers up, closing her eyes. Screw this. What was Adora even *mad* about? Yeah, getting wait listed sucked, but it wasn't Catra's fault.

Her ears twitched at the sound of gentle steps approaching her bedroom, but she didn't re-surface. "Hey," Lyra said quietly, knocking on the door frame. "Can I come in?"

"Whatever," Catra muttered. Lyra sat with Catra, gently rubbing her back.

"Cut Adora some slack. It's not her fault."

It's not *mine*, either! But apparently spending days and days helping her study isn't good enough."

Lyra sighed. "It's hard when there's an intelligence gap in a relationship. Your mother is a million times smarter than I'll ever be, and when we were younger, it *did* make me jealous. She never made me feel bad about myself, but I was very *aware* of it. It makes a person little bitter. I mean, your mother is a doctor, and I'm Lyra gestured around the room, sighing. "I'm a stay at home mom with an almost eighteen year old who's leaving me for college next year. Mom will still have her job, but you're not going to need me anymore."

Catra frowned, finally crawling out of her nest to nestle into her mother's lap. "I'm always going to need you," she said quietly. Lyra hugged her tight, kissing the top of her head.

"Just give her a chance to apologize. She owes you one, absolutely, but be willing to listen when she does. Okay?"

"Yeah," Catra muttered into her mother's shoulder. "Sure."

She went out that night, because she had nothing better to do. Adora still wasn't talking to her (although Catra saw her bedroom light was on), and fine, that was fine. Catra hadn't done anything *wrong*, but fine.

First stop was the apartment complex, which seemed quiet. A few people were milling about on the doorstep, there were lights on inside. Normal night, all and all. She watched the building for a few minutes, debating things. She knew where the gang lived, she knew where Horde lived. Couldn't she just call the cops? Let them raid the complex? There had to be proof of crimes *somewhere* in there. And it wasn't like the Horde was completely unknown. There'd been an assembly about *staying safe* and all that at the beginning of the

school year. The police had picked up a few members downtown for harassing minors. People knew they existed, but no one was *doing* anything about it. Were they all really that stupid?

Her next stop was Hordak's place. She never saw much apart from him moving by windows in different rooms, and sometimes she got close enough to hear a conversation, but it was always boring political stuff. He probably wasn't stupid enough to say anything on a call that could easily be recorded. Taking him down was the *real* goal. Corrupt politicians were a dime a dozen, but Hordak was using the gang for money, and from what Catra could tell, he was also supplying the drugs that the gang sold. Aside from being completely illegal, that was definitely career ending.

He seemed to have settled in his study with a nice book for the night. Boring. Catra sighed and headed for downtown. At least she didn't have to stop every five minutes to let Adora know she was still alive.

Adora ignored her in school the next day, and didn't show up for lunch. Catra just rolled her eyes and ate, ignoring Scorpia's and Entrapta's questions. If Adora wanted to be like this, then fine. Catra wasn't going to go chasing after her.

The next few days continued in that manner. Catra was starting to get irritated, but it was *fine*. Whatever. Adora was going to have to talk to her eventually, even if it was just to study for exams. She wasn't seriously going to fail over her pride, was she?

By Friday, Catra was ready to hit something. It had been a nice, calm week, no robberies or muggings, so she'd just sat around, occasionally checking for the assassin. She hadn't seen them recently, and wondered if the police had really gotten them, or if they were just staying low to lure Catra into a false of security.

She sat on the roof across from the apartment complex, scowling. It was late, and most had retreated into their apartments for the night.

It was stupid. Catra *knew* it was stupid. But all of her frustrations from the week were starting to bubble over, and she just wanted to *do something*. She checked her web shooters, took a deep breath, and launched herself off the roof.

The first few apartments were easy. Apparently no one locked their doors because they trusted their fellow gang members. That was a mistake. Catra got the drop on them and gagged them, pinning them to the wall in the process. The fourth apartment was where she ran into someone who was still awake (and naked, not something Catra really wanted to see), and he managed to get a yell out before Catra could stop him. She snarled under her breath when she heard door start opening. Fine. She could handle this. She was faster, stronger, and she could see in the dark.

The first few people were easy. Webs, claws, fists, she was unstoppable. She finished up with the first floor right as people began descending from the second. Of course they'd heard the commotion. Whatever. Catra turned her attention to them —and ducked when someone swung a baseball bat. Shit. Weapons.

She still gave more hits in than she took, which she felt good about. But by now the third floor was making its way down as well, and shit, she had *really* overestimated her capabilities. *Fine*. She used both web shooters to take down as many people as she could, and started to back up toward a window. She hadn't realized how many people were—

A gunshot rang through the air.

It echoed in her sensitive ears, and for a moment *that* was the worst pain she felt. Then she got out the window and tried to aim her web shooter, only for white-hot pain to burn through her shoulder.

Uh oh.

The good news was that the bullet had gone straight through, so at least she didn't have to dig it out of her shoulder. The bad news

was pretty much everything else. She stopped to call in an anonymous tip (hoping the chaos would make them careless), and then had to deal with getting away. Getting home with one arm was hard, and she could only hope she wasn't leaving drops of blood throughout the city. She managed to get back to her house without much trouble, though. That was a win.

And more problems. She looked up at her window, which suddenly seemed impossibly far away. Her hand was pressed against her shoulder, trying to keep her blood in her body where it *belonged*, and the world was starting to spin.

She thought she heard someone saying her name as she dropped to her knees, the world going gray around the edges of her vision. It was strange, she thought as the last of her consciousness left her. What was the sun doing out in the middle of the night?

"...and I feel bad waking her up so I figured she could just stay here, is that okay? Uh huh. I will. Okay . Thanks Lyra."

Every single part of Catra's body *hurt*. She gritted her teeth against the groan bubbling in her throat and raised her head, blinking the room into focus. Adora's room. She was in Adora's room.

"You're awake!" Adora appeared in front of her , chewing her lip. "How do you feel?"

"Absolutely great," Catra mumbled.

"Good." Adora slapped her head. "How did you get *shot*?"

"What do you care?" Catra said, shoving the blankets back with her good arm and trying to sit up. Oh no, that was a bad idea. She collapsed back against the pillow, swallowing down the nausea.

"I *care* because I don't want you to die!" Adora said, exasperated.

"But then you wouldn't have to worry about being friends with *the class genius*."

Adora seemed to shrivel in on herself, and Catra felt a little bad. That probably hadn't been necessary. "That's not fair," she said quietly.

"Neither is blaming me for you getting wait listed," Catra bit back, once again trying to sit up. This time she actually managed to get her feet on the floor before she stumbled. Adora quickly grabbed her around the waist to keep her upright.

"Okay, what part of *you got shot* did you not get? Stop being stupid."

"I'm fine. I'll heal. The stab wound only took a couple days."

"But you should *still*—Catra!" Adora huffed as Catra staggered to her window. "I already told your mother you're sleeping over here. If you want to sleep in the guest room or something, fine, but it's going to be pretty weird if you climb back in through your window *now*."

Catra slumped against the window sill, glaring at Adora. She noted, for the first time, that she'd been stripped, and was wearing one of Adora's large t-shirts. "Where are *your* parents?"

"On vacation to celebrate their honeymoon. They won't be back until Sunday. Will you *please* sit down?"

She compromised by sitting at Adora's desk. "Fine," Adora grumbled. "Fine. Whatever. You're welcome for saving your life."

"*You're* welcome for every single night I spent studying with you and teaching you so you wouldn't fail."

"I get it, we have things to talk about," Adora said, exasperated. "Are you seriously going to put your pride over your physical health and safety, though?"

Well, when she put it like that, it sounded kind of dumb. "Fine," Catra said, getting up just to crash into Adora's bed again. "Happy?"

"No. Did that assassin finally get you?"

Oh boy. She was going to be *so mad*. "No," Catra admitted. "Um. I tried to raid the apartment complex by myself."

"You did *what*?!" Adora's voice was shrill and doing that thing where it cracked because she was too stressed to modulate it. "*Why*?"

"I was feeling cocky."

"There's *cocky*, and then there's suicidal."

"It's admittedly a fine line." Catra snuggled into the blankets, taking a deep breath and pretending she wasn't just a little intoxicated by Adora's scent. Adora sat with her, wringing her hands together.

"I know we have a lot to talk about, but—"

"Just shut up and lie down with me," Catra said, far too exhausted to deal with anything more right then. Thankfully, Adora listened.

They did talk, eventually. Catra spent most of the next day in bed, after calling her mothers and asking if she could stay over because Adora was lonely without her parents.

"She's really wanted to ask me to come over all week, but she felt embarrassed," Catra informed Cyra gravely as Adora rolled her eyes.

"*Mmm*," Cyra sounded amused. "*Fine, one more night, just because Mermista and Sandor are gone. But you're both coming over for dinner.*"

"Yes ma'am."

It was amazing, really, how much their parents trusted them. And they'd earned that trust. Mostly. Superhero-ing aside.

"I know it's stupid," Adora said quietly, staring at the floor. "I just always feels like people are comparing me to you, and I can't keep up."

Catra scoffed. "Seriously? People *actually* compare me to you to my face. Why can't you be as polite as Adora, why can't you be as helpful, why can't you be as nice. And I don't *care*, their opinions don't matter, but do you really think I can't understand how that feels?"

"No." Adora's shoulders slumped. "I know. I'm sorry. I was just really upset, and then I felt like I couldn't talk to you because you'd think I was stupid, and then you almost died in your backyard—"

"I had everything completely under control, thank you very much."

"Yeah, your bleeding out was definitely controlled. Anyway, that's not the point."

"I know." Catra sighed. "And I'm sorry I made you feel stupid."

"You didn't, though. I think that's why I was mad. You've *never* made feel like I'm dumb, or that I can't take the same classes as you even though they're harder. Even when the teachers say it's a bad idea."

She paused, then smiled. "You'd be a really good teacher."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Hell no." She stretched out her good arm. Adora took the invitation to lie down with Catra, holding her close. "You're not dumb, you just learn differently. There's nothing wrong with that. It's their problem if they don't realize how amazing you are."

"Aaaaawwww, you think I'm amazing?" Adora teased. "Do you *like* me or something? That's so embarrassing."

"I take it all back. You're a dumb ass. Get out."

Adora laughed and snuggled closer. Catra didn't push her away.

Catra spent most of the day sleeping so she could face her moms without looking like death warmed over. She also showered three times to make sure there was absolutely no scent of blood on her.

Cyra didn't look particularly pleased when the girls arrived. Catra winced. "Something wrong, Mom?"

"Ignore her," Lyra called from the kitchen. "She's just annoyed by the news today."

"What happened?" Adora asked.

"Drug bust downtown. The police got an anonymous tip and got to the complex to find the place covered in *webs*."

"Oh. Still not a fan of Spider Cat?"

"God that's a stupid name." Catra couldn't disagree. "It's irresponsible and dangerous. The police found blood at the scene, which means they probably got hurt."

A very terrible thought occurred to Catra. "Can they like, run DNA on that or anything?"

"They could, but unless the person has a record, they won't get much." Catra let out a long, quiet breath. She'd never gotten in trouble with the police. It'd be fine.

They sat down to eat. Catra let everyone else carry the conversation, focusing on eating without eating *too* fast. Blood loss made her really hungry, and Adora's house was woefully empty. She should never be left alone again.

"You've been okay without your parents?" Lyra was asking Adora. "I thought Catra would be over keeping you company every night."

"I'm fine alone."

"She definitely almost burned the house down at least once," Catra teased.

"Did not!"

"T wice?"

Adora stuck her tongue out at Catra, who just grinned back. There. This felt more like normal. She liked this.

The horde was the big news for the next few weeks as police tried to sift through the members and get whatever information they could be the higher ups. Either no one who'd been arrested knew about Hordak, or no one was talking. That was some level of loyalty , Catra thought. She was sure even Adora would sell her out for the right price.

Catra *did* check in on Hordak one night. He was nearly in hysterics. The sight made her smile.

Otherwise, she took some time off after that. She had finals to study for, a friend to get through high school, and frankly, she'd earned it.

May passed into June, and Adora had more or less accepted that she wasn't getting into BMU. She had started looking into the community college, which was depressing to her, but Catra did her best to keep her spirits up. She could always transfer. It wasn't the end of the world.

"*Catra* !"

Catra groaned as her door burst open, and Adora dropped on top of her. "I'm *sleeping* ," she grumbled, burying her head under her pillow .

"I got another letter from Bright Moon University! The envelope looks like yours!"

Catra immediately sat up, wide-eyed. Sure enough, Adora was clutching a thick, huge envelope to her chest, expression cautiously hopeful. "Well? Open it!"

Adora was not at all careful about tearing the envelope open, but she didn't rip anything inside, and that was all that mattered. She found the letter first, and squealed.

"I got in!"

Obviously, after all the celebrations were done, they made sure they were rooming together.

Things went very fast after that. Graduation happened, Catra delivered a speech that no one would remember, and most of the summer was spent packing and buying everything necessary for making a dorm room livable. Blessedly, Adora and Catra had similar color preferences, so there was no argument about that.

Catra still slipped out at night to do patrols. The Horde had been severely handicapped and didn't have the man power to work the way they had, but there were still run of the mill assholes who thought *tonight* would be the night they would get away with mugging someone. Spoiler alert: it never was.

"Are you going to sneak out of the dorms at night to do Spider Cat stuff?" Adora teased.

"I don't have to sneak. No one's going to care if I come in at three a.m."

"As long as you're not bleeding, sure."

Catra pulled a face, rolling her eyes. "I haven't been stabbed or shot in *months*, thank you very much."

Things were good. Great, even. Adora eventually settled on a major—education, which was kind of surprising, but Catra could also see the logic. She wanted to be the teacher she wished she'd had. It wasn't an *easy* major, but Adora could persevere with the best of them. Catra believed in her.

They were nineteen, and the world was their oyster.

"Best ice cream ever," Adora declared as she shoveled down the double chocolate brownie ice cream. Catra rolled her eyes.

"You say that about *every* ice cream place we go to."

"And I mean it every time."

It was Saturday afternoon. They were downtown, enjoying taking some time off between school projects and just existing together. Catra had already finished her much smaller ice cream, but Adora had gotten the biggest possible waffle cone bowl to eat as they walked.

"You know every single place can't be the best, right?"

"Well that's just wrong—"

Sirens cut through the air, interrupting the stupid debate. They looked around in surprise, hearing people yell and tires squeal, and a car banked a sharp right around a nearby corner, peeling down the street. Two cops were right on its tail.

"Aw jeez," Catra muttered. Adora shoved her backpack at her.

"I've got your stuff. Go."

Catra gave her a small smile and slipped into a nearby alley while everyone was distracted. She threw the bag to Adora before scaling the wall and jumping to the nearest roof, trying to keep track of the chase. Then she heard a *second* car, and swore. Fine. Of course. Just make her life more difficult. Why not.

She went after the second car, since that one didn't have any police on it yet. The easy route would've been to just web the tires, but that was *way* too risky. Instead she landed on top of a streetlight, braced herself, and shot a string of web at the car. The initial jolt of it stopping nearly tore her arm out of its socket. She held on, though, digging her claws into the metal for more traction when the car tried to accelerate. *Now* she aimed at a tire and it with a web. It stopped moving abruptly, and the car started to spin. Catra took out the opposite tire and pulled it back onto the road with some effort. She could hear people shouting and phone cameras snapping photos. Great. Front page of the Bright Moon Chronicle for her tomorrow.

The car finally stopped trying to move, and two men jumped out, intending to run. Catra laughed to herself as she webbed both sets of ankles and dragged them back, attaching them to the light. "Sorry guys," she said, giving them a two-fingered salute. "But nice try."

She took off to follow the sirens.

Later, she would think of all the things she could have done. She could have checked the streets to make sure they were empty. She could have made sure Adora was somewhere safe. She could have let it go and let the cops do their fucking jobs.

There were police all over the place now, trying to set up road blocks and clear the streets. The escape car was circling, trying to find an exit that hadn't been blocked yet. Catra couldn't pull the same stunt she had with the other car since the police were *right* on top of it, and it would've caused a crash. All she could do was keep up, watch the cars, and try to formulate a plan.

She saw the stuffed animal that had been dropped in the middle of the street. Saw the child trying to break free from her mother to try and rescue it. But that was under control, she thought as she finally decided to just drop onto the roof of the car and hope the cops got the damn message. Even as they turned onto that street, the kid was still in her mother's grip. Catra prepared to launch herself. It would be fine.

The kid broke free.

Catra's attention immediately went to her. She shot off a string of web, intending to pull the kid out of the way. She'd be bruised and probably a little scraped up, but alive, which was preferable to the alternative. With everything else going on, she didnt notice the second person who ran into the street until it was far too late.

Adora. Sweet, loving, caring Adora. Adora, who wanted to be some kind of hero, even if it was just to one person. Maybe one student whose life she could change. Adora, who would throw herself on the sword for anyone if it meant being able to help them. Even a stranger.

Catra wasnt fast enough to grab her. She shoved the kid away right as the web caught her, ensuring she was dragged to safety, but it was too late for Adora. The car hit her with a sickening thud;her body rolled over the hood, the windshield (which shattered), and she hit the hood of one of the police cars. All vehicles screeched to a halt. Catra jumped down and grabbed the kid, making sure she was turned away from the grisly scene, before shooting a strand of web at the runaway car;she ripped the passenger 's door off, furiously throwing it aside, then grabbed the passenger by the collar and yanked him out. The driver tried to escape, and was webbed to a wall for his troubles.

She looked to Adora, her heart falling into her stomach. Clothes. She needed clothes. Adora had the bag on her still. *Fck*.

t only took two minutes to find an empty clothing store, break the handle on the back door to get in, and slice off some price tags and security tags. Catra ran back to the scene as fast her legs would carry her, web shooters and mask in the pocket of her new sweatshirt, and an ambulance had already arrived. Paramedics were trying to get Adora off the police car and onto a board to transport her. Catra had no qalms about using elbows and claws to shove through the crowd.

“*Adora*!”

A cop saw her and tried to grab her. She swiped at him, hissing, and was pretty sure she caught his skin. She didn’t care. One of the paramedics tried to placate her.

“Please, we need room to work—”

“Fucking *move*,” Catra snarled, flashing her claws. The paramedic held up his hands.

“You know her? Can you call her family?”

“My phone’s in her bag.” A thought occurred to Catra. “Where are you taking her?”

“Bright Moon General.”

“My mom works there. Can I come?”

And that was how Catra wound up in the back of the ambulance with Adora’s nearly lifeless body. Her heartbeat was staggered, breathing ragged even with the oxygen mask on, and she never opened her eyes. One of her hands hung loosely at her side. Catra took it and squeezed gently, whispering, “Don’t you dare fucking die. I’ll never forgive you.”

Adora was immediately whisked off to surgery as soon as they arrived. A nurse *tried* to get information from Catra, but all she could say was that she wanted her mother.

“What’s your mom’s name, and do you know what floor she works on?” the nurse finally asked. Catra scrubbed at the tears she hadn’t realized were falling.

“Cyra D-Driluth. Third floor.”

The nurse nodded, and went to make a phone call. Cyra made it down to the first floor in record time, and had barely entered the

waiting room when Catra crashed into her, hugging her tight.

"Ssshhh, it's okay." Cyra ran her hand through Catra's hair. "What happened?"

Thankfully, the nurse explained, because Catra didn't think she could get the words out. Cyra gave them Marlena's and Randor's cellphone numbers, then led Catra to sit, and called Lyra.

Adora Gray died at ten-forty-three p.m., after nearly eight hours of surgery. Marlena cried into Randor's shoulder as the doctor explained that her injuries had just been too severe. Cyra and Lyra had sandwiched Catra between them, and both were holding her tight, while Lyra extended her other hand to squeeze Marlena's arm. Catra really thought she'd cried all of her tears, but amazingly, there were more. She had gotten her hopes up. How stupid of her.

The next bit of time (Catra couldn't even track it in days or weeks) passed in a blur. Her mothers took her home and called BMU to let them know about the situation. The university was very kind, asking if Catra wanted to take some time off without penalty. She dropped out. The thought of going back without Adora made her sick.

The day of Adora's funeral was absolutely blank in her mind. She remembered Scorpia hugging her, and Entrapta saying something, but the rest of it was a whole lot of nothing.

Cyra and Lyra, with some help from Scorpia, cleared out the dorm room. Again, the school was very understanding, but they couldn't just let a dorm room go unused. They had offered help, but Cyra and Lyra had agreed they could handle it on their own, for Catra's sake, and for Marlena's and Randor's.

Catra knew she should have cared more about Adora's parents. She should have dragged herself over to them during the funeral or any of the days that followed when she was next door wallowing in self pity. But the idea of facing them was horrifying. It was *her* fault Adora

was dead, wasn't it? She should have been there to stop her. Or been faster to save her. How was she supposed to look Marlena and Randor—basically her own parents—in the eye and act like they didn't know all know she had basically murdered Adora?

"What good is a *hero* who can't save one girl?" she heard Cyra saying one night when she was supposed to be asleep.

"It's no one's fault except the person driving the car," Lyra disagreed quietly.

"I knew this whole Spider Cat thing was never going anywhere good. They were there. They could have saved Adora."

"Cyra, shush."

Someone suggested therapy. Catra refused.

Eventually she got a shitty job, and then another one, and then another one, because it turned out employers didn't appreciate when their workers threatened customers. The fact that Catra was still getting hired at all was a miracle. She worked if she had a job, went home, and spent the rest of her time lying in bed. She ate when Lyra brought her food or coaxed her downstairs. She continued to exist, which felt like such a waste.

She packed the suit and web shooters up and shoved them into the closet. Cyra was right. What good was she if she couldn't save the one person who mattered more than anyone else?

"Why don't you move in with us?"

Catra looked up from the meal she hadn't really touched, looking at Scorpia and Entrapta. "Isn't your extra bedroom Entrapta's lab?"

"I moved my stuff into my room." Entrapta shrugged. "It makes more sense than having two rooms to myself."

"Maybe it would help you with getting to work and stuf f," Scorpia added. "W e're definitely closer to downtown than your moms' house."

"Did they put you up to this?"

"W e *di d* ask them if they thought it'd be a good idea." Good old Entrapta. Always honest. "They weren't really sure. W e decided to offer anyway."

"I don't know . Let me think about it."

"T ake all the time you need, Wildcat."

Catra *di d* think about it for several days. Then she almost ran into Marlena on her way to work one afternoon. She texted Scorpia and Entrapta that night to accept their offer.

"Y ou know I can't guarantee consistent rent, right?" Catra asked as they helped pack and move her room. Most of her belongings were still in boxes from the dorms, so it was mostly just moving things to the car.

"W e know, it's okay," Scorpia assured her . "W e're already covering things just fine on our own. Don't worry about it."

"Y ou should probably budget for your own groceries, though," Entrapta added. "I don't think our diets are compatible."

And that was where Catra found herself, just a year after Adora's death. Fired from her last shitty job for telling someone to fuck herself after she threw her drink on Catra (who now reeked of sweet, sickening alcohol), and on her way home. She was taking the long way around to try and cool off, lest she accidentally snap at Scorpia and Entrapta. They were great friends and roommates, but Catra only had so much patience.

The night was mostly quiet. It was late – for some reason she had *stayed* to finish her shift even after the manager had fired her. Her tips had been severely lacking, but that was no surprise. She never got many anyway.

A loud cracker of thunder shattered the silent air.

Catra's head snapped up, eyes wide, as a beam of light struck the top of a nearby building. It wasn't lightning. There was no sign of a storm anywhere. The air definitely smelled a little *of f*now, but that wasn't a weather thing. *Oh christ.*

She scaled the closest wall and jumped roofs to reach the building. It didn't seem like many others had noticed it, or at the very least, they weren't acknowledging it. The weather *had* been doing some freaky things lately. Catra launched herself to the roof, skidding against the cement as she landed, and only belatedly thinking to pull her hood up to hide her face, just in case.

There was a huddled figure on the ground, clothed in white, including a mask and a hood. Catra felt like someone had stolen her look. She took a few cautious steps without saying anything, claws out. The figured groaned, picking itself up and yanking the mask off. Blonde hair spilled over broad shoulders, and Catra felt her entire world turn upside down.

"*Adora*?"

Chapter End Notes

OK Y. Congratulations, you survived the worst parts.

Now the bad news: I'm running into this without any support chapters, so updates may not be as frequent as I usually like to do. But this story WILL get told. I am determined.

So um. Review, maybe? Knowing people are interested would really help.

Let Go

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora deal with things. Not necessarily well.

Chapter Notes

Y'all are awesome and the reply to the first two chapters was amazing. Thank you so much <3 The good news is we're passed the major character death - that's not a fake-out, I swear. I want people to be able to read and enjoy their angst without worrying someone is going to die out of nowhere.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora felt like a sock that had been run through a dryer. Twice.

She curled up on the hard ground, trying to ease the pounding in her head. Had someone drugged her? What had *happened*? She sat up, rubbing her head and pulling her mask off. The city skyline was familiar – Bright Moon. Well that was—

"*Adora*?"

Every single brain cell in Adora's head froze. Her mouth fell open, her mind shutting down. That voice. It couldn't be…

She turned slowly to the source. It was a young woman, a hood covering most of her head. But Adora would know those shining yellow and blue eyes anywhere. *She had died*. That was the only explanation. There had been a terrible accident, and she had died, and—

Catra ripped her hood off and stormed over. Adora saw the moonlight glinting off her claws, and reacted instinctively – she aimed a web shooter at one of her hands, hoping to stop her. She

swung, cutting the webbing off, and her other hand shot out to grab Adora by the hood, dragging her up.

"What kind of fucking *joke* is this?" she snarled. Adora was momentarily stunned by how *strong* she was, then realized she had more immediate problems. She jerked her knee up, catching Catra in the stomach. The hand released Adora, letting her tumble to the ground again. She rolled to avoid having claws slice through her. Years of sparring with Catra had taught Adora a few things. Like how fast she was at follow-up attacks. Adora rolled to stand, aimed, and shot a strand of web. It caught Catra in the chest, and Adora dragged her forward, forcing her to her knees. Catra grabbed the web and pulled Adora down as well, and suddenly there were claws at her throat.

"I'm going to ask *one more time*," she growled, expression dark and dangerous. "What. The. *Fuck*."

Adora clenched her fist and swung, hitting Catra in the cheek. The claws nicked Adora's neck as Catra was forced away. She didn't draw blood, at least. "That's *my* line," she said, bracing the string of web so Catra couldn't pull again. "Who are you?"

"Who are *you*?" Catra snapped back, cutting through the web and stumbling back up. Her eyes widened after a beat, and the claws were at Adora's throat again, closer and somehow sharper. "You're that *fucking* assassin, aren't you? How did you find out about me?"

"Uh?" Adora's brain stalled again, leaving her baffled.

"Don't fucking play with me, I swear I'll—"

"I'm not—not a *shape-shifting assassin*," Adora stuttered. "Is that a thing?"

Something twitched in Catra's expression. She stepped back, claws still flexing. "Then *who are you*?"

Adora rubbed her throat, stepping back as well. "My name's Adora."

"Bullshit," Catra spat. "Adora's *dead*."

Oh. *Oh.* Adora swallowed, staring at her for a long moment. "So is Catra," she said finally in a low voice. Confusion flashed in Catra's eyes. "Do you know anything about Shadow Weaver? Hordak?"

"What—Hordak's that asshole politician. Who the fuck is *Shadow Weaver*?"

Adora thought again about what had happened before she'd ended up here. "Okay. Um. I wish Bow was here, he knows way more about this stuff than I do. There's um...there's this thing...something about multiple universes existing—"

"Parallel to one another and a new one is made every time we make a decision?" Catra guessed.

Adora nodded. "You know about it?"

"It's the multiverse theory. I assume most people at least *know* about it," Catra said with a scoff. "Eternia Labs has a whole project based on it, Entrapta's been following everything."

"You know Entrapta?" Adora asked.

"*You* know Entrapta?"

"I guess I know *an* Entrapta." Oh boy was that going to get confusing. Catra glared at her for a moment, then grabbed her arm, twisting it. "Ow! Hey, what—"

She was staring very closely at the web-shooters. "She made these for you, didn't she? But that design is..." Her voice drifted off, mind clearly working fast.

"Catra's," Adora said softly. "She designed everything."

Catra glared at her, then let her go and took her jacket off, throwing it at Adora. "Put this on, you look stupid. And stay close. I'm not going looking for your dumb ass if you get lost."

Adora caught the jacket, blinking. "What. Where are we going?"

"Just move."

Entrapta and Scorpia just stared. Catra had her hands shoved in her pockets, her teeth gritted, as she waited for someone to break the silence.

"Well?" she finally prompted.

"Um." Scorpia's voice cracked. "*Wow*. This is... wow."

"This is *fascinating*," Entrapta breathed, wide-eyed. She produced a measuring tape from somewhere and hurried over to Adora to start taking measurements. "You look exactly like our Adora! Except she kept her hair up most of the time—"

"Oh, um. I do too," Adora stuttered. "I just, ya know, take it down for the mask."

"Right, right!" Entrapta examined the suit critically. "I made this, didn't I? It's very similar to Catra's. So *you're* the spider person in your universe? How did it happen?"

Catra felt no qualms about abandoning Adora to her fate. She walked to the fridge to get a bottle of water, draining half of it in one sip.

"Uh. Catra – my Catra and I were down in an old subway tunnel. I don't know how the spider got there."

"Is there an Eternia Labs in your universe?"

"I've never heard of it, but that doesn't mean much," her words were muffled when Entrapta stuck a swab in her her mouth. "What do you do?"

"Taking a DNA sample to compare it against our Adora's."

"You have Adora's DNA?" Catra asked skeptically.

"I have *everyone's* DNA. I always knew something like this would happen."

And with that, she ran off to her room, closing the door behind her.

"Uh, sorry about that," Scorpia said with a nervous chuckle. "She's just, like that."

"It's fine," Adora said faintly. "This is all kind of crazy anyway. Might as well add Entrapta to that."

Scorpia smiled weakly, then looked at Catra. "So, what are we going to do?"

"*We're* not going to do anything," Catra said. "Entrapta is going to figure out a way to send her own home, and we're going to go back to our lives."

"Uh," Entrapta poked her head out of her room. "Did you just say I'm going solve the mystery of traveling between universes?"

"I mean, yeah, can't you?"

"Not without millions and millions of dollars in equipment. If I could break into Eternia Labs, maybe…"

"No one is breaking into the labs," Scorpia said. "Let's be reasonable about this."

"I *am* being reasonable," Catra said. "Reasonable about getting her out of here."

"Let's get some sleep," Scorpia said quickly. "It's late. And don't you have work tomorrow?"

"Nope."

Scorpia sighed, looking put out. She knew Catra got fired again. She didn't have to ask. "Well talk more in the morning, then. Um… Adora? Do you want blankets or something?"

Catra turned and walked into her room, barely not slamming the door, to avoid hearing Adora's voice again. This was insane. She had an Adora from *another universe* in her fucking living room, and she had to try and sleep like everything was normal. For the first time in a year, she was tempted to take out the suit and web shooters and go for a hop through the city. But no. She couldn't do that. She just changed and crawled into bed, yanking the covers over her head. Maybe the fake would be gone in the morning.

She was *not* gone in the morning.

In fact, she was snoring *loudly* on the couch when Catra stepped out of her room. Catra just stared at her in muted disgust. Scorpia was in the kitchen, making waffles. "She doesn't seem that bad," she whispered to Catra. "Kind of like—"

"Don't. Say. It." Catra didn't want to hear the comparison. Didn't think she could stand to hear it. She just needed to get this girl *out of here* without causing some crisis, and everything would be fine.

Her phone rang. She fumbled to silence it, then grimaced when she realized it was Lyra. Not sending her to voicemail or she'd be on their doorstep in an hour.

"Mama."

"*Hey sweetie. Are you busy tonight?*"

"Um, yes." Her mom didn't need to know she'd lost her job. "Working all day and night. Scorpia and Entrapta are really pushing me for rent."

Scorpia looked offended. "*Everything okay?*" Glimra asked. "*If you need help you know I command Glare*—"

"No, it's fine," Catra said quickly. "They're not going to kick me out tomorrow or anything. I just need some extra money. Maybe try to start a savings account, you know?"

"*If you're sure*," Glimra said uncertainly. "*What about tomorrow night? We'd really like to see you. It's been awhile.*"

Catra started to protest that it hadn't been *that* long, but...yeah, it had been a month. "I think I'm free tomorrow night. I'll double check the schedule and let you know."

"*Check soon.*" That was Glimra-speak for "I want to know in an hour." Catra ran a hand through her hair, sighing.

"I will. I promise. Love you."

"*Love you too.*"

Catra ended the call, sighing. "You're not going to tell her you lost your job?"

"Not today. She's already worried—"

"You have a mom?"

Oh. The snoring had stopped. Catra turned to look at Adora, who was watching her with wide, uncertain eyes.

"Yeah. You don't?"

Adora shook her head. "Catra and I grew up in a group home."

Well, now Catra felt like an ass. "Oh." She rubbed the back of her head. "Sorry ."

"It' s okay." Adora shrugged. "It' s not like we really knew anything better. Did I... mean, she?..."

Catra looked away, ears falling. "Y eah. She did."

Blessedly , Adora got the message, and shut up. "All right," Catra said after a moment. "W e need figure out how to get her home."

"Y ou really think Entrapta can solve travel between universes?" Scorpia asked doubtfully, flipping the waffle maker and carefully getting it out onto a plate. "Hey , Otherdora, you want a waffle?"

Catra did her best not to snort. *Otherdora* . That was pretty good. Adora blinked a few times. "Um... no. No thank you."

"When was the last time you ate?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow . Adora hesitated long enough for her to say, "Give her a waf fle," before going about making her own breakfast. She could feel Adora's stare on her back, and ignored it steadfastly. Waffles were okay, but eggs and bacon were way better. "Anyway , Entrapta is smart. She can do it."

"But without access to a particle accelerator ," Entrapta said as she stepped out of her room.

"Eternia Labs has one. W e can break in."

"Uh, Wildcat? Maybe we should figure something out before we go straight to commit crimes." Scorpia gave Adora her waf fle and an apologetic smile. "Sorry , she's a little"...

"Look, I'm sure Adora wants to get home. I'm not being unreasonable. I'm just trying to find a way to help her ."

"Okay ," Scorpia said slowly . "But you can't just break into a highly secure government facility."

"We went on a *field trip* there in junior year."

"*You* did. I wasn't in that class, and Entrapta was banned as a potential security risk, remember?"

"My point is," Catra flipped the bacon as she spoke. "That this doesn't have to be difficult."

"I would need more than a few hours to figure out how to work a particle accelerator," Entrapta added. "Plus, there might be a bigger problem."

"What other problems could we *possibly* have?"

"Well... how did she get here in the first place? It's a pretty big leap from 'prove the existence of alternate universes' and bring another person here from one.'"

Oh. Catra scowled at the stove. Okay, yeah, that was probably a big deal and something they had to worry about. "Is that really our problem?" she insisted weakly.

"Maybe not, but if the world is ending, it *might* be an issue."

"Okay, *that's* a bit of a leap," Catra said. Entrapta shrugged.

"Parallel universes are *parallel* for a reason. If they start to collide..." she made an exploding motion with her hands and sound effects. "I'm not saying it's absolutely going to happen, but it's probably something someone should look into."

"Sounds like a problem for Eternia Labs," Catra grumbled, going back to her food.

"But if they're the ones causing the problems, they're not going to admit it. And how would you even tell them? 'Hi, this alternate version of my dead girlfriend showed up last night, can you figure out why?'"

Catra snarled, whirling to glare at Entrapta. "She was *not* —look, just figure it out, okay?! I don't fucking care how!"

She abandoned the stove and stormed out of the apartment, ignoring the looks she was getting. Entrapta *knew* —how could she even say something like that? Great, this was just great. She didn't have a job, she couldn't go to her moms' now, and there was absolutely no one she could talk to who would possibly understand what she was going through.

Actually... that wasn't completely true.

She didn't go to the cemetery often. It was depressing, and anyway, Marlena and Randor visited a couple times a month. Catra hadn't been able to even look at their *house* since Adora died, never mind seeing *them*.

But it was fairly early in the day, on a weekday, and they were probably busy. The graveyard was empty when she walked through the gates, and she let out a sigh of relief.

"Hey Adora," she murmured, stopping in front of the gravestone with her hands shoved in her pockets, kicking at the ground. "You uh… staying out of trouble?"

This was the other reason she never came to the cemetery. She didn't know what the fuck to do. It's... it's kind of crazy. I've been wishing you were here, and now..." She chuckled weakly. "Fucking monkey paw wish, huh?"

She sighed, resting her face in her hands. "I don't know what to do. I know *you* would help, but... what can I even do? This is way beyond me. And she... you… *she*... how am I supposed to look at her?"

Looking at her hurt. *Thinking* about her hurt. Acknowledging her existence hurt. *Everything* about it —about *her* —hurt. But she was going to be here longer if Catra didn't help her find a way home. And

it wasnt like there was anywhere else she could go in this universe. The idea of her just sleeping on their couch forever made Catra physically sick.

"What do Ido?"

She already knew the answer. She *hated* it, but she knew it.

Scorpia and Entrapta had left for the school, leaving Adora with the TV and remote and a brief rundown of how to use it, as if her universe didnt have television. They could've left a channel list, though.

The door opened;Adora jumped, sitting up and looking at Catra. She narrowed her eyes slightly. "Did Iseriously design that suit? t looks awful."

Adora huffed, offended. "*M* Catra designed it, yes. And she was really proud of it, and *I* like it."

Catra had the good grace to look sheepish. "Y eah. Sorry. The design isnt actually that bad, it' s the colors that are killing me. Arent you supposed to be staying under the radar?"

"Oh, that' s easy."

She camo-ed, and grinned when Catra tilted her head, clearly confused. "What the hell?"She moved left and right, as if trying to change her view.

"Camouflage."Adora let herself fade back into view . "Catra could always tell where Iwas, but it' s good enough to completely hide from people with regular eyesight."

"Barre,"Catra said, but she sounded impressed. She made her way to her room, talking over her shoulder. "dont suppose you can share it with other people?"

"never managed to, no."

"Shame. Good thing I'm not a giant show off and know how to blend in."

"Rude," Adora said, scoffing. "What's so special about you?"

"I wear black and red, not *white and gold*. We're going to have to break in to Eternia Labs and find out if they actually know anything about how you ended up here. I'm sure the security is ramped up at night."

"And what are we going to do if we find something?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

"What I do best – wing it."

Catra would never admit that she missed swinging through the city like this. It was just... amazing. She had to slow down for Adora, who didn't know the way to Eternia Labs, but they still made pretty good time.

"Whoa," Adora whispered, landing on a tree limb beside Catra. Even at night, mostly dark, the building was still a sight to behold. "So what makes you guys think the answer is here?"

"Well, they're the number one lab in scientific advancements. They hire the smartest people in the entire world, and give them an unlimited budget. If you had all the money in the world, a super brain, and didn't have to worry about consequences, what would you do?"

Adora tilted her head, thinking for a minute. "Time travel," she said finally. Funny, Catra was thinking the same thing.

"Someone in there is probably working on it." They paused, watching a security car roll by. "If something is messing with universes, it's

definitely here."

"Okay . So how do we get in?"

"I mean, I've never tried to break in. I'm guessing here." Catra nodded to the roof. "Let's try and find a vent or something."

They swung up to the roof, and found something even better than a vent — a *door*. "Excellent," Catra said, strolling over .

"You think they don't have locks on the door?" Adora asked skeptically. Catra slid a kit out of some unknown pocket. She had pockets? Adora was jealous.

"I think I learned how to lockpick a few years ago because I was bored."

"Oh. That works too, I *guess* ."

Catra rolled her eyes, working intently, ears twitching as she listened for…

Click!

"There." She stood, swinging the door open, and made sure her hood was secure and started down the stairs. Adora stayed close. "Is your night vision garbage?" Catra whispered as they walked.

"It's better than a regular human's!" Adora protested, pouting under her mask.

"But not as good as mine." Catra was smug. Adora rolled her eyes, giving her a light shove.

"Get over yourself."

They both froze on the steps, realizing how weirdly familiar and comfortable that interaction had been. Catra snarled, pushing her way forward. Adora jogged to keep up.

They didn't talk much once they were in the building. Adora camo-ed and made her way forward a bit, looking into office through the glass walls. "What are we looking for?" she finally whispered.

"My money is on the particle accelerator , so let's start with that."

"Right. Of course. Just look for a particle accelerator . No big deal."

She had no idea what a particle accelerator looked like. Catra almost laughed. "It was on the third floor when we came here for the field trip. The lead scientist was a lady named Hope. Jesus, that felt like another life. Hope. Dr . Hope."

"That's suspiciously optimistic."

"Yeah I don't necessarily believe in fate and all that, but that's a hell of a name for a scientist."

Adora camo-ed and slipped ahead, looking for any signs of life. She saw a guard turning the corner and flattened herself against the wall, looking back down the hall. Catra must have jumped somewhere out of sight. They waited until the guard was gone, and Catra crawled along the ceiling to meet Adora.

"Not bad," she whispered, dropping down to stand with her .

"You can say you're impressed, it won't kill you," Adora whispered back. She could tell Catra was rolling her eyes, even if she couldn't see her face.

They moved down to the next floor , Catra trying to retrace the steps she had taken years ago, the first time she'd seen the particle accelerator. The room they finally arrived at was locked, of course. Adora looked up, then tapped Catra's shoulder, pointing to the vent. Catra nodded, climbing up to pull the vent grate out, and they went in.

"Her computer probably has a password," Adora whispered as they crawled.

"Got that covered. Do you remember when Entrapta said she wasn't allowed to go on this field trip while we were in school?"

"Mmhm."

"She was deemed a security risk because she has a record with the FBI."

Adora blinked a few times, trying to figure out if she'd heard that correctly. "She what?"

"When she was twelve, she looked up how to make a nuclear bomb. Did you know they monitor that kind of stuff? She swears she wasn't going to make one, but it's always a little iffy with her."

"So they didn't let her come because she googled nuclear bombs?"

"No, the more concerning thing on the record was hacking into the federal government tax system when she was fifteen. On a dare."

What the hell. "How is she not in jail or some black site?"

"Really rich parents with a really good lawyer, and she's on forever probation. Agents can just knock on her door whenever and take her computer to make sure she hasn't been doing anything that might be dangerous. She's only allowed to have one desktop and one laptop, and she's on the no-fly list."

"Do. Do agents actually come and check on her?"

"I moved in with them four months ago and it's already happened once."

That was... scarily impressive. "But what does that have to do with us getting into this computer?"

They dropped out of the vent and into the office; Catra produced a USB stick from somewhere. "Obviously she doesn't want to risk getting sent to some black site or whatever, so she abides by her probation for the most part. But if I ask really nice and let her use my stuff, sometimes I can get her to do things. Like create a little stick that'll automatically download everything on the hard drive, and all I have to do is…"

She plugged it into the tower with a flourish.

"So your big idea was to get Entrapta to do all the hard work?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow. Catra scoffed.

"She has like eight of these things just sitting around waiting to be needed. *We* did all the hard work breaking in here and—"

Something pinged in the back of both their minds. Adora camo-ed without thinking, and Catra hopped to the ceiling to hide. They watched another guard start to walk by, and waited for him to go. But he didn't. He'd noticed the computer screen in the office had turned on.

"*Fuck*," Catra hissed, pressing closer to the ceiling. Adora held her breath as he let himself into the office and walked over to the screen, frowning at it. There was a data box loading, but it didn't say what it was doing. The man pressed the talk button on his walkie talkie.

"Hey, one of the computers up on the third floor is doing something weird. Like it's trying to load something."

Catra looked at the screen, grimacing. It was so *close*. Just a little more…

The walkie talkie crackled before someone answered. "*It's probably updating something. Don't touch it. You know how they get when someone plays with their toys.*"

The security guard snorted. "T rue. A right, I m on my way down to two."

He left. They waited for a moment to make sure he didn't come back, and let out a long breath. Catra dropped back to the floor to check the computer.

"H w do we know we're getting the right information?" Adora asked, looking at all the other offices on the floor.

"W e don't. I m going of f information that's years old and just hoping I m right."

"Seriously?" Adora' s whisper was nearly hysteric. "That' s your plan? t' s awful!"

"I don't hear you coming up with anything better!"

The USB stick finished, and Catra hurriedly snatched it out of the tower. "Come on, let' s get out of here."

Adora started to follow her out, then paused, looking at a picture on the desk. "Is this her?" she asked, picking up the frame. Catra stepped back to look at it. There were two women – one tall, with long platinum blonde hair, pale skin, and a stern expression. Beside her was a darker skinned woman, up to about the tall woman's shoulder, her hair braided, her smile practically radiant.

"The tall one, yeah. Put that down, we gotta go."

All and all, it was *amazingl y* easy. Catra was almost giddy as they jumped off the roof and began swinging back to the apartment. "I never thought I'd be committing crimes," Adora grumbled as they swung. Catra snorted.

"V igilantism is a crime, genius."

"Okay , I know , but like. There's a difference between that and breaking into a government laboratory to steal data."

t’ s all for the greater good.”

They landed on the fire escape outside of Catra’s room and climbed in. Catra yanked her mask off, shaking her head and blowing out a long breath. “Man, havent worn this thing in forever . Iforgot how suffocating it is.”

The door to the bedroom burst open. “Do you have it, do you have it, do you have it?” Entrapta asked eagerly .

“W ere you listening at the door?”

“Y ou told me not to go into your room when you arent home. I waited.”

“Guess Icant get too annoyed if youre listening to me.” Catra went to her desk and grabbed her laptop, handing that and the USB stick over. Entrapta flopped down on the bed, opened the laptop, and got to work.

“I was looking at your web shooters last night,” she told Adora as she worked. “Theyre remarkably similar to the ones Imade, and not just in the design. Ithink the web fluid might even be stronger than mine.”

“I definitely almost ripped a hole in our bedroom wall,” Adora said slowly. “But yeah. Our —My Entrapta, Iguess, made the web fluid. Catra designed the web shooters.”

“It’ s *f asi nat ng* how similar and different things are. Your web shooters are the same even though your outfits are completely different, and both were designed by a version of Catra. The web fluid was created by a version of me and is almost identical. Do you know me in your world?”

“Only a little,” Adora admitted, blushing slightly . “Y ou were more Catra’s friend.”

"That also tracks with this universe," Entrapta said with a nod.

"How long is this going to take?" Catra grumbled. She really didn't want to talk about this. Or hear about it. Or think about it ever again.

"To go through all this data?" Entrapta asked, tilting her head. "Hours at least. Maybe days."

"*Days*?" Catra repeated, voice cracking. "Are you serious? We don't have days! Especially if we have to go *back* for more! Aren't you the one who was talking about universes colliding?!"

"I'm going as fast as I can, but your computer isn't quite built for this kind of work. If I could use *my* stuff—"

"I'm still not convinced the government doesn't have your computer bugged or something."

"They don't. I've checked."

Catra sighed, pressing her hand against her face. "Okay, but using your computer is still a bad idea. Just...take my laptop and do whatever you need to do. Somewhere that isn't my bed. I'm going to sleep."

"I'll be up all night with this data," Entrapta said excitedly, bouncing away. "Otherdora, you can have my bed."

Catra paused halfway through ushering them out. "Wait, what's the plan if the FBI knocks on the door?"

"I've installed a kill switch on your computer that'll wipe it and the USB stick clean. Completely unrecoverable. No one will ever know."

"Y... ou know what, that's fine. Good night."

Catra wasn't really surprised to see Entrapta was still awake when she got up the next morning. There were probably four less Red

Bills in the fridge, and in another eighteen hours or so, Entrapta would crash and sleep for three days.

"How's it going?"

"Still working on it. But I've found a couple of things that may be of use." Catra grabbed a bottle of water, motioning for Entrapta to continue. "She's definitely still working on the particle accelerator. It looks like they wanted to shut down the project a few years ago, and she got *very* upset about it. Which I can understand, it's awful when you're working on something and someone tells you that you can't anymore. The people in charge basically said that there was no funding left for it, but suddenly *poof*, money appeared! And there are a lot of emails between her and some throwaway account about her work."

"How do you know it's a throwaway?"

"Well, I haven't confirmed it yet I guess, but usually people use more than a string of numbers for their usernames."

Catra tilted her head, ear twitching. Weird. "Do you think it's the person who made money appear?"

Entrapta shrugged. "Can't say for sure. But it would make sense. The communication started right around the time the project was restarted, and the messages involve a lot of updates."

"Hmm." Catra leaned over the back of the couch to look at the laptop like she could understand any of it. "Anything else?"

"Not yet. But I'm off today, so I can spend the entire day working on it. It's so exciting!"

Entrapta's bedroom door opened, and Adora stumbled out, yawning. It was her second day in this universe, and she'd been wearing that suit the entire time.

"You need clothes." Catra didn't realize she'd said it out loud until Entrapta and Adora were both looking at her.

"What?" Adora said stupidly.

"You've been wearing that stupid suit *and* sleeping in it since you got here. We need to find some other clothes for you."

"I'd offer something," Entrapta said, looking back at the laptop, "but I don't think we're the same size."

Yeah, that was a problem. Scorpia was definitely too tall, and Catra and Entrapta were too short. Catra had *just* lost her job; there was no way she was going to waste money on this woman.

"I'm fine," Adora said, rubbing the back of her head. "I wear it under my clothes a lot. It's not like I'm not used to it."

"Yeah, but you need a break from it eventually." Catra had worn it under her clothes a lot too. The chafing was the *worst*. "Maybe—"

She was interrupted by her phone going off, and checked the caller ID. *Mama* was displayed on the screen. "Fuck," she grumbled, taking a deep breath. She seriously considered sending it to voicemail, but that might end with Lyra knocking on the door. "Hi Mama."

"*Hi sweetie. Did you check your schedule for tonight?*"

Catra pressed the heel of her palm into her forehead. *Fuck*. She didn't have time for *dinner* when the universe might be ending. "I, um." Her gaze fell on Adora, and an absolutely terrible thought entered her mind. "No. I mean, yeah, I did, I'm not working. What time?"

"*Eight. I'm working late.*"

"Yeah. That'll be fine. See you tonight. Love you." She ended the call, let out a deep breath, and said, "Okay. I think I figured out the clothing problem."

"Oh, really?" Entrapta looked up, truly interested in the conclusion Catra had managed to come to in that short conversation. "What's your plan?"

"Honestly? I don't want to talk about it."

She went back to her room, flopping into bed and burying her face in her pillow. She just wanted to sleep or scream.

There wasn't much to do, aside from watching Entrapta work. Scorpia emerged at some point, saying, "I've got plans with Perfuma, but she'll understand if I need to cancel. I mean, if you guys need me here."

"No," Catra called from her room. "Go to your drum circle or whatever. Just don't tell her about this. I don't need her coming over and trying to therapize me again. I *will* bite."

"Yes ma'am."

Entrapta didn't seem to notice anything else going on around her. She was typing rapidly, watching things move on the screen. Adora was restless; she bustled around the apartment for a bit, deciding to check the cabinets for food and try to make lunch.

"Do *not*," Catra said from the door of her room. Adora jumped, startled, and let her hand fall away from the cabinet.

"Why?"

"Do you know how to boil an egg?"

"Um. How hard could it be?"

"*That's* why." Catra walked over to start checking the cabinets herself. "You have no idea how to cook, do you?"

"No," Adora grumbled. "But I'm good at learning."

"You're not learning at the risk of the security deposit. Do you like grilled cheese?"

"Oh...um, sure." Not really, but she didn't want to be difficult. Catra looked her over for a long, long moment.

"How about ham or turkey?"

How the hell did she do that? "Ham is good," Adora said, clasping her hands behind her back and rocking on her heels.

"Can I have grilled cheese?" Entrapta called from the living room.

"Sure."

Adora watched Catra get the butter, cheese, ham, and turkey out, juggling all three. "There, I can *make* a sandwich," she said, taking the turkey.

"*Fine*, people pleaser. Can you get the bread out?"

"Sure."

They worked in tandem, with Catra getting the grilled cheese going first. Adora went back and forth to the fridge to get condiments, and together they managed to put together a basic lunch. Adora cut her's and Catra's sandwiches in two, and Catra cut the grilled cheese in eight.

"You cut it wrong," Catra said with a scoff, taking her plate and Entrapta's and bring Entrapta's food to her. "Who cuts in *triangles*?"

"I do," Adora said. "How *else* would you cut a sandwich?"

"In *half*, like a normal person. How does someone eat a sandwich like this?"

That didn't *stop* her, of course. She bit off the corners as if to make the sandwiches the right *shape* before she ate it. There was nothing

malicious about it; if anything, it was almost *playful*. Adora stuck her tongue out in response.

"I *did* cut it in half. That's half."

"It's the *wrong* half. Seriously, triangles?"

"Yes! They're easy to hold without getting your fingers messy. Where do you hold a rectangle?"

"By the corners!" Catra said, exasperated. "What kind of savage sandwiches do you make in your universe?"

"Oh my god, you're so dramatic."

Entrapta looked up from her work to grab a piece of her sandwich, eyes flitting between the two. She'd spent many, many lunch periods with Catra and Adora in high school. And while most would think she wasn't paying attention, she was actually very observant. It's not that one *needed* to be observant to see the obvious ways Catra and Adora had flirted throughout the years.

This wasn't quite that. But it was very similar. Entrapta made a note to herself, finished her tiny sandwich bite, and went back to her work.

They finished their food and sat in a silence that was almost comfortable. Catra was curled up on the couch next to Entrapta, pressed into the corner and half dozing. Adora took the dishes and cleaned up the kitchen, because she hated having nothing to do. Catra still hadn't said anything about her plan to get Adora some actual clothes, and it was making Adora *slightly* anxious. What was she planning on stealing? That didn't sit well with Adora. This Catra seemed very cavalier about things like laws. That was just a first impression though, and those could be wrong. Maybe Adora had just gotten the wrong idea about her. They hadn't started off on the best foot, after all.

"So," she said slowly. Catra opened one eye to look at her. "How did you um, you know"…

She waved her hands, wiggling her fingers slightly. Catra raised an eyebrow. "Get spider powers?" she translated. Adora nodded. "At Eternia Lab, actually. Never saw the experimental spider room, but I guess one escaped. You?"

"Spider bite in a subway tunnel. Our guardian kicked us out of the house for the day, um, my Catra was really artistic."

"So am I," Catra argued.

"Right, of course," Adora said quickly. "She just had different ways of expressing it."

"Graffiti artist?" Entrapta guessed.

"Yeah. She found this place in the back of the tunnels that hadnt been touched yet, and we spent all day there while she was working." Adora smiled fondly at the memory. "She was really good at it. And she had this cute little cartoon face that she would draw as her signature"…

Catra tilted her head, then tapped Entrapta's shoulder, gesturing for the notebook and pen on the table. Entrapta handed it over, and Catra quickly scribbled something down before turning it to show Adora. "Like this?"

Adora looked it over, shocked. "Yeah. That's almost exactly it. Catra's was a little spikier."

Catra drew something else before showing it again. Along with Catra's cartoon-y face was Adora's. "Her parents got her bunk beds when we were kids because Ispent a lot of nights over there. We drew these on the side of the bunk during one of our sleepovers."

"That sounds like something Catra would've done." Adora laughed. "Shadow Weaver would've been so mad, though."

Catra looked at the notebook, then at Adora. "How old were you when she?..".

It was a very personal question. Catra wouldn't blame her for not answering. Adora's smile faded; she closed her eyes and looked away. "Seventeen," she whispered, voice trembling. "She never got out of Weaver's home."

They pretended not to notice Adora wiping her eyes. "What about you guys?" she asked quietly after a moment. "I mean, when"…

Entrapta looked between them, then back at her laptop. "Nineteen," Catra said, curling up on herself. "Just last year."

"Oh." Adora wouldn't admit it under threat of death, but she was a little jealous. This universe's Catra and Adora had gotten two extra years, *and* good lives with good families who loved them. Meanwhile Adora's universe just continuously kicked them while they were down. How was that fair?

They were saved from the suddenly awkward silence by the laptop dinging. Entrapta leaned in to type, and something popped up. "Oh, *that* is interesting"…

"What is it?" Catra asked, immediately uncurling to look over Entrapta's shoulder.

"It looks like Dr. Hope's been working off hours. She has notes from a test run of the accelerator that she ran the night Otherdora got here."

"That would be one hell of a coincidence if they aren't related."

"The odds are almost astronomical," Entrapta agreed. "There's still a lot more to go through. I'll try to have more results when you get

back from your moms'."

Catra smiled wryly, nudging Entrapta's shoulder. "Thanks, nerd."

"Really ," Adora added quickly . "Thank you."

All of this was to get *her* home, after all. The last thing she wanted was to seem ungrateful.

"So.what are we doing, exactly?"

"W alking down the street."

Adora rolled her eyes. She was camo-ed, so Catra wouldnt actually see the gesture, but she assumed it was implied in the momentary silence. "I kidding. Why am Igoing to your moms' place for dinner?"

"Y oure not. W ere just.making a pit stop for clothes, then you can head back to the apartment."

"And *where* are we getting clothes?" Catra didnt answer . "Catra. Where—"

"Look." They turned onto a street;Catra paused, running a hand through her hair. "t' s only been a year. Marlena and Randor havent gotten rid of any of Adora's stuff yet. Last Iknew , they hadnt even packed up her room."

"W ait. Were stealing from a dead girl?"

"ust.borrowing." Catra started down the street again. "And Adora wouldnt mind. She' s literally given people the shirt off her back before."

"Okay , but that's not the point!" Adora protested, hurrying after her .

"Look, itll be fine." Catra waved her of f. They stopped in front of a dark house with an empty driveway. "Excellent, theyre not even home. Come on."

"Im not *breaki ng i nto* someone else's house."

"It' s not breaking in, Ipractically grew up here. And Adora' s window doesnt lock."

Adora groaned, but followed Catra around to the backyard. She easily scaled the side of the house, then pushed the window open and crawled in. Adora followed reluctantly. She hated this.

"Can you see without light?" Catra whispered. Adora blinked a few times to adjust, then nodded. "Okay ." She carefully opened the closet door. "Just grab a couple things and we can get out of here."

She crossed her arms, looking uncomfortable, as if this entire thing hadnt been *her* idea. Adora didnt argue;she just started rifling through clothes, grabbing a sweatshirt, a pair of pants—

Something pinged in the back of her head. She looked around as Catra's head snapped up. The bedroom door burst open, and Adora let out a squeak as the lights turned on, momentarily blinding her . Silence followed.

"Catra?" a very confused voice said. Adora lowered her hand, squinting slightly . There was a woman standing in the door, baseball bat raised. She was a bit what Adora thought she herself would look like in twenty years or so. Long blonde hair falling down around her shoulders, eyes a weird mix of stormy gray and blue. She was wearing a nice, fluffy bathrobe, and unicorn slippers. They were adorable.

"M-Marlena," Catra stuttered. She was shaking, expression absolutely terrified. "What are you —I thought no one was home."

But the woman's gaze had already drifted to the second person in the room. A walking copy of her dead daughter. The baseball bat slipped from her hands, clattering loudly against the floor.

"Adora?"

Chapter End Notes

Will I ever stop ending chapters on the cliffhanger of someone saying Adora's name? Maybe.

Review? Tell me about your pain? Your joy? Whatever you feel after reading this?

(Again, not promising weakly reviews. This just happened to get done on the week mark lol)

Memories

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora deal with family and make plans.

Chapter Notes

The last like, four pages of this are completely unedited. Im so tired. t's nap time. but Iwanted to get this posted first. Im aware there might be spelling mistakes, please don't point them out.

Marlena Gray believed in a lot of things. eaven and ell and ghosts werent among those things.

And yet, there Adora was, standing beside Catra as always, wearing a very odd suit. Catra looked utterly horrified. Adora looked hesitant. She was chewing her lip, holding a sweatshirt and a pair of pants a little too tight in her hands. Marlena took a step forward, then another, half reaching for the copy of her daughter. She paused when the girl flinched back. t hurt to see. But it confirmed everything Marlena already knew.

"Y oure not my little girl."er voice wasnt accusatory , just quiet. A little sad. Adora shook her head.

"Im Im sorry ."She *sounded* exactly like Marlena remembered. A little older, maybe. A little more tired. But still Adora, through and through. Right down to apologizing for something that wasnt her fault.

"Who are you?"Again, no accusations. Marlena thought she was handling this quite well, all things considered. "What are you *weari ng*?"

"Im um.well, Im Adora. ust fr.om another universe."She groaned, hiding her face in the sweatshirt. "That sounds so *dumb*

when I say it out loud. "Hey, Catra, a little help?"

Catra hadn't moved an inch since Marlena had walked in. She was frozen in place, like a deer in headlights. Marlena turned to her, frowning. "Catra?" She *also* flinched, which was a little more unnerving. She'd never flinched away from Marlena. "What's wrong?"

She shook her head slowly, backing toward the window. "I'm, I— uh, I'm sorry—."

They watched in shock as she launched herself out the window. "Wha—hey!" Adora protested, voice cracking. She looked back at Marlena, lost, and a bit like she wanted to run away as well. It was a look very reminiscent of the time they had caught the girls sneaking a little bit of wine when they were fourteen.

Marlena sighed, scrubbing her face with one hand, and gave Adora a weak smile. "Why don't you get changed? I'll be back in a few—."

It was weird, and she knew it, but Marlena couldn't look at any version at her daughter—whether she raised her or not—and leave her helpless.

Catra had tried to run when she landed, but her knees went weak; instead she crashed to the ground in a shaking, gasping heap.

She had been careless. How had she not realized Marlena was home? The house was dark, their cars were gone, but she should have *heard* something, even if it was just Marlena moving around outside the room. How had she allowed herself to be surprised like that? She curled up on herself, back pressed against the house;her forehead was pressed against her knees, and she tangled her fingers in her hair, pulling just slightly. She couldn't breathe. She couldn't feel her fingers, or the way her claws dug just slightly into her scalp.

"Catra?"

Marlena knelt carefully beside her, resting a hand on her back. "You're okay. It's okay. Can you try and breathe with me?" Catra shook her head, trying to move away. She didn't get very far. "Catra"…

"Just…just leave me alone," she managed to gasp out, curling up tighter on herself. "I know you hate me."

"What?" Marlena sounded truly stunned by the thought. "Why would we"—

"Because of Adora!" Catra couldn't stand the sincerity in Marlena's voice. She'd rather hear accusations. Blame. *Anything* besides obvious concern. "Because I *left her* and she had to go and be a stupid hero and I couldn't save her and"—

That was all she had time to get out before Marlena crushed in a tight, warm hug. It stunned Catra out of her spiral. "Of *course* we don't blame you, sweetheart," Marlena whispered, rocking Catra just a little. "How could we?"

Catra finally managed to suck in a shallow breath, along with Marlena's scent. And with that came memories. She'd grown up in these arms, been carried to bed, hugged and held and worried over, and they'd always felt safe. As safe as her own mothers'. They were still safe.

She hadn't really *cried* for Adora. Not yet. She'd been angry, she had lashed out, she had been numb, but she had never cried. Not because she was *too strong* for that or whatever. There had just… never been tears for it. Even at her lowest, emptiest point, she hadn't been able to cry.

But here, in a place that felt safe, she finally broke. Every tear she hadn't shed in the last year poured through the broken dam, and all Catra could do was curl up and sob in Marlena's arms. Marlena held

her tighter, one hand brushing through her hair as she whispered, "It's okay. You're okay."

Catra shook her head weakly, clinging to Marlena's arm. No, it wasn't okay. It would never be okay again. Adora was gone, and it was *her fault*. How could Marlena not see that?

Marlena kissed the top of her head, carefully brushing her fingers through her hair and whispering more gentle words. Catra rested her head on Marlena's shoulder, sniffling as the tears finally slowed. "I'm sorry," she whispered again, her voice breaking. Marlena started to respond, but cut off at the sound of approaching footsteps.

"Marlena?" It was Light yra, with Cyra right behind her. "Catra? What's going on?"

Oh. This was going to be a lovely conversation.

Adora was sitting under the window, legs curled up to her knees, listening to everything going on outside. The sound of Catra crying had felt like a punch in the gut; Adora ducked her head to hide her face in her knees, wiping her tears away. It had only been a year. She remembered how *she* felt a year after Catra had died. It hadn't been nearly enough time. She didn't think there would ever be enough time.

The bedroom door opened, and Adora looked up, expecting Catra. But it was just Marlena, alone. And well. That was weird. And awkward.

"Where's Cat...um?"

"With her parents." Marlena sat down on the edge of the bed, hands resting in her lap. "They're right next door, don't worry. I think Light yra and Cyra just wanted a moment with Catra before trying to deal with...everything else."

"Oh." Yeah, that made sense. Adora looked down at the clothes she'd reluctantly put on, because she really *did* need a break from the suit. "If you um...don't mind me borrowing a bag, I can go. I know how to get back to the apartment."

"You can stay here until Catra's ready to leave."

The simple statement surprised Adora. She looked at Marlena for a long, uncertain moment. "I'm...I'm not her. You know that, right?"

Marlena hummed, her eyes falling on a framed photo on the wall. "Are you allergic to blueberries?" she asked after a moment. Adora blinked.

"Um...no?"

"My daughter was." Marlena laughed softly. "There's a neighbor down the street with blueberry bushes. They always let the kids pick as many as they wanted, and they knew she was allergic, but Catra would always sneak some out for her. They were just *so good*, she would say every time she came home, already swelling up. How could she not eat them, even if they hurt her?"

Adora saw the tears shining in Marlena's eyes, and respectfully looked away. Her gaze fell on the framed photos on the wall. Most of them were of Catra and Adora at different stages in their lives. They all looked so *happy*.

"I know you're not her," Marlena continued after a moment. "But she was a good person. She would never forgive me if I turned away from someone who needs help. I wouldn't forgive myself."

Oh. Well then. "I don't want to be a bother," Adora said, uncurling slightly. "I'll just...stay out of your way."

Marlena actually smiled, looking amused. "How about dinner? I'm guessing you haven't eaten much since...how long have you been here?"

"About two days."

Marlena looked absolutely horrified. "Let's get you food."

Adora smiled a little, standing to follow Marlena out of the room. "Catra mentioned, um...another...parent?" She had no idea what to refer to the man as. Marlena's husband? Adora's father? Both felt weird.

"Randor. He's on a business trip for a few days." Marlena smiled wryly. "I thought I'd have some quiet time, go to bed early, lie in bed with a book..."

Adora blushed, rubbing the back of her neck. "Sorry."

"Honestly, I'm just glad you're not a robber. I've been telling Randor for *years* he needs to fix that window. I'm pretty sure Catra broke it on purpose so she could sneak in."

Funny. Catra hadn't mentioned *that*. Adora laughed slightly as she sat at the kitchen table (waved off by Marlena) and watched the woman get to work.

"Do you have..." Marlena hesitated, focusing a little harder on the food than she needed to. "I mean, is there anyone waiting for you? Back home?"

"Not really." Adora dropped her gaze to the floor. "We um...we grew up in a foster home. Me and Catra, I mean. *Just* Catra, I mean. But she's...she's gone."

Marlena was quiet for a moment. "I'm so sorry," she said finally. "When?..."

"We were seventeen." Adora discreetly wiped her eyes. "It...it was my fault."

"I'm sure it—"

"No, it was." Adora curled again, resting her forehead on her knees. "We were investigating a street gang – she liked going out with me and helping because she was superior to humans and stuff." Adora rolled her eyes, smiling to herself. "And we were out one night, and... she was only there because of me."

"It sounds like she was there because she wanted to be," Marlena argued gently. Adora looked up at her. "If your Catra was anything like the girl I watched grow up, she wouldn't have been kept home even if you tried to make her."

That was... true. Catra would have just followed Adora without her knowing. She was never one to sit around and wait for others to do things. "I guess"...

Marlena set her spoon aside and went to kneel in front of Adora, resting her hands on her shoulders. "But everything has to be your fault. It's okay."

Adora smiled slightly despite herself. "How are you not freaking out?" she asked after a moment. Marlena laughed.

"Honestly? I'm losing my mind. But I've had a lot of practice staying calm during emergencies. If Randor were here, I'd probably be a little less composed."

A small, teary chuckle slipped off Adora's lips. Marlena smiled. This poor girl really needed a laugh.

Catra was curled up in the corner of the couch, her mothers sitting on the other side, waiting for an explanation as to why Catra had been crying in the Grays' backyard.

"There's something I need to tell you," she finally started quietly. "And... you're going to be mad."

"We wont," Cyra argued. Catra smiled humorlessly. If either of her mothers was going to have a complete conniption about this, it was Cyra.

"Yeah. Right. Just remember that." Catra shifted a little in place, looking anywhere but at her moms. She wasnt even sure how to say it. Hm. Hm uh. I—

"I know," Lyra blurted out, earning herself a stunned stare from her wife and daughter.

"You know what?" Catra asked slowly. Lyra's ears fell, but she didnt look away from Catra as she spoke.

"That youre Spider Cat."

"*What?*" Catra and Cyra screeched at the same time.

"How?" Catra added, bewildered. She had been so careful. How could Lyra possibly know?

"Is she *right*?" Cyra demanded, looking back at Catra.

"Yes," Catra said grudgingly. "But *how*?"

Lyra gave her a sad smile. "You and Adora werent exactly *quiet*, sweetheart. I heard her mention freaky spider powers when she was upset about getting wait-listed for BMU."

Catra opened and closed her mouth a few times, trying to wrap her head around this. "Fucking Adora," she finally managed to say.

"Language."

"*Why* wouldnt you tell me this?" Cyra demanded, looking at Lyra.

"It wasnt my secret to tell," Lyra said quietly but firmly. "I wanted Catra to trust us enough to come to us herself."

"Wait, wait, wait," Catra said. "Did you know I was stabbed, too?"

"You were *what*?!" her mothers shouted at the same time. Oops. Apparently not.

"Okay, no, fine, but—"

"Back up," Cyra demanded, standing. "You were *stabbed*? What happened? Did you go to a hospital or anything?"

"Um. I went to Adora."

"Adora wasn't a trained doctor!"

Definitely not telling them about being shot, Catra told herself. "I'm alive, aren't I?"

"Barely, apparently!" Cyra threw her hands up. "So this has just been going on for years, and *you*," that was said in her wife's direction, "and no one thought to mention it?"

"I quit after Adora died," Catra corrected her.

"I noticed the news about Spider Cat died down," Lyra said. "Why did you quit?"

Catra looked away, curling in on herself. "Because what good is a hero who can't save one girl."

Cyra flinched as her words were parroted back to her. "That's not. I didn't mean—"

"Yes, you did. And you were right. I'm fucking useless. I'd actually *been* with Adora instead of running around, I could've stopped her."

"That's not," Cyra protested weakly, looking at Lyra. She was just as stunned. In her wildest dreams, she never would have imagined that *this* was what Catra had been thinking all this time.

"I *i s*," Catra ground out, claws digging into her arms. Cyra carefully moved closer to her daughter, ignoring her when she pulled away, and grasping her hands.

"Catra." Her voice was low , shaking just slightly. "I'm not going to pretend that I approve of any of this. The idea of you going out and playing vigilante like that is terrifying." She gently started coaxing Catra to sheath her claws. "But what happened to Adora... it *was not* your fault."

"You—"

"I was angry . We loved Adora too. Losing her was hard. But I know you. And I know you would have done anything to save her ."

Tears burned in Catra's eyes again. She swallowed the lump in her throat, finally meeting Cyra's gaze. Her mothers had never lied to make her feel better. They had *wi l dl* different approaches, but they never lied. Lyra knelt on the floor beside them, resting a hand on Catra's arm.

"I tried," Catra finally whispered, her voice cracking.

"I know . We know." Cyra pulled her into a tight hug. "We know."

Adora tried to have *some* manners as she ate the meal Marlena had thrown together for her. It was just chicken and pasta, but it tasted *so good*. She usually cooked, but with finals closing in on them, she'd been busy, and takeout had been happening more often than usual. Their last conversation had been about the first meal he planned on cooking in over a week. Also, Marlena was just a *real l* good cook.

"Does anyone feed you?" She also sounded *s i ght y* concerned.

"Yeah, of course," Adora assured her quickly . "Just been a bit of a long month. I didn't eat much the day I got pulled here, and well"… She waved a hand vaguely. "But I'm not starving or anything," she

added quickly. Marlena looked extremely doubtful, but she was interrupted by the front door opening.

"Marlena?" Catra called. She sounded tired, and a little stuffy, like she had been crying.

"Kitchen."

Catra walked in, with two older Magicats behind her. Her mothers, Adora assumed. They both stopped, staring at Adora in shock. "Oh," Catra muttered. "Right. Um... Mom, Mama, this is... complicated."

"Adora?" one of them breathed. Adora rubbed the back of her head, wincing.

"Um... kind of. She's from another dimension. There's no short version of the story. Adora, these are my moms, Cyra and Lyra."

"Nice to meet you," Adora said awkwardly before shoveling more food in her mouth. The women exchanged looks, then turned back to Adora.

"You... You too," Lyra finally said. Thankfully, they were all saved from the awkwardness by Catra's phone ringing. She pulled it out, answered, and tapped the screen to the call on speaker.

"What's up, Entrapta?"

"*Are you still with your mom? Other Adora hasn't gotten back yet*"

"Yeah. Long story, but she's with me."

"*Oh, okay. Are you guys busy? If I might need going through that data you got.*"

Adora looked up from her meal, listening intently. Catra nodded. "Anything helpful?"

"*There's some absolutely fascinating*"—

Helpful first, fascinating later."

"*Oh, right.*" There was a brief pause, presumably as Entrapta did some scanning. "*It took a bit, but I finally tracked down the name of the person who re-funded the accelerator project to the late governor.*"

"Prime?" Catra frowned, running through her admittedly limited knowledge of the man. "Wasn't that asshole Hordak part of his cabinet?"

"*Right up until you raided the Horde building, yup. He mysteriously stepped down about a month after that, and no one's seen him since.*"

"Wait a sec," Cyra started, narrowing her eyes. "Weren't people injured during that raid?"

"Anyway," Catra said quickly, turning away from her mothers. "We never *did* figure out what he was doing with the money he took from the Horde. Is it possible it was all going to Prime? And what does Prime care about keeping the lab funded anyway?"

"*I don't know,*" Entrapta said. "*But he's been getting daily updates from the heads sitting on the Council. Speaking of which, do you know anyone named Mara Gay?*"

The name rang a bell, but Catra couldn't place it. She looked at Marlena, who had covered her mouth with a small gasp. "Randor's half sister," she said quietly. "Same father. She was about ten years older than him and lived with her mother. She moved here a couple years ago, but they weren't very close."

"Weren't?" Adora asked, picking up on the past tense.

"*She died six months ago,*" Entrapta spoke up.

Catra winced, ears flat against her head. "She was a police officer," Marlena said quietly. "They said it was an accident, but Randor doesn't really believe that." She paused for a moment, looking at the phone. "Wait, the head scientist—is her name Entrapta?"

"Yeah," Catra said slowly. "You know her?"

Marlena sighed, moving her hand to cover her eyes. "Mara's fiancé. Mara moved here to be with her because she didn't want to leave her job. She didn't actually say the words, but I got the feeling she blamed herself for it."

Catra understood that. She shook the thought off, taking a deep breath and focusing back on Entrapta. "Okay, that all sucks. But what does it have to do with anything?"

"*I can't say for sure*," Entrapta said. "*But it seems like she has her own motivations for continuing her work on the accelerator.*"

"She wants to find another version of Mara," Adora guessed.

Well *fuck*. Catra sat on the floor—just straight down, curling her legs up under herself, burying her face in one hand. "Fuck," she muttered. "Okay, so I get her motivation, but she's still potentially destroying two universes."

"*Oh, more than two*," Entrapta corrected. "*The entire multiverse could be at risk. Imagine using the trial run the other night happened to zero in on Catherdora's universe. This is just a hypothesis, of course, but if she's trying to find a certain person, she's probably using their DNA. But there's a chance that the scope was too broad, and it just grabbed the first person with similar DNA instead.*"

"And because it interfered with that universe," Catra said slowly, "it threw things off balance. Which means if she tries searching *more* universes"…

"*She's basically turning our universe into a black hole that will drag in anything and everything touches it every time she turns the accelerator on.*"

"So how do we stop it?" Adora asked. "Is there any way to fix the damage that's already done?"

"*I have no idea*," Entrapta said. "*I can't imagine one incident is enough to completely destroy the universe, but if she keeps going*..."

"We also don't know if this was only the first test," Catra said. "Or if it's just the first *successful* one."

"*That's also true*," Entrapta agreed. "*We have no idea how many times she's failed. She doesn't have a complete list in her files*."

"So we need to stop her," Adora said. "And figure out why a politician is so interested in multi-universe travel."

"I'm less worried about him right now," Catra said, moving her hand to rub the back of her neck. "Save the multi-verse first, deal with the shitty politician later."

"Save the multi-verse," Adora repeated. "It's big deal, right?"

"People do it on TV all the time. Thanks for this, Entrapta. Get some sleep."

"*I'll leave your lap upon your bed. Goodnight*."

She hung up. Catra sighed, shoving her phone back in her pocket and burying her face in her hands. "God *damn it*," she hissed. Lyra knelt with her, resting a hand on her shoulder.

"What now?" Adora asked. Catra shook her head. She didn't know. She could sympathize with hope. But this was still a threat that needed to be stopped. And why *was* Prime interested in any of it? Politicians wanting power like that was never a good sign.

"Hope's stubborn, but she's logical," Marlena said. "If you told her that what she's doing is dangerous, she'd listen."

"She's been working on this for years. There's no way she isn't aware of the risks already," Catra said grimly. "She's a genius with access to all kinds of technology. Entrapta figured this out with just my laptop and the data we stole from the lab. And on the off chance she *isn't* aware, do you really think she's going to listen? She sounds like a desperate person. Desperate people don't listen to logic."

Adora looked at her food, clearly not hungry anymore. She didn't like this situation. Neither did Catra. "I think I need to call Randor," Marlena said, standing. She had apparently reached her limit for what she could accept without completely breaking down. Catra kind of admired her for holding out as long as she had.

"Are you—" Glyra started to ask as Marlena walked by. The woman smiled weakly.

"I'm okay. Really. Take your time down here."

She hurried up the stairs. Catra curled her legs up to her chest, resting her forehead against her knees. "Great. Fantastic. Okay. Let's stake out her office tomorrow. Find out what she knows."

"You want to break in *again*?" Adora asked in disbelief. "During the *day*?"

"Of course not. I want to break in before sunrise and spend the day in the vent over her office."

"Oh, right. That's so much more reasonable."

"This all sounds like a terrible idea," Glyra said nervously.

"It absolutely is," Catra agreed easily. "Terrible, terrible idea. It's probably going to go horribly wrong. I'm taking suggestions if anyone has anything better, though."

"Not breaking into a federal building?" Cyra said.

"I've considered it, but it doesn't seem to be in the cards." Catra rolled her shoulders, standing up. "What are some quiet snacks? Gummy bears? Do you like gummy bears? We should pick up some snacks. It's going to be a long day."

As if every single day since Adora had gotten here *hadn't* been a long day.

Lyra quietly cleaned the kitchen while Cyra saw Catra and Adora out. That was something Lyra would have to deal with at another time. She had more pressing issues on her mind now—namely, checking to make sure Cyra wasn't planning to divorce her, and that Marlena was okay.

She had made a choice that day when she heard Catra and Adora arguing. If it was the *right* choice was up for debate, but she stood by it. She knew Cyra wouldn't handle it well, and putting Catra on the spot never ended well.

"I can't believe you never told me," Cyra said in a low voice as she walked back into the kitchen. A shouting match in Marlena's kitchen was the last thing anyone needed.

"I can't believe you don't understand why," Lyra replied calmly. "You made your feelings very clear long before I found anything out."

"And instead of telling me, you just let me keep going on insulting her?"

"Catra also knew how you felt. I don't think she ever saw it as you loving her less or insulting her."

"And you're just *fine* with all of this?"

Lyra set the last dish aside to dry and grabbed the towel to wipe off her hands. "Are you asking if I'm okay knowing that our daughter has been going out and fighting crime for years? Putting herself in danger? Risking legal trouble? Of course not."

"Then *how*—"

"She wasn't going to stop no matter what I said, or we said to her. You know how stubborn she is."

"You should have *told* me."

"And what would you have done if I had?"

Cyra stopped, mouth hanging open, then closed it again, frowning. "Exactly," Lyra said. "I did what I had to do for both of you."

Cyra tried to say something, but they were distracted by the sound of Marlena crying softly from her bedroom. "We're not done with this conversation yet," she said firmly.

"I know."

Lyra made a choice the day she realized her daughter was Spider Cat. She wasn't sure it was the right choice, but she stood by it. Even if Cyra never forgave her for it. She just had to trust that her daughter knew what she was doing. And that her wife loved her enough to get passed this issue.

Catra popped a gummy in her mouth, sighing quietly. She and Adora had been held up in this vent for hours, watching Hope come and go from her office. She didn't do much when she was in her office — just sat at her computer, ate lunch, replied to a few emails. Regular office stuff. They probably should have checked out the accelerator room. But all her notes said she ran her tests at night, after hours. Which meant they could end up sitting here all day for nothing.

"This starting to feel stupid," Adora whispered. Only *start ng* ? Catra scoffed silently. "Do you think we should just get out?"

"T oo dangerous now," Catra replied. W ell have to wait until we know it's safe to—" She stopped as the of fice door opened once more, and Hope walked in. But she wasnt alone this time. "Oh, *shit*."

"I really am busy ," Hope sounded slightly annoyed as she walked around to sit at her desk, gesturing for the guest to take one of the free seats. "This isnt a good time."

"I'm simply curious about the project I'm funding." Something in Prime's voice sent a chill up Catra's spine. It was smooth and cold, like a knife ready to dig into her chest.

"I've sent you daily updates—"

"I haven't heard anything since your last test run a few nights ago." Hope pressed her lips thin, staring at her computer screen. Prime smiled. "Did something happen?"

"The data is inconclusive. There' s a possibility of some dimensional crossing, but Idont have physical proof."

"Then *find* some," Prime said, stepping forward so he was looming over Hope. It was definitely an intimidation tactic. Hope didnt let it sway her.

"I can't rush for results." She looked up, meeting his gaze without flinching. "The multi-verse is fragile. If I push it too much—"

"Then you can say goodbye to your funding," Prime snapped. And for the first time in the conversation, Hope looked a little shaken.

"You can't—"

"I can, and Iwill. Iwant an update before the end of the week, or well be revisiting the matter of money ."

He turned on his heel, walking out without another word. Hope let out a long breath, pressing one hand to her face. The other reached for the framed photo on the desk. Something hardened in her expression; she set the frame down and stood, making her way out of the room.

"Motherfucker," Catra hissed. "He's basically blackmailing her."

"But she definitely knows the risks," Adora whispered. "And she's willing to take that chance."

Catra scrubbed her face, sighing. This entire situation sucked. She understood Hope's feelings, and she was sure Adora did as well. She would have burned the world if it meant getting *her* Adora back. Hope had lost someone she loved. She was devastated. She definitely wasn't thinking straight. That wasn't an excuse, though. She still needed to be stopped.

"Okay," she whispered after a moment. "You go after Prime. Just try to find out why he would be interested in something like this. I'll keep an eye on Hope."

"Are you serious?" Adora asked in disbelief. "We're *splitting up*? Have you never watched a movie? Splitting up is *always bad*."

"I know. But we're on a time limit, and it'll be easier for you to follow him than it is for me. Meet back at the apartment around nine. Okay?"

Adora sighed, pulling her mask down. "This is a terrible idea. But okay. Stay safe."

"Yeah. You too."

The rest of the day passed in a fairly boring blur. Hope came and went from her office, returning around five p.m. to sit at her computer for a bit. A few coworkers stopped in to say good night and remind

her not to stay too late. She simply smiled and bid them a good night.

An hour passed, then another, before Hope finally stood, making her way out of the office once more. Catra crawled through the vents, tracking Hope through the grates she passed over. She lost her when she walked into another room, but managed to find her way in – and almost right on top of the particle accelerator.

Well, fuck

Hope was standing at a computer, typing furiously and murmuring to herself. It was almost soundless, but Catra picked up a few errant words. *Reset. Adora.*

The whine of the accelerator starting up was high-pitched and almost *hurt*. Catra grimaced, clasping her hands to her ears for a minute. She was preparing to try it again. The idea of *another Adora* coming through was enough to make Catra laugh or cry. Maybe both. She yanked her mask down over her face, kicked out the grating, and dropped into the room. Hope had no time to even wonder what had happened before Catra aimed at the computer and hit it with a shot of web;the force shattered the screen, and the machine whirred once more as it shut down.

"How dare you—"

Catra cut off the oncoming tirade;she grabbed Hope, throwing her a little roughly into the wall. Maybe that was a bit much, but this woman had caused her a *lot* of grief in the last three days.

"Don't talk," Catra snarled, keeping Hope back up against the wall. "You know damn well what that machine is going to do, and you still plan on using it? What's wrong with you?"

Hope was quiet for a moment, her expression giving nothing away, until realization dawned. "Something happened," she whispered, voice filled with awe. "What was it? You have to tell me."

I'm not telling you a damn thing until you dismantle that thing."

"But if it *worked*—"

"It's *dangerous*!" Catra burst out, frustrated. "I know you know it's dangerous, you tried to tell Prime not to rush it! Why are you listening to him?"

"Because this could be my only chance." Her voice was surprisingly calm despite the deep, aching desire swimming in her gaze. "If it works, then nothing else matters—"

"Potentially destroying multiple universes doesn't matter?" Catra asked in disbelief.

"Sacrifices must be made for science—"

"This isn't about *science*! You're just trying to get your fiancé back!" Silence followed the words. Hope was surprised that Catra knew that, she didn't let it show. "What would she think about this, if she knew? Would she approve of you risking the literal existence of the multi-verse just so you can have her?"

"No," Hope said quietly, and for one stupid moment, Catra thought maybe she'd gotten through to her. "But what she doesn't know won't hurt her."

She had a gun — where the *fuck* had she gotten a gun? Catra barely had time to dodge, and felt the bullet grazing her side. Her mothers were going to be *so mad*.

"Hell no." Catra grabbed the gun and threw it at the ceiling, gluing it up there with some web. "I've already been shot once, thank you very—"

A stiletto heel buried itself in her stomach as Hope kicked her. She dropped to the ground, wheezing as the wind was knocked out of her. "Jesus fuck, that *hurt*. I've always wondered," Hope said slowly

as she approached. "Why a spider? Magicats are already physiologically superior to humans, so why add the spider gimmick? Does it contribute much?"

Catra forced herself up and backed away, still trying to catch her breath. Damn it, she was going to have a bruise. "The webbing is remarkable. We've recovered some of it and tried to break it down, but it's proven difficult." The greatest minds in the world weren't enough to top something Entrapta had created when she was seventeen. Catra would have laughed if she hadn't been cornered but this weirdly, eerily calm woman who kept a gun on her and knew how to kick.

Footsteps caught Catra's attention; her ears twitched as she looked to the door. "Panic button," Hope said, producing one from her pocket. "Do you really think we wouldn't have access to communicate with security at all times?"

Fuck me.

Two security guards burst through the doors, guns aimed at Catra. "Nope!" she declared, dropping into a crouch and launching herself at the knees of one of the guards. She managed to roll into him, sending him toppling over her while she escaped into the hall. She straightened up and aimed at the second guard, hitting him with some web and sticking him to the wall. With them taken care of, she looked back at Hope, pleading.

"You *can't* do this. Nothing is worth the risk."

Hope seemed entirely unphased by everything around her. "Isn't it?" she asked, her voice so soft that Catra barely heard it. The security guard was recovering, forcing Catra to run. She'd destroyed the computer. That would have to be enough for now.

Following Prime around was *boring.* Adora went back to the office with him, where he made phone calls and had meetings and did

boring politician stuff. She wasn't sure what she was expecting — maybe something more evil villain-ish? And how long should she stay? She shouldn't have left Catra without a way to contact her.

She'd just leave when Prime left for the day. That was fair, she thought.

Why was he interested in the multi-verse, though? He didn't seem like someone who was overly attached to anyone. There were no pictures on his desk or walls, no indication that he had any connections outside of professional ones. Maybe he was just a very private person, but Adora doubted it. Was it just a power grab? Was being president not enough power for him? Did he need to rule *every universe*? How would that even *work*?

He certainly enjoyed hearing himself *talk*, Adora thought, rolling her eyes. He'd been going on and on with some staffers or something about future plans, and how the "project" at Eternia Labs was going well, and he was sure there would be good results soon. But he didn't say anything about his motivations, and Adora was struggling not to fall asleep.

Should've stay with Catra, she thought with a sigh. Splitting up never went well. And Catra didn't have any camouflage abilities like Adora did. What if they caught her?

Adora sighed, shaking off the worry. Catra would be okay. She knew how to take care of herself, clearly.

The sun had almost set by the time Prime finally left. Adora considered following him, but she didn't think she'd learn anything else by staking out the home. If Catra thought they should check it out, they could get his address and check it out later.

Getting back to the apartment took a bit — Adora's sense of direction kind of sucked. But finally she landed on the fire escape and climbed in through Catra's window. Scorpia peeked in when she heard the noise.

"Is Catra with you?"

"What? No."Adora tried to shake off the immediate panic. "Is she not back yet? We split up so I could follow Prime while she stayed at the lab."

Scorpia tried to smile and not to look worried. She wasn't good at it. "Oh. I'm sure she'll be home soon. She probably just got distracted."

"Yeah."Maybe she should go back to the labs. She remembered how to get there and how to get in. "I'm sure it's fine."

It was another hour before Catra finally came back, carefully climbing through her bedroom window in a way that *definitely* meant she was hurt.

"What happened?"Adora demanded, rushing to help her. Catra waved her off, moving to change.

"Winged by a bullet. Lady had a *gun* on her."

"Hope? You talked to her?"

"She was trying to activate the accelerator again."Catra grimaced, grabbing a t-shirt that went down to her knees and carefully pulling it on. "I took out some of her equipment, so that might buy us some time, but I wouldn't depend too much on it."

"Did she say anything about—"

"She knows what she's doing is risky."Catra collapsed onto the bed, grimacing. "She made it *very* clear that she doesn't care, as long as she gets what she wants."

There went Adora's tentative hopes. "But...Otherdora still needs to get home, right?"Scorpia asked slowly. She was standing in the door, watching the girls.

"Yeah," Catra muttered. "That's also a thing I'm not entirely sure how to handle."

"Speaking of!" Entrapta piped up, startling all of them, as she appeared behind Scorpia. "How are you feeling, Otherdora?"

"Uh...tired?" Adora said uncertainly.

"That's no surprise, I estimate you've gotten about fourteen hours of sleep the entire time you've been here. But, physically. Do you feel like your molecules are falling apart?"

"Entrapta," Catra groaned, pressing her hands to her face. "*Please* use words people understand."

"Well, Otherdora is from another universe." No wonder she was considered a genius, Catra thought sarcastically. "So there's a chance that she wouldn't be...compatible with this universe, for lack of a better world. But you don't seem to be suffering any ill side effects from being here."

"Nothing that I know of?" Adora asked, looking at herself. "I feel fine."

"Then it might be possible for you to just stay here if we can figure out a way to prevent Hope from opening the portal again."

"*Fuck* no," Catra snarled, sitting up. "She's going home."

Adora tried not to be too hurt by that declaration. She hadn't *planned* on staying in this place, of course. But that didn't make Catra's fierce words sting any less. "Yeah, that would be for the best," she agreed, biting down a sigh. "I don't belong here."

Catra tucked her hands under her head, staring at her ceiling. "I wonder why the accelerator zeroed in on *your* universe," she said after a moment. "There are probably Grays with familial DNA all over the multi-verse, but the machine chose *you*. Why?"

It was a good question. Adora couldn't say. She didn't believe in fate or anything like that. But she couldn't deny that *something* was happening. There were just too many coincidences for it to add up.

"Maybe it just got lucky," she said without really believing her words. "And I got unlucky."

"Maybe," Catra agreed quietly.

"Also did you say you were hit by a bullet?" Entrapta asked after a moment of silence.

"*Winged*," Catra said, stressing the word. "And you do *not* mention to my mothers. At all. Ever. Actually, just don't ever mention guns around them at all. Or knives. Or weapons at all. Just never tell them *anything*."

"If you don't want them to know anything, why did you tell them?"

"Well *apparently* Mama already knew." Catra threw one hand up, turning on her right side. Then she turned to the left when she realized her right side hurt. "Which I'm pretty sure Mom is still pissed about. I can't believe she really kept it secret this entire time."

"I think it's nice," Adora said. "She trusted you enough to know you'd tell her yourself one day."

"I was definitely never going to tell them." Catra closed her eyes, letting out a long breath. "Entrapta, what do you think will happen if Hope activates that thing again?"

"I don't know," Entrapta admitted. "Worst case scenario, we all die."

"Oh, is that all?" Catra asked. "No big deal, then."

"Best case, Hope succeeds and never turns on the accelerator again."

"And kidnaps a Mara from another universe who might not have any idea what's going on," Adora said. "That doesn't exactly seem like a happy ending."

"No one's getting a fucking happy ending in this story," Catra grumbled. "Everything is going to suck no matter what."

She wasn't *wrong*, even if it was depressing. They could save the multi-verse, but everyone would still be unhappy in the end. "Yeah," Adora relented, collapsing into Catra's desk chair. "You're right. But at least the world will survive so things can keep sucking."

"That's the spirit."

It had been a very long, very frustrating night.

Hope frowned deeply at the wrecked computer equipment. Getting replacements would be easy enough, but getting it set up would take valuable time. And she doubted Prime would be understanding.

It didn't matter. None of it mattered. This would work, and she would have Mara back. Nothing else mattered.

Scared of the Dark

Chapter Summary

Things get bad. Things get worse. Entrapta meets herself. That part is delightful.

Chapter Notes

Pace yourself, y'all - and yes, that is a hard chapter count. Next one will be the last.

Adora couldn't sleep.

She rolled over to face the back of the couch, glaring at it, then rolled back onto her other side. Insomnia wasn't new, but usually Glimmer would stay up with her so she wasn't alone (even if it was almost always because she had forgotten to do something that was due the next day. It was the thought that counted).

But now she was alone. And she wasn't enjoying it.

"*God* you move so much," Catra grumbled from her bedroom door. Adora sat up, surprised, and watched her cross the room, going into the kitchen. "Do you ever sleep?"

"Do *you*?" Adora countered, raising an eyebrow.

"No. But at least I don't keep anyone awake while I'm not sleeping."

Adora didn't really take offense. She knew Entrapta and Scorpia were sleeping just fine. It was either sensitive hearing, or Catra couldn't sleep. Or both.

"Sorry," she said anyway, turning over again.

"Sure."

Catra walked to the kitchen digging through the cabinets for a snack. "Do you have anyone back home?" she finally asked, well aware that Adora was still awake. "I mean..you said you don't have any parents, or?..".

"Oh, yeah." Adora sat up, rubbing her eyes. "My friends, Glimmer and Bow." Catra snorted. Those were the worst names she'd ever heard. "After everything with..with W eaver, I ended up at Glimmer 's house. And she introduced me to her boyfriend. And we just kind of became friends from there."

"Do they know about?..".

"The spider thing? Y eah. I kind of lost my temper when Glimmer started saying stuff about..Catra dying, I told her it was my fault. I t was my fault Catra was there that night. My fault she was shot. My fault she died."

Adora was staring at the floor, slumped on the couch. She didn't see the granola bar Catra threw until it hit her in the head. "Ow! What—"

"Stop being stupid." Catra rolled her eyes, turning away from Adora. "I t' s not *your f aul.t* You're not the one who pulled the trigger ."

"I know," Adora admitted grudgingly , rubbing her head.

"Y ou're not the one who pointed the gun at her in the first place."

"I know, but—"

"Then shut up. Y eah, it *sucks* , but it's not your fault. You didn't kill her."

Adora scrunched her nose up, then took the granola bar and unwrapped it. "W ell, you didn't kill your Adora." There was a pause, then a low growl. Adora didn't let it deter her . "Do you think maybe there was a reason it was me that ended up here?"

"Y ou mean besides the obvious?"

"Yeah." Adora took a bite of the granola bar, chewing for a long moment. "I mean... think about it. If there are *other* universes, there are probably other Catras and other Adoras. The machine could have zeroed in on *any* universe, like one where neither of us have powers and we're married, or we're enemies, or something. Maybe there's a universe where *I'm* the Magicat and you're human."

"Fuck off." There was no real heat behind the words, so Adora wasn't too worried about offending her. "*Me*, a fucking human. Get real."

"My *point*," Adora said, "is that it found me."

"And what, it was *fate* that you ended up here?" Catra scoffed.

"I think it was *something*," Adora said. "But it feels kind of stupid when you put it like that."

It *was* kind of stupid. Sure, *fate* had brought them together so they could heal each other's broken bits. So fucking stupid.

"Whatever." Catra walked over to the couch, nudging Adora aside so they could sit together. "All of this is insane anyway. There's no rhyme or reason to it."

"Yeah," Adora murmured. "Maybe."

Scorpia was yawning as she walked out of her room the next morning. Her mind was already spinning with breakfast ideas. She'd been trying to cook a little more to make sure Otherdora didn't starve…

She stopped. Blinked. Rubbed her eyes a few times. Stared.

Catra was sitting on the couch with Adora. They were both asleep, resting on each other. Adora was snoring lightly, and Catra's ears were twitching at the sound, but she didn't seem too disturbed.

Oh. Well, then. Scorpia slowly stepped back into her room, quietly closing the door. This was the first time she'd seen Catra sleep peacefully in god knew how long. She didn't want to bother them.

"*Are you sure you're okay?*"

"Yes," Marlena said patiently. Randor had been calling her every chance he got since the night before. It was sweet, but Marlena was tired. "And Cyra and Lyra spent the night. *And* Lyra is still here. I'm okay, and not alone. Finish out your trip."

Randor was quiet for a long moment. Marlena had told him the broad details of the situation the night before, but he hadn't wanted to push too much. "*What's she like?*" he asked finally. Marlena sighed, pressing her free hand to her face.

"She's older." *Their* daughter had been carefree and happy, a sparkle in her eye that could cheer up anyone she came into contact with. "I don't know the entire story, but she lost her Catra, and it seems like she blames herself."

"*Poor kid*," Randor murmured.

"Mar?" Lyra peeked into the living room from the kitchen. "Do you want lunch?"

Marlena was *fairly* certain Lyra was half using her as a distraction from the fight she and Cyra tried not to let her hear last night. But she wasn't really going to complain. The company was nice.

"Sure." Marlena smiled. "Whatever you want is good."

"*Did Cyra kick Lyra out?*" Rador asked, a hint of wry humor in his voice.

"Not that I know of. Cyra's just at work and I think Lyra needs company too."

t had been a long day , and it didnt seem like it was going to get any easier any time soon. Marlena really hoped the girls were staying out of trouble. Bt that seemed like too much to ask.

"Hw long do you think itll take Hope to get the accelerator back up and running?"

Entrapta raised an eyebrow at Catra. She might as well have asked when the sky would turn neon yellow. "I have no idea. t' s taken years to build it, but all you did was destroy some computer eqipment. t might not take more than a day or two to reprogram things and get everything connected again."

"Okay ."Catra rubbed the back of her head. "Let' s assume we have a day. What can we do to stop her permanently?"

"Destroy the entire machine?"Adora suggested, hitting her open palm with her fist. "W e shouldve done that from the start."

"There' s no way security isnt going to be ramped up to eleven after last night,"Catra said regretfully . t was amazing nothing had been on the news about it, or online anywhere. She wondered if the labs had covered up the break in. Bt why?

"Maybe shell get the hint and not use it again?"Scorpia suggested. She always wanted to see the best in people. Catra wasnt as hopeful.

"I dont think so,"Adora said. "Desperate people do desperate things."

"Y eah. Were going to have to figure out a way to shut her down for good."

"What does shutting her down for good look like, though?"Scorpia asked qietly . "I dont think either of you are murderers."

They definitely weren't murderers, no matter how angry they might get. They couldn't really prove that crimes were being committed. Was it even a crime to destroy the multi-verse?

"We can try to appeal to her common sense again," Catra said. "But she didn't seem willing to listen before."

"She's looking for another version of her fiancé, right?" Scorpia asked. "But it wouldn't be her *real* fiancé. Kinda like how Otherdora isn't really Adora, ya know?" Catra paused and blinked, looking at Scorpia as if seeing her for the first time. "What? Did I say something wrong?"

"No," Catra said slowly. "I think you said something very right." She looked at Adora. "We're going back. Tonight."

"Are you sure about this?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow. "No, no she wasn't. But it was the best idea Catra had right then. She'd just have to hope it worked.

Security had been tightened after Catra's break in, because of course it had.

"Well, what do you expect?" Adora whispered as they crawled through the vents. "You broke into a government laboratory and destroyed their property."

"Yeah, yeah"…

There were three security guards posted outside the room, probably with no idea what they were even guarding, or what Hope was attempting to do.

"You take out the guards," Catra said. "I'm going to talk to Hope."

"Do you really think you can get through to her?"

“I have to try.”

Catra crawled on while Adora camo-ed and broke through the vent. Hope was already on alert when Catra dropped into the room, gun drawn.

“Wait!” Catra held her hands up. “Please, don’t shoot. I just want to talk.”

“I don’t believe there’s anything to discuss. You’ve made your feelings clear.”

“I know, but listen anyway,” Catra pleaded. “I understand what you’re going through. Not exactly, but I can relate.”

Her eyes flitted to the door to make sure the security guards were good and distracted, then slowly reached up and pulled her mask off. Hope narrowed her eyes slightly.

“I lost someone too. It’s kind of funny, in a weird morbid way, but her and Mara were related. Did you ever meet her niece, Adora?”

Hope was still glaring at her, but there was a spark of familiarity in her eyes. “I never met her, no. But I went with Mara to her funeral.”

Huh. Catra had no memory whatsoever of that, but the funeral was kind of a blank anyway. “I would do *anything* to get her back. I’d burn the entire world without any guilt. I don’t *care*. But that,” Catra waved a hand at the accelerator. “isn’t going to bring Mara back.”

Adora kicked the door in, ready to fight. She paused when she saw Catra without her mask and Hope with the gun. She tilted her head, clearly asking, *are you sure about this?* Catra nodded slightly.

“You’ll find *a* Mara,” she continued, waving a hand at Adora, who hesitantly pulled her own mask off. Hope’s composure slipped for a moment, letting her surprise show. “Just like you found *an* Adora. But she’s not *my* Adora. She’s not the best friend I grew up with. She

looks like her, and sounds like her, and it's really easy to just pretend. But she's a completely different person. You might find someone who looks like Mara, sounds like Mara, even acts like her in a few ways. But it won't be *your* Mara."

Hope's eyes flicked between them, a frown creasing her expression. "No," she whispered, shaking her head. "Of course it will be a different Mara, but she'll still…"

"Still what?" Catra challenged. "Still love you? Maybe. Maybe it's a universal constant that every Mara has a Hope and every Hope has a Mara, and you always love each other. Maybe you'll be stealing her from her own Hope. You don't know. That's the problem. You don't *know*."

"It hurts," Adora added when Hope didn't say anything. "It hurts so *much*. I lost someone too. My Catra. And nothing is ever going to bring her back even if she's standing right next to me. She's still gone."

"But you have each other." Hope's voice was hard. "*Mmachi ne* brought you together. Maybe it won't fix everything, but it's a start. It has to be a start."

"You're going to regret it," Catra said. "If you don't kill us all in the process."

"You said you would burn the world to get your Adora back. I'm willing to take the same risk."

She pressed the button to start the machine. The computers were out of sight now – probably a smart move – and Hope still had the gun on Catra. Adora darted forward as the machine whirred to life.

"Don't!" Catra yelled She had no idea what would happen if the machine was destroyed mid-use. Hope turned the gun on Adora, who ducked to dodge the bullet, then aimed at Hope, sticking her to

the wall with some webbing. Catra grabbed Adora's arm before she could try to do the same with the machine.

The high-pitched whirring got louder and louder;Catra clasped her hands over her ears, wincing. Adora looked around, trying to figure out some other way to shut it down —a lever , a button, an emergency switch, *anything*, there had to be something, she had to —

The world exploded in a blast of light.

Catra blinked a few times as her eyes slowly opened. She was on the ground, outside, staring up at the starry sky. How had she gotten out here? She sat up, rubbing her head, and saw Adora next to her , still unconscious. Okay, well she was safe at least. That was good, right?

Then she saw Eternia Labs.

"Aw, *fuck*."

Most of the building had been consumed in bright, crackling electricity, almost like fire, but with no heat. As she watched, a bolt of the energy shot out into the sky;the sky fractured like glass, and more light began shining through.

"Oh no," she heard Adora breathe beside her . Great, she was seeing this too. Catra hadnt lost her mind.

"Does um..does the city look weird?"

Catra just stared at Adora in disbelief. They were looking down at the city from a warehouse rooftop, and *yes*, it looked fucking weird. It looked a puzzle where the pieces didnt quite fit right, but someone had still forced it together. There were fines cracks in the air that

some people walked through and some stepped around. And was the sidewalk a little more crowded than usual?

"Hang on." Adora squinted her eyes at something down the street. "That diner. I go there with Bow and Glimmer all the time."

"Awesome, wanna stop in for a bite?"

"It doesn't exist in your universe. I've looked for it."

They looked at each other for a moment, tilting their heads in unison as they tried to figure out what that meant. "Come on," Adora said finally, straightening and pulling her mask down. Catra followed suit.

They landed on the outside of a balcony of a very nice apartment building. Adora peaked into the window; she squeaked in surprise, and knocked on the glass.

"Glimmer! *Glimmer!*"

There was a pause, then the window flew open, revealing a frazzled and half-dressed young woman with pink hair. "Adora?! Where have you *been*? We were worried out of our minds!"

"Really?" Catra asked, looking into the room. "Does sex help you feel better?"

There was a yelp from the bed. The woman stared at Catra, opening and closing her mouth a few times, her cheeks burning red. "That's not—I'm sorry, who are *you*?"

"It's a long story," Adora said, rocking back and forth on her heels. "Can we come in? Please?"

Glimmer looked over her shoulder, then nodded and stepped aside to let them crawl through the window. "Catra, this is Glimmer and Bow. Glimmer, Bow, this is Catra. From another universe. It's a long story."

Glimmer and Bow exchanged long, shocked looks. "Okay," Bow said slowly. "Tell us everything."

Catra was walking back and forth in the living room while Adora filled her friends in on where she had been the last few days.

"No fucking reception," she muttered when yet another call failed to connect to her mothers, Scorpia, or Entrapta. She even tried Marlena, whose number she'd memorized years ago. Nothing.

"I doubt any cellphone providers really know how to maintain reception when universes are collapsing," Bow said, obviously trying to be helpful. Catra just hissed at him.

"She's worried," Adora said quietly. Well, *Adora* was worried. She hoped Catra's parents were okay. She hoped Marlena and Randor were okay. Marlena had been so nice to her. If she was hurt – if any of them were hurt – it would be her fault.

"She seems... nice," Glimmer said with a small, forced smile. They knew Catra had been Adora's best friend, and probably wanted to be kind.

"She is. This is just a terrible situation."

"Have you been okay?" Bow asked Adora gently. She shrugged, not entirely sure how to answer that.

"It's been a long few days."

Bow wrapped his arms around her, pulling her into a tight hug. "We're just glad you're home."

Glimmer joined the hug, nuzzling into Adora's shoulder. "So happy. We were so worried."

Catra paused, looking at them, trying to ignore the bitterness welling in her chest. Adora had told her she had friends. Adora had made it quite clear she had people waiting for her in her universe. So what if she had gotten along with Marlena and Catra had felt a brief moment of hope? That was stupid. She was stupid. Adora had a *life* in this universe. She wasn't going to abandon it for a place where she was *dead*. So stupid.

"*Catra*?" She jumped as a call finally connected. Cyra's voice was static-y, not quite connected, like it was cutting off. But it was connected, and she could hear her mother's voice, and that was a start.

"Mom! Are you okay? Is Mama?"

"*We're fine*," Cyra assured her, though she sounded a little harried. "*What's going on?*"

"Honestly? I don't know if I can explain it before this call cuts out again. Just... just stay inside, okay? And if you can in touch with Entrapta and Scorpia, tell them to do the same thing. Do *not* let Entrapta go out for any reason. I don't care how important the science is."

"*Where are you?*" Cyra asked quietly. Catra paused, looking at Adora and her friends. She turned to stare at a wall.

"I'm safe. Don't worry about it. I love you."

"*Catra—*"

She ended the call before Cyra could protest. "Should we be worried?" Adora asked, separating herself from Glimmer and Bow and standing.

"About the universe possibly falling apart? Uh." Catra made her way back to Glimmer's room, intending to go out the window. "I'm sure it's nothing. Enjoy your friend time."

"Okay , point taken," Adora muttered. She gave her friends one more squeeze before hurrying after her . "What should we do?"

"Fuck if I know ," Catra said, pulling her mask down. "Pretty sure the answer is back at Eternia Labs, but we need a plan before we go back there."

Adora tilted her head, clearly thinking for a moment, then grabbed Catra's arm. "Come on. We can go to my thinking place."

"You have a thinking place?" Catra asked in disbelief. Adora smiled, almost mischievously.

"I do, and I think you'll like it."

Walking down the subway tunnel felt almost like coming home. Adora hadn't realized how much she had missed not being able to visit the mural.

"Whoa," Catra murmured when they stepped into the large room. "Did I—I mean, your Catra?"

"Yeah. This is the mural she did." Adora went to sit down in front of the wall, curling her legs under herself. "I come here when I need to think. And it makes me feel closer to her."

Catra hesitated before moving to sit with her. "She was really talented, huh?"

"She was amazing." Adora smiled. "She had to go through so much, and she never let it get her down. She just... she always kept going. I admired her ."

Hearing that probably would have meant the world to the Catra who had drawn this amazing mural. Adora had probably never told her .

They sat in silence for a bit. Adora wondered if Catra was really thinking about their current predicament and how to fix it. She hoped so, because she definitely wasn't. She was just staring at the mural and thinking about her last normal day. Her Catra. But for the first time she didn't feel alone. She'd never brought anyone else here, but it felt *right* that she'd brought Catra here to see it. It felt like something that was safe to share with her.

"What are you thinking?" Catra asked after a moment. "I know you're not coming up with ideas for fixing all of this."

"I'm trying," Adora protested. "But I don't know . I'm not smart enough for this. Catra would probably know. My Catra, I mean."

"Thanks for the vote of confidence," Catra muttered, half jokingly . Adora jolted out of her reverie.

"Sorry , I mean — I'm sure you can think of something too. Every version of you is smarter than me."

"That's not true," Catra said. "Sucking at school doesn't mean you're not smart. Anyone can read a book and memorize a few facts. *You* created an entire superhero persona and worked for years to save a city that probably didn't deserve you. That's worth way more than book smarts."

"I didn't, though." Adora traced the lines on her costume. "Catra created it, and Entrapta designed it."

"And *you* wore it. *You* fought. *You* were the hero. Neither of them could have done that. Ah!" Catra put her hand over Adora's mouth. "Stop selling yourself short. You know how I know neither of them could have done it? Because Entrapta just doesn't have the physical fitness for it, and Catra couldn't do anything without you. *You* kept going when you lost her. I stopped. I've always been selfish. I didn't care about the city or being a hero or anything like that. I just… wanted to be someone Adora would be proud of. And I love."

She muttered that last part, cheeks burning red. She heard a hitch in Adora's breathing, and hurriedly kept speaking, not wanting to know what she was thinking. "You got to have all your moments with your Catra. You loved each other, and you knew it, and you didn't waste time. I was too busy trying to be a person good enough for my Adora, and my chance was over before I got it."

Catra curled her legs up to her chest, resting her forehead on her knees. She could feel Adora's gaze burning into her. "Catra... my Catra... she was like a star," Adora said slowly. "It was like she knew she wasn't going to live forever, and she made every single second count. I was always thinking about the future, and how much better our lives could be once we were out of Weaver's. But she lived in the present. She burned bright and fast and... and then she was gone. And I don't think she regretted one minute of her life.

"I think that's why I could keep going. Because it's what she would have wanted. Maybe because I thought I wouldn't live much longer, either." Catra looked up, surprised; tears were falling slowly down Adora's cheeks as she stared up at the mural, smiling. "I don't feel like I should. It's like I'm living on borrowed time. All I ever had in this world was Catra. I love Glimmer and Bow, but Catra was my constant. She was like the center of my universe. And everything fell a little out of place when she was gone."

She looked at Catra, giving her a small, sad smile. "Maybe that's why you could walk away. You still have family and friends and people who really need *you*, not just Spider Cat. You still have so much to live for, even if you don't realize it yet."

Catra met Adora's gaze, ignoring the tears burning in the back of her eyes. "I couldn't save her."

"That's not all you're good for. You're more than what you can do as a hero."

It was hard to tell how touchy-feely Adora was. They'd both carefully avoided anything that came too close to physical contact. It felt too

much like crossing a line.

Catra absolutely shattered that line and threw herself at Adora, hugging her tight. Adora was still for a moment before her arms slowly wrapped around Catra in return. They sat there for a moment, two lost girls in a universe that wasn't really either of their's, in front of a memorial for the artist, drawn by the artist's own hand.

And for a moment, Adora kind of understood hope. She'd spent almost three years wishing to hold Catra just one more time. She couldn't imagine letting go now that she had it. And Catra also understood. She had finally said (albeit in a roundabout way) the one thing she had never told Adora. She felt almost at peace.

They didn't come up with an actual plan, but both of them felt better when they finally separated. They gave each other weak, awkward smiles, then laughed.

"What now?" Adora asked, wiping the tears from her eyes.

"Fuck if I know." Catra looked back up at the mural. "Did you really think coming here would help?"

"I don't know," Adora admitted. "I just wanted to see it. I haven't had a chance to visit. It's not. It's kind of like her grave, I guess. She was a ward of the state, and I couldn't claim her body, so she didn't get a funeral or anything, and visiting the cemetery always felt kind of weird. This is a better memory."

They sat a little longer before finally standing and making their way out. Catra's phone rang right as they emerged. She checked the collar ID and let out a relieved breath.

"Hey Entrapta. What's up?"

"*This is fascinating!*" She sounded like she'd shotgunned two packs of Redbull. "*I borrowed your computer – sorry I went into your room*

but it was really important — and managed to get into the main server at Entrapta Labs —

"You *what*?!" Catra shrieked, tail lashing.

"*Don't worry, the Horde has way bigger problems than worrying about what I'm doing. The multi-verse is ending!*"

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose, letting out a long breath, and put the call on speaker so Adora could hear as well. "Okay, first of all, could you sound less excited about the end of the world? Second, do you know that for sure?"

"*Oh yes, absolutely.*" Entrapta did her best to inject some seriousness in her voice. "*The readings coming out of the labs are… confusing, honestly.*" Entrapta was confused by something? That was probably the most disturbing part of all. "*It's like a heartmonitor trying to read multiple heartbeats at the same time.*"

Catra looked at the cracks in the sky and air, thought about the bits of Adora's universe she had seen. "Could that be because of two or more universes trying to exist in the same place at the same time?"

"*Oooooooh, possibly. If that's the case, though, this is something that can be sustained for long.*"

"What happens if we can't fix it?" Adora asked, catching Catra's gaze.

"*If I had to guess, the universes are probably going to start colliding. I doubt it's just yours and ours in this mix, there are probably others — oooooooooh, maybe there's another me I could work with!*"

"Uh, no," Catra said quickly. "Let's not mess with that. Who knows what could happen if you meet another version of yourself."

"*Aaaawwww.*" Entrapta was understandably disappointed. "*But I guess you're right. Okay, I'll keep going through the data the I.A.R.E. is collecting and see if I can find anything else that I'll help*

"You're amazing, Entrapta. Really. Thanks."

Catra hung up, running a hand through her hair. "God. Can you imagine two Entraptas meeting each other?"

"No," Adora said flatly. The very idea of it was horrific. But then her eyes lit up as an idea occurred to her. "Maybe they can both help us."

Bow and Glimmer were still in the living room, talking quietly, when Adora and Catra got back. "Hey." They jumped up, eyes wide. "What's going on?"

"Do you think you can get Entrapta on the phone?" Adora asked, pulling her mask off and shaking her hair out. Bow blinked, surprised.

"Uh. I can try. Phone lines have been kind of…"

"I know."

Catra was already trying to get her Entrapta back on the phone. She switched to calling Scorpia after the third call failed to go through. "*Wild cat?*

"Hey. Yes, I'm okay. I need to talk to Entrapta."

"*Oh, she's pretty busy…*"

"Trust me. She'll want to be interrupted for this."

Bow, meanwhile, was on his own phone. The first call failed to connect, then the second, then the third. Finally on the fourth, a

disturbingly familiar voice answered. "*Hello! This is really important! The universe is kind of ending.*"

"Um. this is about that, actually." Bow shot Adora a questioning look. She took his phone and held it out to Catra.

"*I don't have anything new,*" Entrapta said on Catra's phone.

"No, but I do." Catra made sure both phones were on speaker and said, "Say hello to yourself."

"*Hello?*" Entrapta repeated dubiously. A loud gasp echoed out of Bow's phone.

"*What the—?*"

Another gasp from Catra's phone. "*It is! This is incredible!*"

"Better yet, it's a you who *isn't* on an FBI watchlist." Catra paused, then leaned closer to Bow's phone to say, "*Are you?*"

"*Well, of course not. What did I do to end up on an FBI watchlist?* Wait, *is this Catra?*"

"Yeah. The too long, didn't read version is that I'm from another universe where someone is using a particle accelerator to break dimensional boundaries and try to find someone who's dead in our universe. But it went really, really wrong, and now the universes are trying to exist in the same place at the same time and everything is sort of falling apart."

"*Oooooooh. That makes sense.*"

"*If we're existing in the same place at the same time, though,*" Entrapta on Catra's phone said slowly. "*Then Other Entrapta should be able to access all the same data I'm getting from Eternia labs.*"

"That's what we're hoping," Catra said. "Two of you working together could probably accomplish a lot more than you could alone, right?"

"*Absolutely! Especially if she doesn't have the same legal restraints Other Me) what kind of computer stuff do you have?*"

They started babbling at each other. Catra put the phones on the table, close together, so they could talk and coordinate, and stepped away. She looked at Adora, who was a little amused.

"I think we made the right choice to not let them meet in person."

Catra wandered over the kitchen to find a snack. Her moms would have admonished her for her lack of manners, but the multi-verse might be ending;asking permission was the last thing on her mind.

The sound of bells echoed in her ears, and then Glimmer appeared next to her. "What the *fuck*?" Catra yelped, nearly dropping the protein bar she'd stolen. "Sorry, I'll ask next time!"

"What?" Glimmer looked at the protein bar. "Oh, no, those are Bow's. You can have them all, they're disgusting." She looked over her shoulder. Bow and Adora were enraptured by whatever was happening on the phones. "I want to talk to you about Adora."

Catra did her best to look uninterested as she unwrapped the protein bar and took a bite. "What about her?"

"Just.whatever happens, take care of her. Please. I know you just met her, but she's really important to us, and we.we want to make sure she's okay."

Catra looked back at the living room, gaze landing on Adora. Yes, she'd just met her. But she'd also know her for their entire lives. She didn't just share a physical traits with the person Catra had lost;she was kind and caring and stupidly loving. She wanted to help people. She wanted to be someone worth loving. She tried so hard to be optimistic even when the world was threatening to cave in around her. She didn't give herself enough credit. She deserved the entire world, and someone who could give it to her.

Maybe, technically, they had just met. But Catra knew, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that she would die for this Adora. For any Adora. Maybe it was a universal constant. Just like maybe there was always a Mara for every hope. There was always a Catra for every Adora. And Catra would do anything to keep any Adora safe.

"That's the plan, Sparkles," she said with more confidence than she really felt. Glimmer half-smiled.

"Adora's always said we'd probably like Catra, if we got to know her."

"Yeah, well... maybe it's for the best. I feel like we'd either like each other, or want to kill each other."

Glimmer sorted, covering her mouth to laugh. "Probably."

"Hey, guys?" Bow called from the couch. "The Entraptas think they've got something."

"Two Entraptas still seems like such a terrible idea," Catra said as they walked back out to the living room. "What's going on?"

"*Well,*" Entrapta on Catra's phone started, "*Othertrapta managed to confirm all of what I already suspected.*"

"*I did some research, and it turns out there's no Eternia labs in our universe,*" Othertrapta said. "*That location here is actually empty. But there's definitely something there now. I managed to get into one of the nearby satellites—*"

"You did *what*?" Catra asked in disbelief. What was it with Entrapta and hacking into things she absolutely was not supposed to?

"*And there's definitely some kind of energy in the area. It's rather concerning.*"

"Assuming this spot is the exact same in both universes," Catra said slowly. "That's probably the center of it all."

"So if we want to stop it, that's where we have to go," Adora finished.

"*That would be our best guess*," Entrapta said, a little too cheerfully in Catra's opinion.

"*But we have no idea what's going to look like*," Entrapta added. "*This spike might have gone a little beyond just turning off the machine. There are going to be consequences to this kind of damage.*"

"Doesn't matter," Catra said. "We'll do whatever we have to do."

Adora nodded in agreement. Glimmer and Bow exchanged uncertain looks. "We could come with you—" Glimmer started, but Adora shook her head.

"Absolutely not."

And they'd kind of known she'd shoot that down. She never let them go anywhere near her superhero work. Not after what had happened to Catra. She wouldn't risk them like that. "Just... be careful," Bow insisted. "Please."

"Of course." Adora gave him a quick, reassuring smile. "We'll be fine."

That wasn't reassuring. "*Will do, cat*," Scorpia said quietly on Catra's phone. Catra picked it up and took it off speaker, putting it to her ear.

"Yeah?"

"*You're going to be okay... right?*"

"Of course. Don't worry about anything. I'll call you as soon as this is all over."

She hung up before Scorpia or Entrapta could respond. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow were hugging; she turned away, focusing on the wall. "Be safe," Glimmer insisted, squeezing Adora a little tighter.

"I will," Adora said. "I promise. I love you both."

"We love you too."

Catra looked at her phone, considering calling her mothers again. But they would have questions, and she just couldn't. They didn't need to know she was about to do something stupidly dangerous. And if she came out fine on the other side, they would never need to know. And if she didn't, she wouldn't have to face them.

Glimmer and Bow watched the girls disappear out the window and into the night. "Do you feel like we just said goodbye?" Bow asked quietly. Glimmer crossed her arms tight, nodding.

"Yeah. But I think she'll be okay."

Catra had promised to protect her, after all. And weirdly, Glimmer trusted her. Maybe it was stupid, but she felt good about the other woman. Adora would be all right. They both would be.

The trip back to Eternia Labs was silent. They were both lost in thought, trying to figure out what they were about to face. Walking into the unknown, unprepared. Neither of them liked that.

"How do we even get in there?" Adora asked as they landed in front of the glowing ball of energy. Catra was pretty sure it had gotten brighter and worse.

"Walk?" Catra suggested. Adora shot her a disbelieving look.

"Just walk into the crackling energy that might rip us apart limb from limb?"

"Sure. What's the worst it could do? Kill us?"

Catra started forward, pulling her hood up to hide her ears. Adora watched, then pulled her own hood up and followed.

Walking into the energy didn't… *hurt*, exactly, but it felt *weird*. Like the energy ran through their bodies, right to the tips of their fingers and toes. They winced, exchanging looks.

"You felt that, right?"

"Yeah."

They started forward, pushing through the weird resistance, and stumbling into a light-filled hallway.

It was like walking on air. Catra felt disoriented for a moment, as if she had been turned upside down; she stumbled, grabbing Adora's arm to steady herself.

"You okay?" Adora asked, looking down at her. She seemed fine.

"Yeah." Catra picked herself up, blinking furiously. "Spatial awareness, I think. Things feel kind of topsy turvy."

Adora helped her stand upright, squeezing her arm. "So how are we supposed to find our way to the middle of all this?" she asked, gesturing with her free hand. Catra rubbed her head, looking around.

"Just move forward, I guess."

Adora kept her fingers around Catra's arm as they started walking. Catra's ears twitched at nearly imperceptible sounds that she knew Adora wouldn't be able to hear, so she didn't bother calling attention to them. Until she heard giggling.

"Are... Are there kids here?" she asked, turning and looking around.

"I doubt it?" Adora said uncertainly. She couldn't hear it of course. The giggles echoed, louder this time, and Adora jumped in surprise. "Okay, that was—"

They both went very still as two children ran out of the light, laughing and chasing each other. It was… *them*. Young Catra pounced,

knocking Young Adora over, and they both sat up, giggling hysterically. It was an almost familiar position to Catra, but not… quite. Adora's breath hitched.

"Is that?…" Catra started slowly. Adora nodded once. The children faded away; Adora turned, leading Catra away. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah. I—"

"*Catra! Adora!*"

Adora full on flinched at the voice, her fingernails digging into Catra's arm. "Weaver," she breathed. Catra growled quietly. She didn't know the bitch, but she knew enough. The sound of a hand slapping a cheek, followed by a small cry, echoed around them.

"*Stop! She didn't do anything!*" That was Adora's voice, desperate. Trying to protect someone.

"She left us home alone," Adora murmured. "There were a couple older kids too, but they didn't watch us or anything. We were just playing, and I knocked over a vase. But Weaver hated Catra, so she blamed her."

There was a sniffle, and then they saw Young Catra hiding under the bed, trying not to cry. Adora crawled under the bed with her, snuggling close to her.

"*Why does she hate me?*" Young Catra whimpered, wiping her eyes.

"*She's the worst,*" Young Adora said fiercely. "*We don't need her, or anyone else, as long as we have each other. You look out for me, I look out for you. Right?*"

Young Catra looked at Young Adora, tears still swimming in her eyes. She nodded once. "*Yeah. We have each other.*"

Young Adora shifted a little to get her tiny arm around Young Catra, hugging her tight. Catra watched, jaw clenched, as the scene

disappeared. "Come on," she said quietly, turning to lead Adora onward.

More low giggling that Catra knew Adora wouldn't hear. She braced herself for whatever memory this weird portal was going to throw at them next.

"*You need to pay more attention.*"

Catra recognized the voice, although it had been years and she couldn't give the voice a name anymore. It was their first grade teacher, scolding her and Adora for talking during class.

"*We were paying attention,*" Catra's young voice protested.

"That sounds familiar," Adora said, half-laughing. "Not a teacher I recognize, though."

"They learned early on not to let us sit next to each other."

"*I know you can do better than this, Adora.*"

Another scene faded into view, one Catra recognized. She was eight, looking into a classroom, where Adora was being lightly scolded by another teacher. "*I'm trying,*" Young Adora mumbled.

"*You need to try harder.*"

"*I—*"

"*Maybe you're just a bad teacher,*" Young Catra said loudly, walking into the room. Young Adora and the teacher looked at her in shock.

"*Catra!—*"

"*Catra, that's not appropriate thing to say,*" the teacher scolded her. "*Please wait in the hall—*"

"*No* ." Young Catra took Adora's hand, standing in front of her. "*I bet* I *can teach Adora better than you can. You just don't know how to teach her.*"

The teacher opened and closed her mouth a few times, clearly stunned by the declaration. "*Wait there, both of you*," she finally said, turning and walking out.

"*Catra!*" Young Adora squeaked, looking annoyed and exasperated. "*You can't just say stuff like that!*"

"*Well, I might. I'll show her. I can teach you everything, way better than she can.*"

Young Adora looked stunned. Young Catra looked stupidly over confident. The scene faded away, and Catra laughed weakly.

"I got in *so* much trouble for saying that. But I was right. I helped her every year all the way through high school, and I was a *way* better teacher."

"I'm sure you were." Adora was smiling under the mask.

They pushed on, ignoring the bits and pieces of memories that flitted through the air. Some Catra recognized, some she didn't. A lot of them featured Weaver, and Catra *definitely* hated her.

"Is gravity getting heavier?" Adora finally asked, breaking the silence. It *did* feel like there was pressure on them.

"Remember what Entrapta said about the particle accelerator being like a black hole? Maybe we're being pulled in."

Adora tightened her grip a little, as if that would actually help. The energy around them was crackling dangerously; it was like walking into a thunderstorm. It was a little terrifying, but Catra was willing to bet that it also meant they were getting closer. Catra pulled her hood

forward a little more, as if that would somehow shield her. Adora was adjusting her mask.

"Hey," She stopped them suddenly, turning Catra to look at her. "Whatever happens next, I'm really glad I met you. I know all of this has sucked, but being with you has been... I mean"…

Her voice drifted off as Catra pulled her into a hug. "Yeah," she murmured. "I get it. And same."

They pulled apart after a long moment, turning to face the scene in front of them. The energy seemed to have coalesced here, into a spiraling portal. They exchanged looks and nodded before running in.

There wasn't nearly as much resistance as they had been expecting; their momentum nearly carried them right into a wall. Catra skidded to a halt and grabbed Adora before she could fall.

"*Oof, sorry!*" Catra's ears twitched as an unfamiliar voice rang in the air. "*I'm so sorry, I'm running late. Do you need help with that?*"

"*I thought you were running late?*" The responding voice was only vaguely familiar, but they both knew it. Hope.

"*My mother taught me to always clean up the mess I make. So I'd say I'm with her broom if she knew I ran into a pretty girl and didn't help her pick up her books.*"

It was Adora who finally found Hope, standing against what was probably a wall, eyes closed. There was a small smile pulling at her lips even as tears slid down her cheeks.

"Hope! You have to stop this. Is there a way to – to turn the machine off, or?"…

"I found her." Her voice was a reverent whisper. "I finally found her."

"You found memories!" Catra snapped. "You already *had* those. You didn't have to build an entire machine and rip universes apart to—"

"But now I can have her whenever I want." Hope was absolutely not listening to them. "I won't ever have to worry about losing her again."

"But it's not real," Adora said desperately. "They're just memories. We heard the same things walking through here. None of it is *real*. The people *we* care about are gone." No answer. "Hope, please. We need to do something. *You* need to do something. The world is falling apart, and you really *are* going to lose Mara if you don't help us, because you're going to die too!"

Nothing. "Forget it," Catra snarled, turning in the direction the energy seemed to be pulling. "That *has* to be the particle accelerator. If we stop it now, maybe the multi-verse will still survive."

Adora gave Hope one last pleading look before following Catra. "Do you think there's a plug or something?"

"I'm pretty sure something like this runs on more than electricity." They could just make out the faint outline of the machine in the light. There was no sign of the equipment running it, though. No magical button or lever to shut it down.

"*Fermi Labs is one of the greatest facilities in the world. It was the opportunity of a lifetime.*"

"*Then you should go.*" Mara sounded nice. Kind. Her voice was soft, her excitement obvious in the undertones. "*I'll be right behind you.*"

"Screw it," Catra muttered, surging forward and reaching out to touch the machine. A bolt of energy came down from the ceiling, crackling as it hit her and threw her back.

"Catra!"

Adora knelt to help her sit up;she groaned. "Okay . So it's not going to be that easy. Ishould've known that."

"I know you think destroying it while it' s running is a bad idea"…

"But we're running pretty low on *good* ideas."Catra laughed humorlessly. "Y eah."

"*You can al ways l eave your j ob i f you dontl i ke.*" That was Hope, in a soft voice neither of them would have thought her capable of. It was loving, tender. Caring. "*I make more than enough to take care of both of us.*"

"*Awww , do you wantme to be a house wi f e?* "Mara laughed. "*I l ove my j ob. There are j ust a f ew people Idontt rust .*"

"*Not exact y a qual i ty you wanti n a potent al l y l i f e or death situat on.*"

"*It Bl l be okay . Dontworry .*"

It was hard to think with Hope' s memories playing in the air around them. Especially when other voices started to intermingle.

"*You're such an i di ot*"

"*Hey , thi s i s al l practi ce f or when you go to medi cal school . You're wel come.*"

"*Adora, come on*"—

"*Dont* Adora come on *me! Y ou coul d've gotten seri ously hurtthi s ni ght You coul d've di ed! Do you even know how many people woul d mi s you i f you j ustnever came home?*

Adora and Catra exchanged looks. *They* were the heroes. They'd never been in Hope' s shoes, worrying someone they cared about would leave and not come back. They didnt know how it felt.

"What was Mara doing?" Catra asked after a moment, trying to be a little more patient. "Marlena said her death was ruled an accident, but Randor doesn't believe that."

Hope laughed bitterly. "It wasn't an accident. She was set up and left without backup. I don't know all the details—she never told me. She said she didn't want to put me in danger. But I know it had something to do with corruption in Bright Moon's police force. Something about an old street gang?"

The Horde. Of course. All the lines went right back to Prime. "The official story is that her radio wasn't working and no one heard her call," Hope continued. "But how likely is that? That she just happened to be in the right place for an ambush on a night when her radio happened to be broken?"

"It was probably a set up," Catra agreed. "And you're taking money from the guy pulling all the strings. Prime has a hand in everything, including the Horde. Especially the Horde."

"I know." The admission surprised them a bit. "But he was giving me money for my research. I couldn't turn it down."

"What does *he* want with this thing, anyway? Ruling the multi-verse is a little too cartoonishly bad." And Catra couldn't imagine there was anyone *he* loved enough to take this kind of risk.

"He's never said. I never asked."

Energy electrified the air around them, making Catra's fur stand on end. Right. They didn't have time for this. "We need to shut this down, Hope. It isn't worth it."

Hope wrapped her arms around herself and curled in slightly, eyes squeezed shut. "She promised she would always come home."

"And I'm sure she would have kept the promise if it was up to her," Adora said gently. "This isn't the way to fix it, though."

"You told me you know she wouldn't want this," Catra added. "She was a cop, right? And she loved her job. She loved protecting people. How many people are you going to hurt chasing memories? What would she think?" Hope finally opened her eyes to look at both of them. The pure, raw grief in her gaze hurt to see. It hurts. I get it. Adora gets it. But you *know* we're right. It's not too late to fix things. Just tell us how to turn the machine off."

Hope looked between them. Her voice was hollow when she finally spoke. "There might be a problem."

Only one? Catra wanted to ask, but Adora nudged her before she could speak and nodded to Hope, encouraging her to continue.

"I don't know what exactly will happen if you shut down the accelerator now. I assume part of it would be pulling apart the different universes that have started to converge. But we're at the eye of the storm, so to speak. If anyone is in here when the accelerator shuts down"…

"They'd be trapped," Catra finished quietly. "Or killed."

Hope nodded once. Well okay. That was just… *great*.

Home

Chapter Summary

Things end, things begin. Such is the way of life.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A very tense silence filled the air as the women looked at the swirling matrix that was the particle accelerator. "Well," Catra said after a moment, trying to inject some humor into her voice. "I didn't want to look for a new job anyway."

"Catra," Adora scolded her. "This is serious."

"Yup. Totally serious." Catra took a few steps closer to the matrix. "You guys should really get out of here. This might get ugly."

"Wha — *We* should get out of here?" Adora said in disbelief. "What do you mean? Do you think *you're* staying here to turn this thing off?"

"Uh, yeah. My universe, my problem."

"How does that make sense?" Adora demanded, ripping her mask off so Catra could see the anger in her ocean blue eyes. "*I'm* the one with no family waiting at home."

"You've got Glimmer and Bow." Catra waved Adora off. "And I told Sparkles I would take care of you. So you're going to get out and go home and keep living your damn life. Got it?"

"No, I don't got it," Adora said. "*You* have Scorpia and Entrapta, *and* your mothers, *and* Marlena and Randor."

"They'll be fine without me," Catra pulled off her own mask to meet Adora's gaze. "It's not like I'm any use to them anyway. You're still doing the hero thing in your world. They need you."

"We already went over this!" Adora said, exasperated. "You're worth more than—"

"Yeah, I get that! But I can do this for *everyone*, and it'll be worth *way* more than just existing."

"Even if that's true—which it's *not*—you still need to go home. I'm not letting you sacrifice yourself here!"

"Oh, I need your permission to sacrifice myself?" Catra asked sarcastically. "Please, Adora, can I stay behind and shut down the stupid, dangerous machine and potentially kill myself?"

"That's not the point, and *no*!"

"So who's going to do it then? You?" Adora didn't answer. Catra scoffed. "You're such a hypocrite."

"Look who's talking," Adora shot back. "You're the one determined to stay behind because, what? You promised Glimmer you'd protect me? You don't even know her!"

"It's not just about her!" Catra blushed slightly, ducking her head to hide it. "I'm not—I can't let anything happen to you. How am I supposed to live with myself if I let you die again?"

"And you think I can let *you* die again?" Adora's voice cracked. "You can't ask me to do that."

"Well *you* can't ask me to—"

"Pardon me."

It was almost comical, how calm the interruption was compared to Adora's and Catra's voices. They'd completely forgotten Hope was

there. “What?” Catra asked, tone a little short. She wasn’t in the mood to argue about turning this thing off because Hope missed her girlfriend.

“I believe you’re both missing a rather obvious third option.”

They exchanged looks, then turned back to Hope. “And that is?” Adora asked after a moment.

“You both leave, and I stay behind to shut the machine down.”

“Absolutely not,” Adora said immediately.

“How do we even know you’ll actually turn it off?” Catra added.

“You don’t,” Hope admitted. “But what do I have to gain by letting it continue? Even if I wanted to start over, it would be completely from scratch. And I would still have to find a way to turn the machine off.”

She took a few steps forward, and Catra stiffened; this woman had tried to shoot her *twice*, she had every right to be a little suspicious. But Hope walked past her, eyes fixed on the swirling matrix.

“This is the problem with heroes. They always think it’s their responsibility to fix everything on their own.” She smiled sadly. “Mara was the same way. I think she would have liked you two. She always had a lot of admiration for Spider Cat.”

Catra blinked. It always felt weird when people said they admired Spider Cat or looked up to her. She thought she could fix everything by being on the inside. But deep down, she knew it was something she would never accomplish alone. She understood why people worked outside the system. I think in a way, she wanted to be more like you, but she was scared.”

“Yeah, well.” Catra mumbled. “It’s easy to go against the grain when you’re hiding under a mask.”

Hope shook her head. "But you could have been anyone. You represented something fundamental to Mara. Proof that someone could stand up and fight back. You didn't need a badge and a gun. You just needed a mask and a will to fight."

"And look where all that got her." Catra didn't mean to be so dismissive, she was just... tired. The world was ending around them and she was *tired*. "She's dead."

"But she lived her life the way she wanted. I think, at the very least, she was proud of that." Hope turned back to look at them, smiling sadly. "Now it's my turn to do something she would be proud of, and let go."

Adora tried to argue, but Catra stepped back, resting a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You don't know what's going to happen to you."

"No, I don't. And that's okay. Mara loved the unknown. It was something we always disagreed on."

Adora looked like she still wanted to argue. Catra cut her off again. "What about Adora? How does she get back to her universe?"

"I can't say for certain," Hope said slowly. "But if the universes are converging, then you would have to find a place you know only exists in your universe and stay there. I'll give you both as much time as I can to get somewhere safe."

"Why?" Adora finally managed to say. "Why are you doing this?"

Hope's expression softened into a small, sad smile. "You're both so young. You have so much left to live for, even if you don't believe it now. Besides, Mara would never forgive me if I didn't clean up the mess I made."

Catra stared at Hope for a long, long moment. "We're trusting you," she finally said, eyes narrowed. Hope nodded.

"I know."

Adora hesitated, but Catra took her hand, tugging her away. "Let's go."

Somehow, it was easier to get out than it had been to get out. It seemed like almost no time at all before they stumbled back out into the fresh, fractured air. "You gotta haul ass, but you can probably make it back to your place before she…"

Catra's voice drifted off when she saw the stricken look in Adora's eyes. "What?"

"I don't want to leave."

"I don't like it either," Catra admitted. "But this is what she wants, so—"

Adora shook her head furiously. "No, I mean, I don't want to leave *you*."

Catra's stomach dropped to her toes. "No, she couldn't do this. Not now. "I'm *not* her. You know that, right?"

"I know!" Tears welled in Adora's eyes. "I know, you're completely different people, but you still… I just… remember what you said to Hope? About how maybe there's a Mara for Hope in every universe, and vice-versa? I've been thinking—what if it's the same with us? A Catra for every Adora, an Adora for every Catra. But our universes are messed up. What if that's why I'm here? The universes are trying to fix their mistakes."

"Do you actually believe that?" Catra asked incredulously.

"I don't know," Adora admitted, voice wavering. "I just… I don't want to go back to a universe without you."

Lightning crackled in the air above them. They winced; Catra grabbed Adora and pulled her into the trees. "I'll go," Adora said. "I

you don't want me here, I'll go. I won't force you to accept me if you don't want me. Just say it."

Catra *couldn't* say it, and she hated herself for it. She couldn't say, *I'll go back to your universe. Goodbye.* Because she didn't want to live in a universe without Adora, either. It was selfish, asking her to leave her entire life behind for a universe where she was *dead*. How could she even think about asking it? But if Adora was *offering*...

"Is this what *you* want?" Catra asked, voice cracking. The tears spilled over, and Adora nodded slowly. "What about Glimmer and Bow?"

"They... I think they'd understand. They know I'm not happy here."

"And you think you'll be happier in a place where you're dead?"

Adora faltered slightly. "If you don't want me to stay, just say it."

"I *do*!" Catra burst out, throwing her hands up. "Of course I want you to stay. How could I *not*? You think I want to live in a world without you?"

They stood in silence, staring at each other as the world threatened to collapse around them. "But you can *never* go back," Catra continued, her voice thick with tears. "What if you stay here and regret it? What if you end up hating me because I'm not *your* Catra? How do you know things are going to work out?"

"I don't," Adora admitted, a small, sad smile pulling at her lips. "Call it a leap of faith?"

Catra stared at her for a moment, slack-jawed, before moving to wrap her in a tight hug, which Adora returned with all the strength she had. She never wanted to let go.

An explosion very nearby reminded them why it was a *bad* idea to stay where they were. "Fuck," Catra mumbled, hurriedly pulling away

and grabbing Adora's hand. "We need to get clear of this place."

They took off into the trees. The air around them was electrified and thick with tension. Bright purple light was shining through the cracks in the air. It looked like everything was about to fall apart. How much longer was hope going to hold out? She couldn't really predict how long they had; this was new territory to her too. Maybe they should have stayed. Maybe they should have—

A loud boom echoed through air, followed by a shock wave which knocked Catra and Adora to the ground. They laid in a crumpled heap, moaning and rubbing their heads. Adora looked up first, and let out a small gasp.

"Look."

Catra followed her gaze. Eternia Labs was about a hundred feet away, looking clean and untouched. The cracks in the air had disappeared, the purple light gone. "Did it work?" Adora asked slowly.

"Yeah. I think so." Catra pulled her phone out and called Entrapta. She picked up on the first ring.

"*Catra! You won't believe what just—*"

"Is everything fixed?"

Entrapta cut off abruptly, going weirdly silent for a moment. "*I believe so, yes! The energy readings were seizing in Eternia Labs are gone.*"

"Okay. Cool. I'll be home soon, but I really need to check in with my moms. And um. Adora's with me, so don't freak out."

"*What—*"

She hung up, running a hand through her hair and sighing. Adora was watching her, curious and apprehensive. "You're not already regretting letting me stay, are you?" she asked cautiously.

"No," Catra said quickly. "I'm just tired." And that was true. It had been a *long* few days. "Are... Are *you* regretting it?"

Adora shook her head. "Not at all."

"Okay. Cool."

"Cool."

Randor's car was in the Grays' driveway, Catra noted as they landed in her moms' front yard. "He must have come back early. No one really wanted to spend the end of the world at a business conference, she supposed.

"Mom?" she called as she let herself into the house. "Mama?"

Cyra and Lyra darted out of the kitchen, both immediately scooping Catra into a tight hug. "Do you know how worried we were?!" Cyra demanded. She was nearly in tears. Lyra just held them both, kissing the top of her daughter's head. Adora looked past them to see Marlena and presumably Randor standing in the kitchen door. Randor looked a little shell-shocked.

"She's"...

Adora realized, a little too late, that she probably should have thought more about how her counterpart's parents would feel in this situation. She waved, a little awkwardly. "Hi. Um. I'm sorry. I didn't think this completely through."

"Think what through?" Marlena asked.

"I... I wanted to stay here. In this universe, I mean. Obviously I won't bother you or anything. I can figure things out on my own."

Randor and Marlena exchanged long looks before Marlena slowly said, "Well... you'll need clothes to start."

Bow and Glimmer sat on the balcony outside their room, watching the sun rise.

"She's not coming back, is she?" Bow asked quietly.

"I don't think so," Glimmer said.

"Do you think she's okay?"

"Yeah." Glimmer wasn't sure why she was so confident. It was just a feeling she had. The sky was blue, grass was green, and Adora was with Catra. She was okay. "And who knows, maybe we'll see her again someday. Entrapta's got a bug in her ear now, and if anyone can build a portal to another dimension…"

Bow laughed. "If anyone can do it, it's her."

The idea brought them some comfort. Maybe they'd see Adora again someday. Clearly, nothing was impossible.

Someone sent all of Prime's records to every single law agency in the country, detailing every illegal thing he'd ever done. He was promptly arrested. The FBI showed up two days later to find Entrapta walking Catra through setting up her brand new computer. She never *did* tell anyone what she did to the old one. Catra decided she didn't want to know.

Marlena and Randor had cleaned out their daughter's closet and given the clothes to Adora. They also wanted to get to know her. They knew she wasn't the Adora they had lost, but she was a child who needed parents, and that, apparently, was enough.

"They don't *really* have family dinners every weekend, do they?" Adora whispered to Catra as they left the Driluth house one Sunday night. The four parents had gotten together and decided that Sunday was mandatory joint-family dinner night, despite both girls being

adults and one of them *not* actually being related to anyone in the parental group.

"Hell no, that's new." Catra didn't bother lowering her voice. Her mothers were going to hear either way. "Probably Mama's idea."

Adora smiled a stupid smile; Catra glared at her. "*What*?"

"I just think it's cute that you call your mother Mama."

"Shut *up*!" Catra shoved her away. "It's just practical. Do you know how many stupid jokes they would make if I called them both Mom?"

"Still cute."

"Fuck off."

"Language!" they heard Lyra call from the house. Adora looked back from the end of the driveway, surprised.

"I know Magicat hearing is good, but *yeesh*."

Marlena watched from the window as the girls disappeared down the street, a small smile pulling at her lips. "So, how are things going?" Randor asked as Lyra set out tea for the four of them and joined Cyra on the couch. It wasn't exactly a secret that they were still dealing with the fallout of Lyra not telling Cyra about Catra being Spider Cat. Catra had already asked twice if they were getting a divorce. The resounding answer was *no* both times. The wives exchanged smiles.

"I think we're okay. No more big secrets apparently, other than Lyra not liking the necklace I got her for our third anniversary. Which honestly, I already knew since she never wears it."

"It's the thought that counts, though." Lyra took Cyra's hand. "Mar, come sit down. The tea is going to get cold, and they're definitely long gone."

Marlena did nothing to hide her fondness of Adora. Randor understood, though he wasn't quite there yet. He was still a little worried about replacing his own daughter. But Adora was very hard to not like. She'd told them all a little bit about her's and Catra's lives in her own universe — mostly about growing up with Weaver, and how neither of them knew their biological families. It was a shame that the universes were already closed off and none of them would ever get a chance to meet Weaver.

"Do you think we're being a bit overbearing with the dinners?" Marlena asked as she sat with Randor, picking up a mug.

"Catra's lucky we haven't already moved her back into the house," Cyra grumbled, sipping her drink. While she *understood* why Catra had kept it a secret and Lyra had never told her, she didn't *like* it.

"She's an adult," Lyra reminded Cyra patiently. "We can't *make* her move back home."

"Watch me."

It was mostly an empty threat. Cyra would never make Catra do anything she didn't want to do. No matter how tempting it was. She'd always known she couldn't protect Catra from the anything that hurt her — something that was reinforced when Adora died. But she always wanted to try.

"Has she mentioned anything about her and Adora?..."

Marlena's voice drifted off, letting everyone fill in the blanks. "Of course not," Lyra said with a small laugh. "She'd never talk to us about *that*."

But they weren't blind. They saw the way the girls looked at each other when they thought no one else was looking. Saw the way their hands brushed, like they *wanted* to intertwine their fingers, but couldn't work up the courage to actually do it. They also knew that

the girls were currently sharing a room, even if Adora was sleeping on an air mattress. That probably wouldn't last long.

"You don't think we're just trying to replace our Adora, do you?" Randor asked. Marlena shook her head.

"She's not our Adora. I know that. But she's someone who needs love and a family. If she wants it, and we can give it to her, I think we should try."

Randor nodded slowly. He wouldn't force his way into Adora's life, but if she wanted them to be part of it... he could do that.

Mara Gray was humming as she closed her locker and put her lab coat on over her scrubs. She was one of the lucky few people in the entire world who actually, truly loved her job, and walked in every day with a smile on her face.

That smile turned into a raised eyebrow and quirked lips as she walked by the nurse's station and saw her coworker leaning on the counter, flipping through a chart.

"Were you here all night?"

Cyra Driluth looked up from the chart, blinking a few times at Mara. "Is it morning already?"

Mara shook her head. Cyra was truly useless without her wife. "How do you not realize that you've been here for almost twenty-four hours?"

"I got caught up in doing some work, and you know, Lyra took Catra and Clawdeen to visit her family—"

"Oh, is Catra gone? I couldn't tell from the way Adora's been moping around and living on her phone."

Cyra laughed. "Catra's apparently been doing the same. Remember what it's like to be young and in love?"

"If only." Mara's only love was, and had always been, her job. "Go home, or I'm calling Lyra and telling on you."

That earned her a properly horrified look. Lyra was lovely and the kindest person Mara had ever met, but she was a force to be reckoned with, especially when it came to her wife's habit of overworking. "Evil," Cyra said. "Oh, four-d woke up last night."

"Really?" Mara asked in surprise, taking the chart from Cyra. "Did she say anything about what happened?"

"She doesn't remember," Cyra said, starting off toward the locker room. "Gave us a name, though."

The name had been scribbled in at the top of the chart. *Hope*. Mara hummed thoughtfully, heading for the room.

"Hello," Mara said cheerfully as she walked into Hope's room. The woman had been found in the woods unconscious a few days earlier. It was nice to see her awake and somewhat alert; her eyes swiveled to look at the doctor, a faint look of confusion passing across her face.

"Hello," she said cautiously. The prevailing theory was that the woman was a victim of domestic violence – people didn't usually end up unconscious in the woods by accident. But there had been no bruises or any indication of abuse. It was like she'd just… appeared.

"I'm Dr. Gray, one of the doctors on your case. I've been told you don't remember anything about what happened?"

Hope shook her head. "I don't remember much at all, I'm afraid. Everything before I woke up here is blank."

That was certainly interesting. Complete amnesia like this wasnt common, and there was no sign whatsoever of head injuries. "W ell, well do whatever we can to help you," Mara assured her , smiling. Someone would probably report her missing eventually, right? She had to have a family, or someone missing her. And if not, well… Mara was a person of her word. She would absolutely do whatever she could to help h[illegible]e. The woman smiled tentatively .

"Thank you."

[illegible]ly , Adora?"

Adora rolled over to look at Catra, who was already staring at her. "Y eah?" They didnt really *hav[illegible]* to whisper; Scorpia slept with a white noise machine, Entrapta didnt sleep, and they all had doors. B[illegible]t it was very reminiscent of old times for both of them.

"[illegible]ve been thinking a lot. .and Ithink Im going to go back to school."

"Really?" Adora smiled. She knew Catra had dropped out after the accident. Going back was a good step forward. "That' s great."

"Y eah. Im tired of doing nothing with my life. And Ithink this would be good for me. The thing is. .I d want to move back on campus. I dont drive, so it'd just be easier ." Oh. Right. Of course. Adora tried not to feel too bad. This was good for Catra. She deserved this. "I havent talked to Scopria and Entrapta about it yet, but Im sure theyll let you have my room."

"I cant pay rent." [illegible]ell, Adora couldnt even get a *j ob* Entrapta was working on cooking up a fake identity so Adora could live legally, but she had to be slow about it, lest the FB[illegible]descend upon them again. Adora still couldnt believe that had actually happened.

Catra laughed. "Do you think Ipay rent? Ilost my last job the night I met you because Itold a customer to fuck of f. Scorpia and Entrapta

knew I couldn't pay rent when they offered to let me move in. They're good about things like that."

Adora didn't really like the idea about living off of someone else's charity. But it was temporary. She would get a legal identity and a job, and she'd be able to pay.

"Why do you look so bummed out?" Catra teased. "Gonna miss me?"

"Yeah." Adora didn't really mean to admit that out loud. She didn't want Catra to feel guilty about doing something good for herself.

"Oh." Clearly Catra hadn't expected that answer. "I mean, BMU is only like twenty minutes away. You can always just drive in with Scorpia some time and visit. I'm going to try and get a single dorm, so you could even, ya know, stay over sometimes. If you want."

Adora sat up, surprised. "You'd be okay with that?"

"I wouldn't have offered if I wasn't." Catra sat up as well, running a hand through her hair. "We can keep the air mattress in my dorm, or um"…

They'd been taking things slow. *Very* slow. Because Adora had already had a relationship and Catra hadn't, and they needed to find a way to meet in the middle. Physical contact like hugging and holding hands had become a comfortable habit, at least. Adora was glad for that as she launched herself off the mattress, holding Catra tight.

"I'd like that," she murmured into Catra's shoulder. Catra snuggled into her, a small purr rumbling in her chest. It had been a long, *long* time since she'd purred in a content way. She'd forgotten how nice it felt.

Scorpia and Entrapta were perfectly fine with Adora staying, just as Catra had predicted. It felt weird, packing Catra's stuff up with her and helping her move into the dorm, but Adora wanted to help. The dorm room was small, but nice.

"This is the worst bed ever," Catra said as she hopped up to sit on it. "You can change your mind about the air bed any time. Well, I might take it myself."

Adora rolled her eyes. She was so dramatic. "Mooooooooom," they heard a voice groaning. "I don't need you to unpack for me. I'll do it myself later."

"You say that, but we'll visit for family weekend and you'll still be living out of boxes."

Adora peeked out of the room, and almost laughed. There was Glimmer, arguing with her mother across the hall while her father moved boxes into her room.

"And *please* remember that you wanted a single dorm so you could study better, *not* so you could have Bow over every night"—

"*Mom*!"

Catra peeked over Adora's shoulder, trying not to laugh. "I'll try to make friends with them," she assured Adora. Adora grinned in return.

"I think you'll get along great."

Adora made a big splash when she debuted as Spider Woman. *Especially* when Spider Cat started getting back out in the world as well.

"*How are they already spectating that we're* dating*?*" Catra asked, disgusted. They didn't *need* to talk on the phone every night, but

they liked to.

"Convenience?" Adora guessed, scrolling through the same article. "I mean, you've got two Spider people. Throw in a third and we can have a love triangle."

"*Hell no. Can you imagine?*"

No. Adora could not. "Hey, so. Marlena and Randor invited me to dinner for Friday night. Do you think I should go?"

"*Do you want to go?*"

"Yeah," Adora admitted softly.

"*Then why are you asking me?*"

"Because you're better at reading people than I am, and I just. I can't tell if they actually care about *me*, or if they're really trying to recreate their dead daughter."

"*Impetty sure that is what this is*," Catra said. "*You're not her, we all know that. They might want to start planning about your birthday, though. I mean, I assume it is in January?*"

"Yes, but it's only October." Adora gasped. "Wait, *your* birthday is coming up!"

"*Not the point*," Catra said quickly. "*Marlena and Randor probably want to find out if you're interested in celebrating, and what to get you and all that. And if they start asking now, they'll think they're being subtle and you won't catch on.*"

"Okay, but your birthday—"

"*You know what, I got to go. Talk later.*"

Adora laughed as Catra abruptly hung up. She closed her laptop and rolled over to get comfortable. Obviously she needed to get Catra

something for her birthday. She had some time to consider it, though.

Catra's birthday fell on a weekend, and agreed to spend the weekend at the apartment. She was getting dinner with her mothers Friday night, but that left the entire weekend for Scorpia, Entrapta, and Adora to spoil her.

Cyra and Lyra were their usual, overbearing selves when Catra arrived Friday night. They immediately descended upon their daughter, hugging her tight and wishing her an over-enthusiastic happy birthday.

"Okay , okay, okay," she grumbled, ducking out of their arms. L yra had made her favorite meal, and there were even a couple gifts waiting on the table. "Y ou know, I've had twenty-two of these things."

"And each one is just as special as the last." L yra kissed her forehead. "Go on, sit. Dinner is almost ready ."

"How' s school going?" Cyra asked almost as soon as they were at the table.

"All right. I finally declared my major . Think my adviser nearly keeled over when I told him."

"Amazing. What'd you choose?"

"Biology ." L yra made her way to the table with plates, setting one down in front of Cyra and Catra, then taking her own. Oh good, she only had to say this once. "I've decided I want to be a doctor ."

Cyra literally *squeal ed* , clapping her hands together in joy; L yra beamed and leaned over to hug Catra tight. "That' s amazing, sweetheart."

"Do you know where you want to go for medical school? What about specialization? Oh—"

Lyra rested a hand on Cyra's shoulder. "Breathe, Cyra. She just made this choice. I doubt she's thought much about it."

Actually, Catra *had* thought about it all, but she was just as happy to let it pass in favor of enjoying the night and the meal. There would be time to talk to Cyra about it later.

"Sooooo how're things with Adora?"

Wait no. Catra wanted to go back and talk about the medical school thing again. But it was too late. "There are no *things* with Adora. We're friends."

"Friends who share a room and a bed at an apartment?" Cyra teased. Catra hissed at her mother, who laughed.

"Just. Friends."

"Mmhm." Lyra hummed, exchanging a knowing look with Cyra. Catra rolled her eyes at both of them, focusing on her food. Her mothers just loved to make up stories where there were none.

Scorpia was delighted to have Catra over for her birthday, and spent most of the day cooking. Her girlfriend, Perfuma, came over to help her, which meant it was going to be a vegan meal, but Catra could live with it for one night. Especially since she got to spend time with Adora while the girlfriends were working. Entrapta was in her room, working on something that Catra didn't question. It was always safer that way.

"They've been planning this meal for days," Adora whispered conspiratorially to Catra. "Scorpia is really excited."

"I don't know why everyone is so worked up about my birthday this year," Catra said, rolling her eyes. "It's not even a big milestone or anything."

Okay, she short of knew why. Her last birthday had been only a few months after Adora died, and no one had really wanted to push her about celebrating when they weren't sure she was even happy to be alive. This year was exciting for everyone who cared about her.

"I think it's sweet," Adora said with a small smile. Birthdays hadn't been a big deal at Weaver's, but she and Catra had always found ways to celebrate. Her first birthday without Catra had been a little bittersweet – Glimmer and her parents had thrown a proper birthday celebration for her, but it all felt hollow without Catra there.

"It's *something*," Catra grumbled.

Entrapta came barreling out of her room right before dinner, clearly proud of herself as she presented Catra with a small box. "Tada! Happy birthday! Although it's sort of a gift for Adora, too."

Catra raised an eyebrow and popped the box open. It was a charging box for a couple of earbuds, one red and one white. "Make sure you don't get them mixed up," Entrapta said seriously. "Catra's is designed to accommodate her sensitive hearing."

"What are they?" Catra asked, taking the little box.

"They're communication devices for when you and Adora are out on patrol!" Entrapta sounded quite proud of herself. "So you can stay in contact with each other and stop carrying your phones around. I can't believe I didn't think of this sooner, honestly. The red one is for you, and the white one is for Adora."

"This is pretty cool," Adora said, looking over Catra's shoulder. "Thanks Entrapta."

Entrapta beamed, clearly proud of herself.

Dinner was great. It was Perfuma's first time meeting Adora (although she had been filled in, with permission from Catra and Adora), but Adora had vaguely knowing a version of Perfuma, and Perfuma was interested in hearing about her other self, and Scorpia and Entrapta. Catra was just as happy to let Adora do all the talking and enjoy being in everyone's company. It was a nice time.

Catra stretched out on the bed, letting out a content groan. "Changed my mind, I want the entire bed to myself."

Adora didn't answer. Catra looked up to see her standing near the door, shuffling nervously. "Hey, I'm just kidding. Come lie down."

"Um. I, I have a present for you."

"Oh. Okay." Silence, save for the sound of Adora shifting her weight between her legs. Catra raised an eyebrow. "This isn't the part where you rip off your clothes and present *yourself* as the present, is it?"

"What? No!" Adora blushed deeply, looking anywhere *but* at Catra.

"All right, so why are you so anxious about it?"

"It's just." Adora huffed, running a hand through her hair. "I was cleaning out the closet after you moved out, and I found a box of old sketchbooks, and I realized I've never seen you draw, but some of the books looked pretty new, so I thought maybe it was something you gave up when, anyway."

She produced a leather-bound book from the desk, holding it out uncertainly. It was gorgeous—handmade, if Catra had to guess, with a cat pawprint stamped in the middle. Catra took it slowly, flipping it open to look at the blank pages.

"Wow," she said, running her fingers over the leather. "This is beautiful."

"I didn't want to make any assumptions or anything," Adora said quickly. "So if you really just don't want to draw anymore I understand—"

Catra reached out to take Adora's hand, tugging her to sit down. "I love it," she said quietly. "And you're right, I haven't really drawn anything since the accident. I haven't really had the inspiration for it, so I threw all of my stuff into a box and just ignored it. But this is really, really amazing. And I promise to try and use it."

Adora relaxed, smiling. "I'm glad you like it."

Their hands were still intertwined. Catra looked down at them, then at Adora. They'd been taking things at her pace mostly, because Adora didn't want to be pushy, and all of this was extremely new to Catra. She knew she would have to take the next step. Doing it on her birthday felt cliche, but…

She leaned forward before she could over-think it too much, and gently pressed her lips to Adora's. Adora's eyes went wide for a moment; then she leaned into the kiss, almost eagerly. "Wow," she breathed as they pulled apart. Catra rolled her eyes, resting her forehead against Adora's.

"Don't ruin it."

Marlena and Randor *thought* they were being sneaky, but their attempts to talk to Adora about her birthday were as transparent as Catra had guessed they'd be. Adora was touched by the gesture, though, and saying no didn't feel right.

"I'm not taking advantage of them, right?" Adora asked as she and Catra made their way down the street. It was a usual Sunday dinner, but with cake and some presents.

"By letting them feed you?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow. "No, I think you're fine. And they want to do this. Marlena's been using

Mama to get gift ideas from me since last month."

"I guess. I just it's *their* Adora's birthday too. I feel like I'm intruding on something."

"They visited the cemetery for her birthday last year. I'm sure they did the same thing this year. Now they're celebrating you. Think of it like you happen to share a birthday with a dead relative. They can acknowledge both without you intruding."

Adora nodded slowly. "Okay. Yeah. You're right."

"Of course I am. I'm always right."

They let themselves into the house—Catra had been given a house key when she was ten and still kept it on her—and Marlena greeted them with a hug.

"You're both freezing! Did you walk here? Go to the kitchen, it's nice and warm."

Randor, Cyra, and Lyra were sitting at the table, talking about something, when Adora and Catra walked in. "Hey girls!" Randor greeted them cheerfully. "Happy birthday, Adora."

"Thank you, Mr. —um, Randor."She was still getting used to that.

Dinner was amazing, and so was the cake. Blessedly, no one suggested singing happy birthday. Marlena was very excited to give Adora her first present.

"Choosing your own present to give her first, huh?" Randor said with a smirk. "I see how it is."

"Oh, shush," Marlena scolded him teasingly. Adora took the present and carefully unwrapped it. It was a hand-knitted hat and a pair of gloves, both red and white—Spider Woman's colors.

"Oh, *wow*," Adora murmured, brushing her fingers against the hat. "It's so *soft*. Catra, feel this."

"I know what kind of yarn she uses," Catra said. "Have you seen my hat with the ears? Marlena original."

Adora put the hat on, marveling in how it felt on her ears. "I love it so much. *Thank you*."

"And it's from *both* of us," Marlena said, looking pointedly at Randor.

"Yes, I contributed a lot by buying the yarn," Randor said wryly. "I think my actual gift is a bit better."

"That one is *also* from both of us," Marlena said. "You just had the idea."

Randor reached over to grab a small box and handed it to Adora. She unwrapped it, and her mouth fell open when she saw a phone. "We figured you didn't have a phone," Randor said as Adora stared at the box. "Or if you do it's probably been tinkered with by Entrapta." Catra snorted, coughing to hide it. "And we're happy to put you on our phone plan. We still have a third line available."

Oh. Adora felt tears well up in her eyes. The fact that they'd even thought about such a basic need for her made her feel loved.

"Hey, her phone is nicer than mine." Catra helpfully provided a distraction so Adora could pull herself together. "Can I get a new phone?"

"Sure, when you start paying your own bill," Cyra said. "How's the job hunt going?"

"Actually, I've got an interview with the campus library."

Adora discreetly wiped her eyes, shooting Catra a grateful smile.

The last gift was from Cyra and Lyra. It was a handmade photo album, mostly empty except for a few pictures they'd somehow gotten of Catra and Adora without them noticing. "We know you don't have that many memories here," Cyra explained as Adora looked through it curiously. "But hopefully you can make some, and have a place to keep them. It's mostly Lyra's work, but I had the idea, so"…

"I love it," Adora said honestly. "So much. Thank you. You guys really didn't have to go through all this trouble."

"If it makes you feel better, I didn't go through any trouble at all," Catra said. "Your gift is having me home for the weekend."

"Honestly, Catra, we raised you better than that," Lyra said. "You can at least get your girlfriend *one* thing for her birthday."

They both blushed at the use of the word girlfriend. Adora quickly changed the subject to setting up her new phone, and Catra became much more interested in her cake.

"How'd you know?" Marlena asked curiously after the girls left. Lyra laughed.

"I didn't. I just figured it was the easiest way to find out."

"So obviously I was lying," Catra said as they walked into the bedroom. "About getting you a present, I mean. I just wanted to give it to you in private since it's kind of a private thing."

"You really didn't have to," Adora said. Catra shrugged, going to her bag and producing a small present.

"It's not much, really."

Adora was still excited to unwrap the gift. It was a horizontal photo frame with a drawing—a near perfect replica of the mural Adora had left behind in her own universe. "I know it was important to you,"

Catra said, rubbing the back of her head and looking anywhere but at Adora. "And you don't get to see it anymore. And I'm not really a graffiti artist—I've looked it up, and it's *hard* to learn. And it wouldn't be the same if I just drew another one a wall anyway, but I thought you should still, you know, have a way to see it, even if it's not the *real* thing."

It could have been a photograph, Adora marveled, carefully tracing the lines. She had gotten every single detail, right down to the cartoon face signature in the corner. "Thank you," she breathed after a moment. She hadn't realized until right then how much she missed being able to visit the mural. Or she had chosen not to think about it. And maybe she could never have it back, but it felt like she had a piece of it, at least.

"If you don't like it—"

"I *love* it," Adora said firmly, reaching a hand out to bring Catra around to face her. "It's perfect."

Catra relaxed, smiling just a little. "I know you gave up a lot just to stay here. I don't want you to regret it."

"I won't," Adora assured her. She was very, very sure of that. She felt good about her choice. As long as Catra wanted her here and didn't regret it, then everything would be okay.

Their first "I love you" wasn't anything special. Adora was spending the weekend on campus with Catra. Her dorm room wasn't exactly warm (even with the heater running), so they'd silently agreed to just stay in bed together, snuggled under the blankets. Catra was resting with her head pressed into Adora's shoulder, and Adora thought she was asleep until she heard the soft murmur.

"I love you."

t took her another minute to process it. "Oh," Adora finally said stupidly. Catra resisted the urge to roll her eyes.

"Better than *thank you*, I guess."

"I mean, of course I love you!" Adora said quickly, sitting up to look at Catra. She at least looked amused rather than offended or annoyed. "I guess I just wasn't expecting... I mean, I thought we were going slow."

Catra shrugged. "We are. But we both know how short life is. Maybe your Catra had the right idea – live fast and don't have regrets."

Adora softened slightly, a small smile pulling at her lips. "Just don't burn out too soon."

"Not a chance," Catra assured her, smirking. She sat up to kiss Adora, and was interrupted by a loud knock at the door.

"Catraaaaaaaaaa! I need a breakfast buddy and hangover food."

Catra groaned, pulling back to call, "I'm not going to the dining hall, Sparkles. It's too cold for that shit."

"But I need eggs!" Glimmer protested. They could just imagine the little pout on her face.

"Call Bow and ask for a delivery."

"He's spending the weekend with his dads. Pleeeeeeeeeeeeease? I already tried everyone else."

"Are they all hungover too?"

"Yeah."

"Honestly," Catra grumbled, reluctantly leaving the warm cocoon she and Adora had created. "*Fine*, give us ten minutes."

"Us? Oh — Adora's here! I completely forgot. I'm so sorry."

Catra opened the door to let Glimmer in. "It's fine, you can make it up to me later. I need a space heater."

"Uh, those aren't allowed in the dorms," Glimmer pointed out.

"Which is *why* I need someone to make it magically appear in my room without having to walk by the front desk."

Glimmer's tired eyes lit up with a little rebellious spark. "Oooooooh. Got it."

Adora had been absolutely right about Glimmer and Catra liking each other. They got on like a house on fire. Unfortunately, they enjoyed pouring more gas on the fire to encourage it. It was a dangerous combination sometimes.

"Bright Moon's kind of beautiful from up here, isn't it?"

Catra looked at Adora, then down at the city. They were perched on the highest rooftop they could find, legs dangling over the edge. They were *supposed* to be patrolling, but there wasn't much going on that particular night, so they could take a break.

"I used to do this a lot, after Catra." Adora's voice drifted off. Neither of them could ever bring themselves to say the word *died*. "It was good to remind myself why I didn't just quit everything."

"Is that a dig at me?" Catra asked, a bit teasingly. Adora squeaked, shaking her head.

"Of course not! I understand why you did what you did. I *needed* the reminder sometimes. I think you might have been a little healthier about it, really."

"I don't know if I'd call what I did *healthy*." Catra snorted. "But sure."

Neither of them had been at their best. They were getting better. Slowly. Together. Catra leaned over to nudge her shoulder against Adora's.

"Still no regrets?"

"None," Adora answered without hesitation. She knew she was never going to regret this. She reached out to intertwine their fingers; Catra gave her a small, almost shy smile.

The moment was, of course, interrupted by police sirens. Catra groaned. "People just love to ruin things, don't they?" she said as she stood, pulling her mask on.

"We'd be out of a job if they didn't," Adora pointed out as she followed suit.

"I don't think I'd mind losing this job," Catra grumbled. Adora rolled her eyes. She knew Catra liked to complain, but she'd be out there for as long as Adora was. They were in this together. An Adora for a Catra, a Catra for an Adora.

Just as it should be.

Chapter End Notes

Wow, I can't believe that's actually done. This has been such a fun project, and it really pushed my capabilities imo.

I know some people might agree with the choices I made, and that's okay, but I feel like I wrote things up enough to make this a realistic conclusion. And I know I'm happy with it.

Don't forget to drop a comment! I have no idea what my next project will be, but looking at past comments always makes me feel better and more motivated. And thanks for sticking with me through this <3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!